

Evaluation of Thousand Schools Program (Phase 1)

FINAL REPORT

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Executive Summary

Introduction

The Thousand Schools Program (TSP) is a joint collaborative effort of Tata Steel Foundation (TSF) and ASPIRE, which was launched in selected blocks of Odisha from 2015 onwards with the objective to create a replicable and scalable model of universalization of elementary education within the Right to Education framework. The program was later extended to two blocks of Jharkhand in phase 2. Till 2019, the programme covered 123 gram panchayats, two municipalities, 2239 habitations, 1129 government schools, 1,70,467 households, and an estimated 1,50,000 children in the age group of 6-14 years in the six Odisha blocks. Funded through the Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiative of the TSF, the ASPIRE, a non-profit organisation is the implementing partner.

The Evaluation

This report is based on an evaluation undertaken to understand and document the impact of the phase 1 of the program and to understand the changes brought on by the programme in the lives of children as well as to understand how the beneficiary communities have adopted schooling for all as a social norm. The evaluation attempted to answer a number of specific questions pertaining to relevance, effectiveness, impact and sustainability. While the evaluation was concerned with phase 1 of the programme only, in order to understand the replicability potential of the programme, the intervention in Noamundi block of Jharkhand was also included in the scope of the study.

Methods Used

Considering the nature of the programme, it was important to adopt an approach which allowed us to understand the impact of the programme on the whole ecology in the areas in which the programme was implemented. Also, given the comprehensive and vast scope of the evaluation as well as the importance of capturing diverse perspectives regarding the programme, a mixed method approach was adopted for the evaluation. The mixed method approach adopted comprised of quantitative, qualitative, and participatory methods so that we are able to arrive at conclusions about relevance, effectiveness and impact following an approach that is fast yet robust. The different components of the evaluation exercise were analysis of secondary data (programmatic as well as independent sources), analysis of primary data collected through household survey of 300 households, FGDs and KIIs, verification of records and participatory exercises such as panchayat / village mapping. Multiple methods used also helped in triangulation of the data collected, analysed and interpreted.

Findings

1. Universal Access

Universal access of children in the age group of six to fourteen years to elementary education was one of the primary objectives of the intervention. It is evident that the programme has been almost able to achieve this in the relevant age group. Hundred percent of children in the relevant age group in our sample were in school in two of the five selected blocks. In the other three, the drop out proportion was below 2 percent. The major initiatives which contributed to this achievement are the bridge courses at RBCs, direct enrolment, weekly headcount tracking, LEP classes and community mobilization initiatives. The programme has been designed in such a way as to envisage and address any needs of a child that is getting left behind. Adoption of such an all-encompassing approach and implementation on a large scale with significant amount of human resources at the ground level has ensured wide reach and effectiveness of the intervention.

2. Learning Enrichment

Analysis of the programmatic data, reading / comprehension and thinking activities conducted as part of the household surveys as well as group work activities conducted as part of FGDs show that there is an improvement and a shift in the way children are learning in the project intervention areas. It is also obvious that the TSP has contributed significantly to this positive shift. While the learning related interventions such as LEP, RBC/NRBC or summer camps have contributed towards this, the change has also occurred due to an overall focus on improving school functioning. However, individual and locational variations were also observed in the learning of children.

3. Lockdown learning

The lockdown learning program was formulated by TSP in response to the Covid-19 induced lockdown and closure of schools in order to curb the learning loss and to prevent losses of the impact of programmatic interventions gained during the past five / six years. We found that TSP's LLP acted as a bridge between the students and learning especially during the lockdown, as government teachers couldn't conduct physical classes and that TSP's application of a hybrid model i.e., clubbing the students who had access to technology with those who didn't, and combining it with physical visits can be seen as a potential solution to mitigate the learning loss which can happen as reliance on technology increases.

4. Governance: Strengthened local units

The TSP recognises improving school governance as a major component of strengthening public education and believes that community ownership of and engagement in education is crucial to strengthen the functioning of public education system. TSP mainly works with SMCs, PRIs, PTAs, CRPF and GRPFs, SHGs and youth groups to facilitate community ownership and engagement. We found that under the governance vertical, Their engagement with SMCs is most intense and in

general, the SMCs in these areas came across as far more inclusive and active, in comparison to what they had been in the past (as suggested by our survey, interviews and FGDs), and also as compared to how they usually function (as suggested by the literature). TSP has also created new community associations such as CRPFs and GRPFs who will hopefully remain engaged with the initiatives for eradication of child labour and child marriages. The program is also engaged with the PRIs. However, we found that there is a need to deepen the engagement with capacity building of SMCs and PRIs as well as in intensification of advocacy efforts.

5. Replicability

The key takeaway from the evaluation was that the TSP model successfully implemented in Odisha was largely able to be replicated in the same structure in Jharkhand too. The fundamental principles of large-scale intervention, community-centric practices and local hiring have helped in all three verticals of intervention that is access, learning and governance. One key factor promoting replicability is the anchoring of activities at the block level which facilitates the integration of local differences into the fold of the TSP/ESP intervention. The integration of the Munda Manki system in Noamundi is an example of programme flexibility and the ability to adapt.

Conclusions and Recommendations

The evaluation finds that the objectives of the program are valid and relevant and worth working towards. Some of the major findings that emerged from the exercise are:

- **Universal access:** The program has been able to show significant achievements in the timeframe of seven years through achieving ‘near universal’ access for elementary education in a highly difficult context. Some of the interventions which have contributed highly to this achievements are the bridge courses offered through RBCs/ NRBCs, continuous monitoring of childrens educational status through VERs and headcount tracking and extensive community engagement through SMCs.
- **Learning enrichment:** There is a significant positive shift in children’s engagement in learning supported by LEP classes conducted as part of the program. Children enjoy being engaged in the play based learning methods and also appreciate the support / attention given by LEP teachers.
- **Lockdown learning:** There is considerable acknowledgment from community members, parents, children and school teachers in the program area that the lockdown learning intervention conducted under TSP helped greatly in prevention of learning losses during the lockdown period. In presence of the considerable lack of access to digital devices, network and skills in the program area, considerable attrition in learning levels could have been anticipated. However, the lockdown learning program prevented this as well as facilitated children’s continued engagement in education and learning of life skills.

- Community ownership / engagement: In keeping with its objective of bringing about a positive change in the social norms prevalent around education, the program has managed to engage deeply with community associations such as SMCs, PRIs, SHGs and youth groups. It has played a major role in strengthening of SMCs in the area through capacity building efforts. It has helped create new community associations such as CRPF / GRPFs and it is also engaged with PRIs.

While noting these commendable achievements, the evaluation team also found that there is a need to deepen the engagement in many of these areas as the way forward for the program. Some of the potential ways in which the program could improve are:

- Deepening learning interventions: Through greater emphasis on comprehension and critical thinking, through reinforcement of shared understanding of framework and principles of LEP with the implementation staff
- Deepening the work with school-teachers and trainers on critical pedagogy
- Strategising for the institutionalization of certain key processes / mechanisms for attaining change
- Greater emphasis on knowledge building, dissemination and advocacy

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List of Abbreviations

AADR	Average Annual Dropout Rate
ABEO	Assistant Block Education Officer
ANM	Auxiliary Nurse and Midwife
ASER	Annual Status of Education Report
ASHA	Accredited Social Health Activist
AWC	Anganwadi Centre
BASS	Bal Adhikar Suraksha Samiti
BEO	Block Education Officer
BL	Baseline
BPL	Below Poverty Line
BRC	Block Resource Centre
CBPS	Centre for Budget and Policy Studies
CERC	Community Education Resource Center
CF	Cluster Facilitator
CLFZ	Child Labour Free Zone
CRC	Cluster Resource Centre (Cluster Resource Coordinator)
CRPC	Child Rights Protection Committee
CRPF	Child Rights Protection Forum
CSR	Corporate Social Responsibility
DEO	District Education Officer
DIET	District Institute of Education and Training
EL	Endline
ESP	Education Signature Programme
FGD	Focus Group Discussion
FLN	Foundational Learning and Numeracy
GER	Gross Enrolment Ratio
GP	Gram Panchayat
GPCM	Gram Panchayat Community Mobilizer
GRPF	Girls' Rights Protection Forum
HH	Household
HM	Head Master
JSL	Jindal Stainless Limited

KGBV	Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalaya
KII	Key Informant interview
KISS	Kalinga Institute of Social Science
LEP	Learning Enrichment Programme (Learning Enhancement Programme)
LF	Learning Facilitator
LLP	Lockdown Learning Programme
LLX	Lockdown Learning Expansion
MDM	Mid-day Meal
MGNREGS Scheme 77	Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee
ML	Midline
MVF	MV Foundation
NAS	National Achievement Survey
NER	Net Enrolment Ratios
NGO	Non-Government Organisation
NRBC	Non-Residential Bridge Course
OBC	Other Backward Castes
OoS	Out of School
PDC	Periphery Development Committee
PRI	Panchayati Raj Institution
PTA	Parent Teacher Association
PTR	Pupil Teacher Ratio
PVTG	Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups
RBC	Residential Bridge Course
RTE	Right to Education
SASS	Shishu Adhikar Suraksha Samiti
SC	Scheduled Caste
SDP	School Development Plan
SHG	Self Help Group
SMC	School Management Committee
ST	Scheduled Tribes
TLM	Teaching Learning Material
TSF	Tata Steel Foundation
TSP	Thousand Schools Project

UEE	Universal Elementary Education
VER	Village Education Register

Chapter 1: Introduction

The Thousand Schools Program (TSP) is a joint collaborative effort of Tata Steel Foundation (TSF) and ASPIRE, which was launched in selected blocks of Odisha from 2015 onwards with the objective to create a replicable and scalable model of universalization of elementary education within the Right to Education framework. The program was later extended to two blocks of Jharkhand in phase 2. Phase 1 of the programme is being implemented in six blocks of the three districts in Odisha; Sukinda and Danagadi in Jajpur district, Harichandanpur and Joda in Keonjhar and Koira and Kutra in Sundargarh. Till 2019, the programme covered 123 gram panchayats, two municipalities, 2239 habitations, 1129 government schools, 1,70,467 households, and an estimated 1,50,000 children in the age group of 6-14 years in the six Odisha blocks as per data shared in the RFP. Funded through the Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiative of the TSF, the ASPIRE, a non-profit organisation is the implementing partner.

1.1. Origin of the programme

The programme was conceptualized as an education related intervention to be implemented on a significant scale so as to be able to effect change at a noticeable level. Before the start of the Thousand Schools Program, ASPIRE was providing technical support to a similar intervention with around 80 schools in Nuapada district of Odisha being implemented by American Indian Foundation (AIF). At the same time, Tata Steel's CSR arm wanted to contribute to large scale programmes, which would bring changes to the communities in their project areas in different sectors including education, public health, tribal identity, livelihoods, agriculture, water and disability etc. According to one former senior TSF official who was instrumental in the project being funded, the selection of project areas was very deliberate as these were the areas which were affected due to TATA steel's presence in mining and manufacturing, and while these effects cannot be neutralized completely, they wanted to mitigate some of the effects through education and health related interventions. When representatives from Tata steel visited the education initiative of AIF in Nuapada district being supported by ASPIRE, they felt that such a programme could be implemented on a much larger scale in their project areas. This led to the programme (TSP) being conceptualized and funded. The origin of the programme is important to understand as it influenced the programme in key ways including in terms of its conceptualization and strategisation. The key features of the program as they were conceptualized were:

- Large scale
- Working within the Right to Education (RTE) framework to impact change in the public school system
- Holistic approach to ensure universal access to education

1.2. The context

Two of the three districts, Sundargarh and Keonjhar, have a high Scheduled Tribes (ST) population proportion of 50.75% and 45.45% respectively according to 2011

census. Jajpur district on the other hand has a ST population of 8.3% only but the percentage of Scheduled Caste (SC) population was higher at 23.7% as compared to the other two districts, Keonjhar (11.6%) and Sundergarh (9.2%).

Table 1.1: Population Percentage and Literacy Rates for Disadvantaged groups in Project districts, Odisha, 2011

Districts Indicators (%)	Jajpur	Keonjhar	Sundergarh	Odisha (state average)
Population ST	8.3	45.4	50.7	22.8
Population SC	23.7	11.6	9.2	17.1
Literacy Rates	80.13	68.24	73.34	72.87
Total Male literacy	86.84	78.12	81.01	81.59
Total Female literacy	73.29	58.28	65.48	64.01
ST Total literacy	47.60	53.24	65.08	52.24
ST Male literacy	59.68	65.22	73.98	63.70
ST Female literacy	35.48	41.56	56.39	41.20
SC Total literacy	70.30	73.77	70.92	69.02
SC Male literacy	79.29	83.81	79.75	79.21
SC Female literacy	61.02	63.76	62.03	58.76

Source: 2011 Census

Table 1.2: Schooling Participation rates, Project districts, Odisha, 2016

Districts Indicators	Jajpur	Keonjhar	Sundergarh	Odisha (state average)
GER Primary	89.14	95.97	95.36	92.47
GER Upper Primary	110.38	99.89	103.51	104.52
NER Primary	88.69	94.16	93.82	91.00
NER Upper Primary	82.00	83.94	88.14	83.36
PTR Primary	25.76	25.73	21.67	23.71
PTR Upper Primary	23.83	23.52	21.62	23.06
Average Annual Drop out (primary)	3.30	6.62	5.44	4.20
Average Annual Drop out (Upper primary)	3.60	5.43	5.69	5.15

Source: Unified DISE 2016-17 (as on 30th September, 2016)

In terms of literacy rates, these districts are neither far worse not much better when compared to the state averages. While the average literacy rates for Jajpur, Sundargarh and Keonjhar were 80.13%, 68.24% and 73.34% in 2011, as against the state average of 72.87%. The literacy rates among the disadvantaged sections within these districts follow similar patterns (table

1.1). This pattern remains the same if we take the figures for Gross Enrolment Ratios (GER), Net Enrolment Ratios (NER) or Average Annual Dropout Rates (AADR); the districts figures are somewhat close to the state averages (table 1.2) during the initial phase of the TSP implementation.

Table 1.3: Block-wise literacy rate of SC and ST population (%) in TSP project area, Odisha, 2011

District	Block	All			Scheduled Tribe				Scheduled Caste			
		Total literacy	Male literacy	Female literacy	Population	Literacy	Male literacy	Female literacy	Population	Literacy	Male literacy	Female literacy
Jajpur	Sukinda	67	76	57	37	46	59	33	11	69	79	58
	Danagadi	69	78	60	31	45	57	32	22	69	78	59
Keonjhar	Harichandanpur	62	73	51	56	52	64	40	7	70	81	60
	Joda	58	71	45	60	46	59	32	9	68	80	55
Sundargarh	Koira	57	69	46	70	50	62	39	6	63	77	50
	Kutra	69	77	61	77	68	76	60	7	64	73	54

Sources:

District Census Handbook, Kendujhar, 2011, Series 22, Part XII-A

<https://censusindia.gov.in/nada/index.php/catalog/948>

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District Statistical Handbook, Sundargarh, 2015

<http://www.desorissa.nic.in/pdf/Sundargarh-dshb-15.pdf>

This situation, however, changes if we disaggregate the data to blocks (table 1.3). The six blocks literacy rates, especially for the ST and SC population in these blocks are much lower than the district averages. This obviously means that these blocks present greater challenges in education as compared to the rest of the districts.

High tribal or SC population is associated with poor educational performance as these communities have been disadvantaged historically. ST children are found to lag further behind in education when compared with other deprived groups such as the SCs, despite the number of special educational provisions and incentives designed for them (Jha and Jhingran 2005; NCERT2006b). Scheduled Tribes constitute 9% of the total population, with literacy rates of merely 59% in 2011, which is much below India's total literacy rate of 74%. The reasons for poor educational

stats of tribal children are many. These can vary from cultural, geographical and economic isolation (Rashmi and Paul, 2022). These areas are generally marked by hilly terrains and high forest coverage with remote habitations, implying relatively lesser access to amenities and facilities. Population density is less thus schools are situated far away and children find it difficult to access the schools in such terrains. School infrastructure and facilities are also limited thus discouraging children from attending school. One study from the tribal district of Dang in the Gujarat state of India shows that common toilet facilities for girls and boys were the standard issue for preventing the tribal girls from re-enrolling after primary schooling beyond the 5th standard (Rami, 2012). In addition, there is lack of sufficient number of teachers in government schools contributing to the lack of interest in education as parents feel that children are not benefitting by attending school as quality of education is missing. In 2003, one study exploring multiple issues of primary education of tribal children of West Bengal concluded that poor infrastructure, shortage of schools and teachers, financial constraints in families, the rising market of private tuition had restricted the growth of tribal children (Ghosh, 2007).

Poverty in these areas is high and it also contributes to children not being able to attend regular schooling. Many children are engaged in income earning activities as well as in unpaid carework while both parents are engaged in income earning. A study from the Eastern Indian states of Jharkhand and West Bengal found that the dropout rates were high in tribal children due to economic hardship, especially during the cultivation period when the children helped their families with sowing and weeding plantation and harvesting activities (Ghosh, 2007). This prevents them from attending school regularly.

Language is another major challenge. While the medium of instruction in public schools in Odisha is mostly the state language of Odiya, many of the children from the tribal communities speak Ho and other local languages. They face difficulties in understanding and usage of Odiya as the medium of instruction. Lack of guidance from less educated parents and other elders at home contributes to their difficulties.

Considering the context and the challenges that arise due to this socio-economic context, TSP interventions were designed to facilitate universal access and learning of children from these communities through public education system.

1.3. The Programme

1.3.1. Programme objectives

The objective of the project, as mentioned earlier, was to create a replicable and scalable model of universalization of elementary education within the Right to Education framework. The belief behind this objective was that public schools are the only means to reach education to every last-mile child in the country (ASPIRE presentation, 2022).

The original programme objectives, as outlined by the TSP team and as understood by the evaluation team were:

1. To build community awareness and ownership towards the school, leading to transparency and better accountability and management of schools
2. To ensure 100% enrolment and 90% regularity of children in school in the 6-14 years age group and particularly those from the Schedule Tribes
3. Addressing learning deficits of primary grades children by creating a learning intervention, addressing diversified learning needs of children, both in-school and out-of-school, and across age levels (6-14 years), and also prepare them as independent and self-directed learners going forward
4. Sensitizing government teachers to adopt research based effective pedagogic practices and classroom organization
5. To create Community Education Resource Centers (CERC) to support teachers, School Management Committees (SMCs) and Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) as well as to extend learning support to children beyond primary grades and subsequently develop a variety of resources and learning materials for capacity building of different stakeholders
6. Work across entire blocks, and rejuvenate Cluster Resource Centre (CRCs), Block Resource Centre (BRCs) and District Institute of Education and Training (DIETs) as well as the PRI structures, towards improvement in school performance and management
7. Document and disseminate the experience to a wider audience
8. Network with relevant agencies/institutions to upscale and replicate the interventions in other geographies and states

1.3.2. Programme strategy

In order to address the challenges outlined in section 1.2, the programme adopted a holistic approach which intended to address all the causes which were keeping children away from school (Interview with programme senior management, March, 2023). Three critical areas of intervention were identified: i) Access - to ensure every child is in school and completes grade 8, ii) Learning – to address foundational learning deficit to enable age-appropriate learning, and iii) Governance – to ensure effective school governance and make ‘schooling for all’ a social norm. While these three were the critical areas of intervention, incidence of Covid-19 and imposition of lockdown in 2020 lead to school closures. To address the challenges arising out of school closures (Cessation of learning and enrolment in schools, regression in learning, and increase in child labour and child marriage), a lockdown learning program at a significantly large scale was implemented and forms the fourth vertical for the purpose of our evaluation.

In addition to focussing the programme on three critical areas of intervention, the programme strategy is built on five core principles. These are:

- **Area saturation model:** TSP aims to cover a complete administrative unit. This provides an opportunity to take advantage of all the administrative linkages in the block and work with all actors/institutions engaged with the school system
- **Large scale intervention:** Ensuring all children in a given geographic area are able to access the benefits of the intervention and attaining a scale which is relevant for the government and facilitates a significant impact.

- **Comprehensive approach:** A holistic approach is adopted which tries to mitigate all the challenges related to education including irregularity and drop outs, learning deficit, child marriage, child labour etc
- **Local hiring:** Local hiring often leads to the staff coming from the same community and helps in faster relationship building, understanding of local language and challenges. It also ensures that local capacities are built for the longer term and facilitates ownership of local communities in the program.
- **Community centric approach:** This is built on the belief that ultimately the community should take ownership of the education of their children as well as that every community has the capability to take ownership once there is trust in their abilities. Thus, a large component of the program involves engagement with stakeholders from the community including parents, SMC members, panchayats, Self Help Group (SHGs), youth groups, etc.

1.3.3. Interventions

While the interventions as part of the programme are multiple, we are focusing the discussion here on some of the key interventions. These are:

1. **Identification and tracking of out of school children:** The interventions started with identification of out of school children in these blocks. This started with conduct of a household census around 2014-15 when the programme started. Once all the Out of School (OoS) children were identified, there were follow ups to ensure that the children in these age groups were sent to school through various means. Data on these children are maintained at habitation / village level to ensure that the children continue going to school and are transitioning from primary to upper primary and then secondary levels. Village Education registers are maintained in order to monitor and facilitate continuation of children in schools. Headcount registers are maintained to monitor attendance in schools. Data on transition of every child in the village is also maintained.
2. **Bridge Courses to bridge the gap in learning of children not in school and facilitating them to get enrolled in formal mainstream schools:** Since many of these areas were educationally backward and socio-economically deprived, there were many children who had never enrolled or attended schools or had dropped out of the school at some particular stage. One of the major challenges in bringing these children back to school was that these children were not educationally or learning wise at the same level where they should be by their age. If simply enrolled in school at a lower level, they would face embarrassment and stop going to school again. However, if enrolled at a level appropriate to their age group, they would have difficulties in keeping up with the studies as their foundational skills in education were lacking. If they have difficulties in learning at school, they will lose interest in schools again and stop attending leading to further deprivation of education. In addition, there were many children in these villages who were orphaned and / or destitute who had no stability of livelihood. Strategy adopted by TSP to address these issues was to offer short term intensive bridge courses where the learning gaps were bridged.

These bridge courses were either residential or non-residential. Residential Bridge Course (RBC) centres were those where children stayed at hostels / residential facilities and participated in these bridge courses. For a child who has not attended school for a long time and is in need of more intensive supportive education, RBCs are chosen where they learn and catch up in a dedicated residential facility. Children who are younger and need supportive education to less extent are admitted in non-residential bridge course centres. In addition to these considerations, RBCs also host orphan / destitute children in the villages who need a shelter as well as a learning environment. RBCs play a very important role in improving access to education as children are provided bridging support which enables them to attend regular school through the process of mainstreaming after they complete the bridge course. In the context of these areas, too, the RBCs play a very important role as the proportion of destitute children is higher.

3. **Bringing Out of School children back to school through direct enrolment:** The bridge courses were meant for children who had been out of school for long or were older children who had never enrolled in schools. For younger children who did not have long gaps in schooling or were at the age when they were supposed to start schooling, the project simply concentrated on getting the children enrolled in school through direct enrolment. This was done through community mobilization and creating awareness amongst parents regarding the importance of education. TSP worked with the community organizations such as panchayat, school management committee, parent teacher associations and child right protection forums (CRPFs) to track out of school children present in the community. Panchayat level local staff of TSP (GPCM – Gram panchayat community mobilizer) played a big role in the conduct of these exercises and they worked along with SMCs, CRPFs to facilitate children being in school.
4. **Learning Enrichment Programme (LEP):** LEP is based on a student-centred pedagogy that facilitates learning in children present in the government schools where the 1000 schools programme intervenes. the programme tries to identify and address the basic learning gaps especially in language and mathematics for children, then moves on to other subjects like science and social studies, and gradually enables children to self-directed learning. While LEP classes are more readily associated with the learning component of the program, these also facilitate access in a major way. Since children are taught in a play based manner in these classes and get to clarify their doubts, their interest in education increases and their attendance in school improves.
5. **Lockdown Learning Programme (LLP):** During the years of incidence of Covid-19 and associated school closures, lockdown learning intervention of TSP played a major role in continued access to education. Children were taught through online and offline modes (by gathering small groups of children in open areas of the villages) by LEP teachers during the school closures and this was in most cases the sole means of continued education in these areas. **Ensuring regular attendance in schools:** Head counting of children is conducted once every week in the school and the parents of the children absent on that day are followed up

with to check the reason of their absence and address any issues if present. Similarly, once every week the staff visit the habitations on a normal school day to check if any school going age children are present in the habitation and not in school. Then they work with the parents to ensure that the children attend school regularly.

6. **Community engagement and strengthening of local institutions:** In keeping with the program strategy of making the community the centre of its interventions and to ensure that the community accepts the ownership of these initiatives, a key component of the program is engagement with different segments of the community. This includes strengthening of School Management Committees (SMCs), engagement with Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs), strengthening of Parent Teacher Associations (PTAs etc). Every school based intervention in the program starts only when there is a SMC resolution supporting the intervention. Similarly the government machinery is approached only through PRI representatives and SMC members. In addition, the program works with SHGs and youth groups in the area to generate and build awareness about the importance of education. The GPCM and cluster facilitators play a major role in this component of the intervention.
7. **Prevention of child marriages and child labour:** Child marriages and elopement were a common occurrence in these areas when the programme started and this was a major reason for children, especially girls, dropping out of schooling. Hence, prevention of child marriages was one of the major initiatives undertaken by TSP to improve access to schooling. Similarly, child labour was one of the major reasons working as a hindrance for regularity in schools. And prevention of child labour was one of the major initiatives taken up by TSP. Both of these were done through community mobilization predominantly. TSP worked closely with the community members, PRI representatives, SMC members, SHG and youth groups to prevent child marriage and child labour from happening. Once a habitation or panchayat is free from child labour, it is declared as a child labour free zone (CLFZ).¹

A perusal of relevant literature in India suggests that the programme had learnt from existing experiences and models; the influence of the MVF (MV Foundation²) approach is particularly evident in the ecological approach with focus on mainstreaming out of school children through bridging, working with public schools & existing institutions while also trying to address the issues of child labour and child marriage directly through public action.³ However, the learning related interventions were not part of the MVF approach and they have been added here, making the programme more comprehensive.

¹ Please refer to <https://aspire-india.org/focus-areas/governance/child-labour-free-zone-clfz/> for greater details.

² <https://mvfindia.in/>

³ <https://cbps.in/wp-content/uploads/MVF-report-final-8-May-2017.pdf>

1.4. The Evaluation

1.4.1 Objectives

The TSP recently, in 2022, completed phase 1 of its existence. This evaluation was commissioned to understand and document the main results and to understand the changes brought on by the programme in the lives of children as well as to understand how the beneficiary communities have adopted schooling for all as a social norm.

The major objectives of the evaluation were to:

1. To assess the impact of the phase 1 of the programme
2. To understand and document the changes brought on by the programme in lives of children
3. To understand and document the changes brought on by the programme in the communities they are working with regard to education
4. To understand and document the interactions of the programme with the public school education system
5. To understand and document the impact of the lockdown learning program

The evaluation attempted to answer a number of specific questions pertaining to relevance, effectiveness, impact and sustainability. Those questions are not being listed here for the sake of brevity, as they appear in the conclusions section in detail. It is important to mention this was a one-time evaluation with no direct reference available for either time (baseline against same parameters) or space (status and change in geographies other than project area) comparisons, and hence, the conclusions need to be interpreted with caution. Also, the focus of this evaluation has been on understanding the impact at the ground level, and therefore some of the larger macro-level issues have not been examined.

While the evaluation was concerned with phase 1 of the programme only, in order to understand the replicability potential of the programme, the intervention in Noamundi block of Jharkhand was also included in the scope of the study.

1.4.2 Evaluation approach

The evaluation approach was guided by our understanding of the key features of the programme. These were:

- (i) **Highly desirable yet challenging goals:** Universal elementary education -UEE, Right to Education -RTE compliance, Replicable and Scalable model
- (ii) **A comprehensive approach that includes strategies for Access, Learning and Governance including School Accountability:** this means adopting a 360 degree approach and working with diverse institutions which should make the model sustainable
- (iii) **Engages with several stakeholders of diverse nature** Children, parents, community, teachers, school system, panchayat members/ leaders, SMC

- (iv) **Wide coverage in a challenging area over a long period of time (about 7 years):** Implications of the context as well as the scale to be considered while finalising the evaluation design
- (v) **Quick response to the pandemic:** The programme has developed and implemented a learning response strategy in response to the pandemic enabled school closures.

Considering the nature of the programme, it was important to adopt an approach which allowed us to understand the impact of the programme on the whole ecology in the areas in which the programme was implemented. Also, given the comprehensive and vast scope of the evaluation as well as the importance of capturing diverse perspectives regarding the programme, a mixed method approach was adopted for the evaluation. The mixed method approach adopted comprised of quantitative, qualitative, and participatory methods so that we are able to arrive at conclusions about relevance, effectiveness and impact following an approach that is fast yet robust. The mixed method approach is chosen carefully to suit the diverse set of objectives that call for different methodologies.

1.4.3. The Methods

As mentioned above, the methodology comprised of quantitative, qualitative as well as participatory methods. The methods chosen were also guided by the limited time available for the evaluation. The different components of the evaluation exercise were:

- **Analysis of secondary data:** Since TSP is rich in internal documentation, we analysed some relevant documents in detail to: (i) understand the programme, (ii) finalise the approach, and (iii) identify the data points that can be used as pre-existing raw data. We analysed the program data available with TSP to understand the changes that happened during this period (2015 to 2022). As the evaluation was a onetime exercise, pre-post comparisons were not possible. However, we used some parameters from the household survey conducted by TSP in 2015 to understand changes that happened during this time. Similarly, we used program data available to understand the scale of activities and how those have changed over time.
- **Analysis of primary data:** Both quantitative and qualitative primary data were collected through a sample household survey, Focus Group Discussions (FGDs) and Key Informant interviews (KIIs).
 - i. The household survey was conducted for 300 households and collected data on the socio-economic characteristics, parent experiences with and feedback on TSP interventions as well as their attitude towards children's education. In addition, the household survey also collected data to assess the learning levels of children for a cohort of 300 children. Collecting data on learning levels as part of the household (HH) survey allowed us to analyse the findings in context of the socio-economic characteristics of the household.
 - ii. Focus group discussions were conducted with four groups of stakeholders at every panchayat. These were parents, School management committee members, school teachers and children. The FGD for children also had an activity-based

component where we tried to assess the learning levels and other skills such as interaction skills, collaborative and team work skills, application of concepts learnt etc.

- iii. Key Informant Interviews were conducted with diverse stakeholders including PRI representative, Cluster Resource Coordinator (CRCs)/ Block Education Officer (BEOs), ASPIRE personnel, TSF personnel etc.

In addition, in order to understand the village dynamics in terms of institutional and household locations, we conducted a village mapping exercise. A verification exercise of records in the identified villages was undertaken to assess the consistency between TSP reporting and village level records. This included village registers, SMC meetings minutes and school data.

Table1.4: Methodology and Approach

	Method	Scope	Purpose
1	Preliminary review of programme documents and data	All programme documents, internal reports, training modules	This helped in initial understanding the programme and its approach, coverage, locations, etc. These were also used to formulate tools and guidelines for the survey, KIIs and FGDs.
2	Preliminary two-day workshop/meeting with the Aspire and TSF Teams	Was conducted at the TATA Steel office in order to arrive at a mutual understanding of the programme and expectations from the evaluation	This workshop was used to (i) gain an in-depth understanding of the programme, (ii) collect supporting documents for all the achievements, (iii) to formulate and understand the expectations from the evaluation and (iii) to mutually chalk out a field plan
3	Focus Group Discussions (FGD)	(i) SMC members (ii) Teachers (iii) Parents (iv) Children	Separate FGDs were conducted with each of these groups using specific guidelines. These guidelines were developed taking the respective roles / training / inputs / achievements into account. The main focus here was on understanding their experiences with the programme and examining the aspect of capacity building of respective stakeholders. The children FGD also had element of gauging their learning understood through group work.
4.	Village/GP mapping	Through open meeting with villagers	A village/GP map was drawn at each of the location to understand the dynamics/location and to aid to the analyses later.
4	Record/ document verification	Village Education Registers (VER)	These were undertaken with the purpose of (i) verifying the presence of the VER, (ii) verifying the data from the VER on a random basis

	Method	Scope	Purpose
5	Household Survey	Survey of selected number of households	to undertake a quantitative analysis of experience, reach and impact of the programme to add to the analyses emerging from the qualitative work
6	Key Informant Interviews (KIIs)	School/Department of Education /Panchayat officials and ASPIRE and TSF personnel	The focus for the KIIs with educational department officials was on examining the synergy with the existing institutions and probe the aspect of sustainability. The focus for KIIs with ASPIRE and TSF personnel was to understand their expectations and understanding of the program, their experiences while being associated with the program, their opinions about the relevance and effectiveness of the program and the challenges associated with implementation of the program.
7	Validation Workshop	With ASPIRE/TSF team and other selected stakeholders	This is to validate the findings and also disseminate what is emerging from the analyses

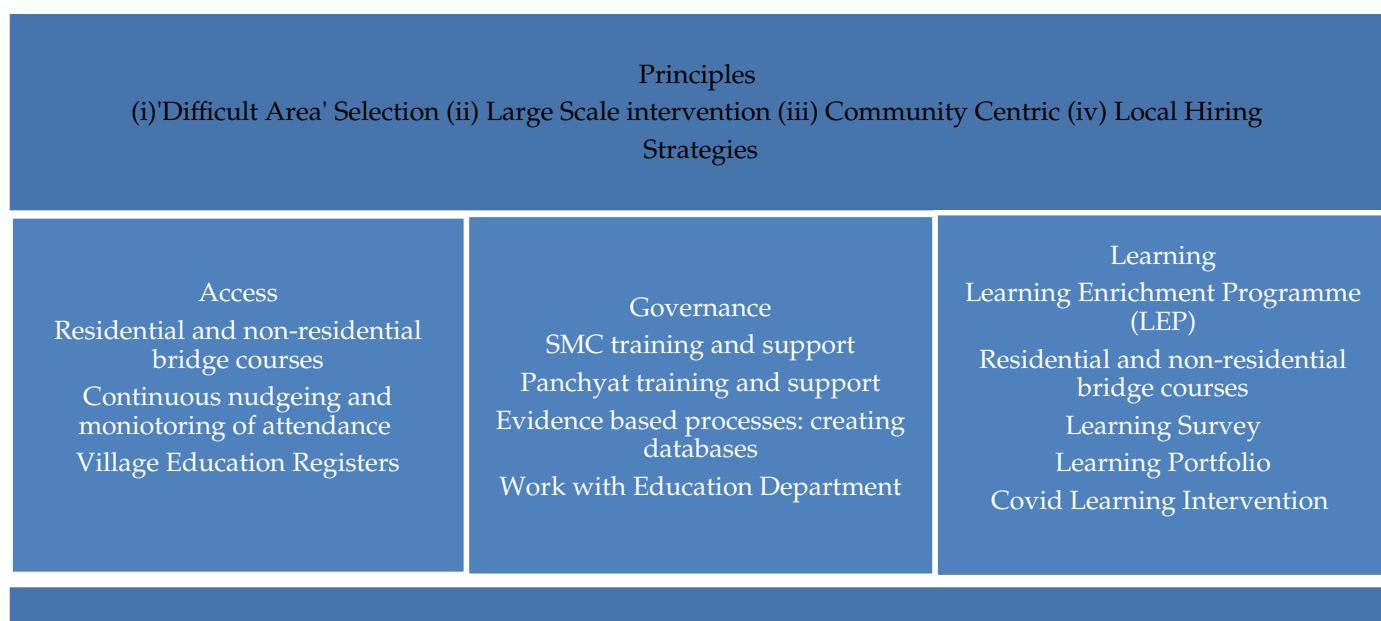
1.4.4 Framework of Analysis

The analytical framework derives from the objective of assessing the movement towards the goals of improving access, governance and learning for school-age children in the project area through the adopted strategies while following the basic principles that the organisation had decided to follow (Figure 1.1). This implies that we examined the achievement of or movement towards stated goals of the intervention through the functioning and impact of strategies and in that process also looked at the adherence to the stated principles, wherever relevant (Figure 1.2).

Figure 1. 1: Analytical Framework



Figure 1. 2: Interventions Framework for Evaluation



Source: Conceptualised by the Evalution Team

The various methods used to collect data have been outlined earlier in the report. While following the framework for analysis described above, we used the data collected from various sources to triangulate our findings. The data collected from the primary household survey and secondary data from the programme constituted the bulk of our quantitative data. These were analysed to assess the changes and understand the connections between socio-economic characteristics and access to education. These findings were supplemented with feedback from children, parents, SMC members and school teachers through FGD/KIIs and feedback from government officials and ASPIRE/ TSF personnel through KIIs. While supplementing the findings from quantitative survey with a richer understanding of the nuances of context and challenges, these also serve as sources of triangulation.

Figure 1. 3: Methods and Triangulation of quantitative and qualitative data

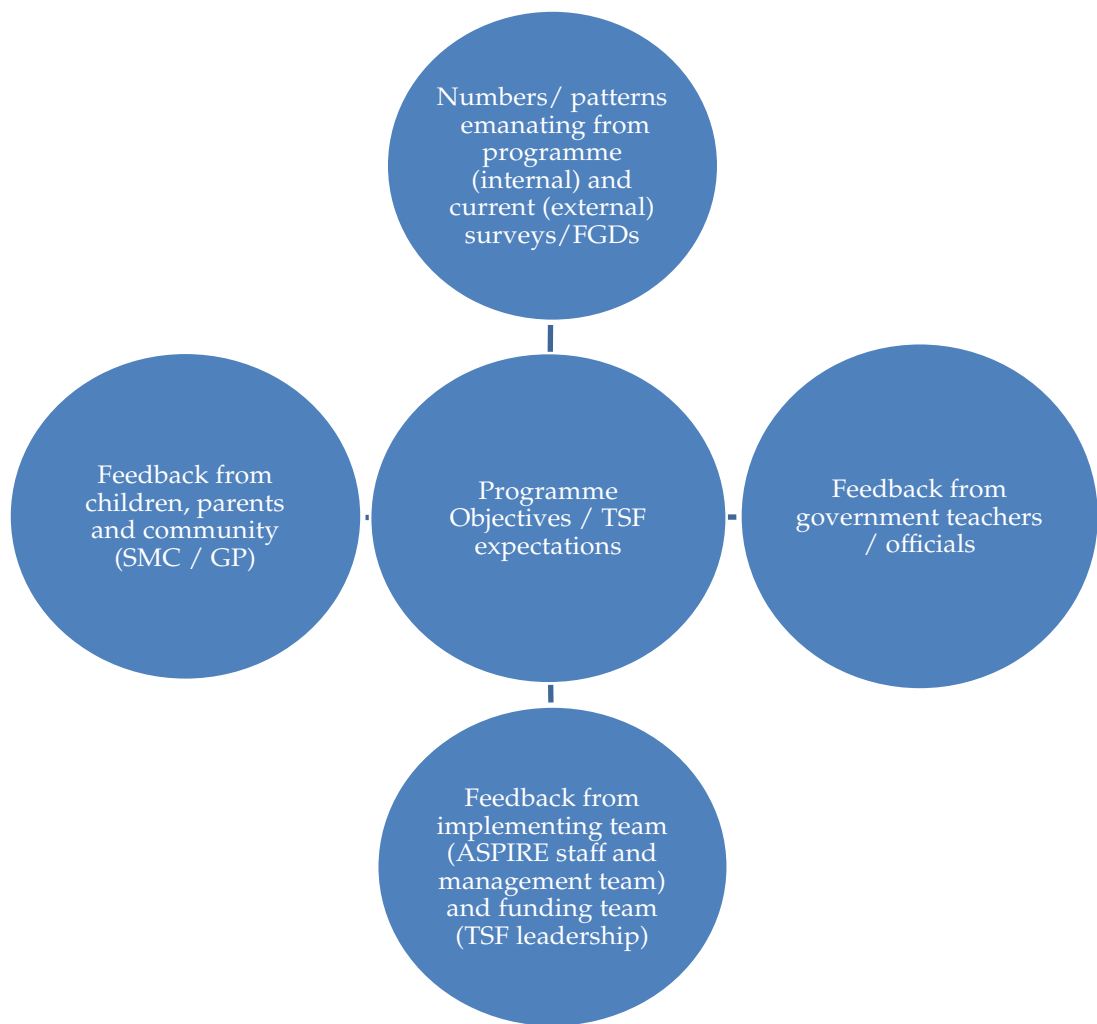
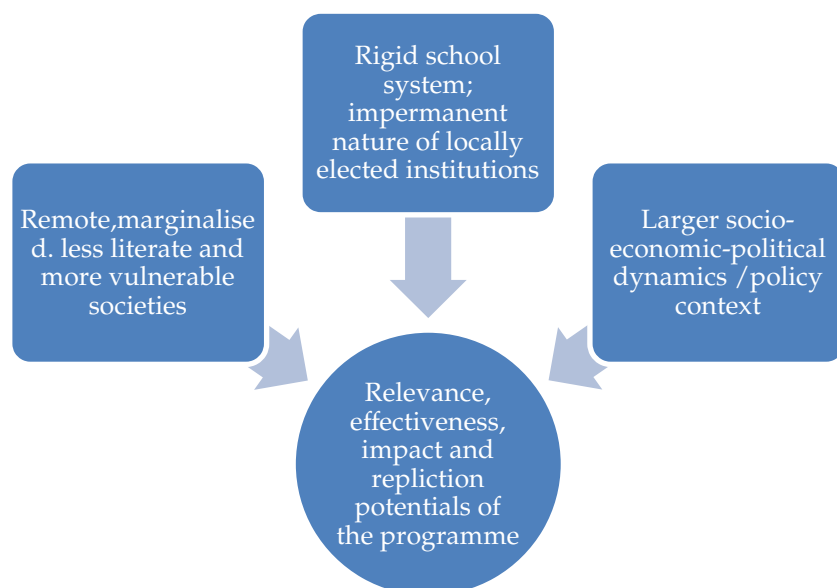


Figure 1. 4: Connecting the dots and inferences taking the micro and macro contexts into account



While the framework for data collection and triangulation is depicted in figure 1.3, the analysis was carried out in the context of the specific areas and communities as well as the macro-environment and policy discourse (Figure 1.4).

1.4.5 The Sample

As mentioned earlier, we followed an ecological approach where we covered all stakeholders within an identified site to get a complete picture of that site. Our sample constituted of two panchayats in each of the six blocks across three districts in Odisha and one district of Jharkhand.

The selected six blocks were Koira, Joda, Harichandanpur, Sukinda and Danagadi in Odisha and Noamundi in Jharkhand. Within each of the selected blocks (based on the programme's presence), two panchayats were chosen. An effort was made to represent diverse demographic characteristics while selecting the panchayats. The panchayats were selected based on three factors: i) size of the panchayat and population of children in the panchayat to ensure availability of households ii) literacy rates (from census 2011) to ensure that we capture the experiences of the most disadvantaged segments of the community in the block, and iii) presence of RBC in the panchayat. Since RBCs are an important initiative as part of the intervention, we tried to ensure that at least some of the panchayats that are part of the sample have the presence of an existing RBC centre so that the RBC related interventions could be understood well. We were able to visit five RBCs across Odisha and Jharkhand.

Table 1.5: Evaluation tools and their application

Evaluation tool	Particulars	Final Numbers	Proposed Numbers
Focus Group Discussions	Children (School and RBC), Parents, Teachers (School and RBC), SMC members	56	60
Key Informant Interviews (KIIs)	TSF/ASPIRE senior management, PRI representative, LEP teacher, LF, GPCM, CF, BEO/CRC, LEP coordinator, block coordinator, Child Rights Protection Forum (CRPF) member	88 [84 from field + 4 from TSF/ASPIRE senior management]	12
Profiles	School, RBC	17	12
Social maps	village	12	12
Household survey	Sample	300	300
Data verification	Sample	36	36

Within each panchayat, we conducted 4 FGDs (one each of the SMC members, parents, school teachers and children), data verification and process verification exercises. In addition, we conducted KIIs of TSP staff (LEP teacher, GPCM, Learning Facilitators (LFs), Cluster Facilitators (CFs) and panchayat representatives (sarpanch / ex-sarpanch, member). In addition to the KIIs at the panchayat level, we

also conducted interviews of government education department officials (Cluster Resource Coordinators (CRCs) / Block Education Officers (BEOs), TSP personnel at the block and state levels (Block coordinator, LEP coordinator, State in-charge, resource coordinator, etc.) and of senior leadership of the programme. We also conducted FGDs/ KIIs with teachers in RBCs and children staying in RBCs. Table 1.5 provides the details of these numbers as against what was agreed upon at the time of the contract.

In addition to this, we also conducted survey of 300 households. For our household survey of 300 households, 25 households were selected from each panchayat. The sample was chosen carefully to represent both households which had direct exposure to any education related intervention including LEP, RBC/NRBC, lockdown learning and summer camp (referred to as TSP households) and those who did not have direct exposure to these programmes (non-TSP households). While the intervention focused on the entire area and hence the entire population was covered by the programme, all households did not necessarily have any child who directly experienced any TSP learning related intervention, and hence for the limited purpose of comparisons, they have been referred to as TSP or non-TSP households.

The demographic characteristics of households in our sample are outlined in table 1.6. The sample characteristics show that it is fairly representative of the population in the selected blocks (see table 1.3)

Table1.6: Sample household characteristics (Numbers; percentages in parentheses)

Religion	Hindu	Christian	Sarna	Total
	285 (95)	9 (3)	6 (2)	300 (100)
Caste	SC	ST	OBC	
	73 (24.33)	164 (54.66)	62 (20.67)	299 (100)
Status	APL	BPL	Others	
	22 (7.33)	271 (90.33)	7 (2.33)	300 (100)
Type of house	Kutcha	Semi-pucca	Pucca	
	194 (64.67)	50 (16.67)	56 (18.67)	300 (100)

Source: CBPS Household Survey

1.4.6 Caveats and Challenges

The biggest challenge that we faced was that of time. The entire evaluation, which included developing an understanding of the programme, review of texts and data, analysis of programme data, development, and translation of tools in two languages (Oriya and Hindi), training of the field team, conducting fieldwork, data processing, cleaning and analysis (both quantitative and qualitative), triangulation and writing, was completed in a period of five months. We tried to overcome this by deploying a large team of senior researchers but that has had cost implications for CBPS.

The next major challenge faced is that of attribution as this is a one-time exercise without a comparator. While we tried to overcome the issue of time (absence of a similar study before the programme intervention) by using a number of change questions as well as using programme data, the issues related to recall remain there.

The absence of a comparator in terms of geography (comparison with another non-project block) is also a limitation. However, we have focused on examining the present status against stated objectives and principles of the programme and the validity of that is not questionable.

In the light of these challenges, our approach has been to go deeper and understand the functioning, processes, and impact of the ecological approach in a manner that it helps the programme further in its future planning rather than establish the causality. Nevertheless, the causality is also explored and analysed, though not in a very strict and linear sense. Triangulation of data from diverse sources, for instance, helps in establishing causality if the feedback coming from diverse sources reinforce each other, and that has been used effectively in this report.

1.5. The Report

The report is divided into seven chapters: introduction, access, learning, lockdown learning, governance, the replicability potential, and conclusions. While the individual chapters analyse specific objectives and interventions, the conclusions bring together those and answer specific questions on relevance, effectiveness, and impact. The conclusions also highlight the remaining challenges and way forward in the light of the observations and analyses. We have also developed four narratives of specific interventions from four different blocks highlighting a particular intervention and related observations there. A few annexures have been added to provide details wherever necessary.

All the names have been either changed or used in anonymised form to protect the identity of the respondents.

Chapter 2: Universal Access: Almost there

2.1. Context and challenges

The context of remote habitations in hilly terrains and higher percentage of tribal population with high proportion of illiteracy has been mentioned earlier in the report. The challenges arising due to the context were also mentioned in the introduction sections. Hence, these are not being detailed here. To summarise the discussion, the key challenges especially from the perspective of access to schools are:

- **Geographical:** The remoteness of the terrain poses as one of the most challenging aspects of access. Many of the habitations in these areas are extremely small with sparse population. Children have to walk in such terrains for long distances. While physical access to public schools is relatively better, the problems of access increases at post-primary stages. Additionally, the area is marked by high forest coverage as well as mining activities and thus parents deem it unsafe for children to walk long distances due to threat from mining trucks and animals such as elephants.
- **Social:** Most of these areas are inhabited by tribal populations of mixed tribes, including Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTG). The areas in which the PVTGs reside are even more remote and difficult to access. Many of the children in these communities now are the first-generation learners. Thus, they are facing the challenges of lack of familiarity with formal mainstream education as well as lack of support / guidance from parents. Parents lack of awareness about importance of education and thus high rate of drop outs from schools was a major challenge TSP had to deal with in the initial days of the intervention.
- **Economic:** Poverty also contributes to children not being able to attend regular schooling. Majority of the population in these areas are marginalised and are mostly engaged in daily wage labour. Many children are engaged in income earning activities. Even if they themselves are not engaged in income earning, they support parents through unpaid carework at home while both parents go out to work. This prevents them from attending school regularly. There is also a high rate of destitution among children. The proportion of children who are orphans or are abandoned is higher in some of these areas as alcoholism takes its toll on the community (discussion with ASPIRE team, Nov – Dec 2022 and KII with PRI members Dec, 2022 and Jan, 2023). Lacking stability in their lives, such children are excluded from access to education.
- **Language:** Language is another major challenge. While the medium of instruction in public schools in Odisha is mostly the state language of Odiya, many of the children from the tribal communities speak Ho and other local languages. They face difficulties in understanding and usage of Odiya as the medium of instruction. Lack of guidance from less educated parents and other elders at home contributes to their difficulties. This challenge is exacerbated by lack of adivasi teachers or teachers who are familiar with the language in public schools. The difference in language among children and teachers leads to communication gap between teacher and students, children are not able to

understand the subject matter being taught, are unable to get their doubts cleared due to lack of communication, eventually lose interest and drop out. While there have been some efforts by the government in recent years in form of provision of teachers who teach the mothertongue, this is still being taught as a single subject and in select schools. Since the medium of instruction continues to be Odiya and as majority of teachers are odiya speaking, language forms a key barrier to both access and learning.

- **Lack of government school infrastructure:** Public schools in the area lack infrastructural facilities such as sufficient number of class rooms, functional toilets, drinking water facilities. Although the Teacher parent ratio is usually within the RTE norm of 1:30 in most schools, this does not translate itself into one teacher per classroom due to the low population in these villages. As a result, most of these schools have multi-grade classrooms. It is noteworthy that the most frequent challenge regarding the status of education in their communities mentioned was lack of sufficient number of teachers, even though the pupil to teacher ratio was in accordance with the norms (FGD with parents, FGD with SMC members, KII with PRI members during Dec, 2022 – Jan, 2023). Additionally, many parents mentioned that once their children complete primary, it becomes difficult for them to attend high school and college as they have to travel long distances in order to be able to do so.

2.2. Impact on access: reduction in and prevention of drop outs

The objective of TSP was to universalize elementary education by ensuring that every child in the six to fourteen age group was in school in the six blocks in which the intervention was underway. Later on, the programme scope was broadened to include pre-school education and the age range was extended to 3 to 16 years. However, for the purpose of this evaluation, our focus is on the six to fourteen age group.

The TSP adopted a 100 percent saturation approach where the objective was to reach every child in these blocks and prevent any drop outs in the relevant age group. In order to achieve this, they adopted a 360degree approach in which they aimed to touch every facet of a child's life to ensure that the child continues to go to school.

Although the objectives of the programme had three major pillars of access, learning and governance, the interventions need to be viewed as being interlinked and creating an impact together on these dimensions. The major interventions under TSP have been outlined earlier in chapter 1 of the report. Here, we examine the impact of the programme on certain access related parameters.

Since the evaluation exercise was a one-time activity, it was difficult to assess the change per se, we had access to the household census conducted at the start of programme implementation. We compared the drop out proportions of selected blocks in the household census to the drop out proportions in the sample survey of 250 households conducted by us. The comparison is presented below in table 2.1. Although not strictly comparable, as one is based on the census of all households and

the other is based on a sample, this can be taken as indicative of the direction of the change.

Table 2.7: Reduction in percentages of dropout children

Block	2016*	2023 (6-14)**	2023 (6-18)**
	Percentage of dropout children	Percentage of dropout children	Percentage of dropout children
Joda	5.28	0 (0)	1.80 (2)
Harichandanpur	7.97	0.95 (1)	3.81(4)
Koira	9.84	1.63 (2)	2.44 (3)
Sukinda	3.53	0.87 (1)	2.63 (3)
Danagadi	3.63	0 (0)	3.36 (4)

Source: * from Household Survey data of ASPIRE;

** proportion calculated from sample of 250 households across five blocks from the CBPS household survey; numbers of drop out children in parenthesis

As we can see, there is significant reduction in the proportion of drop out children in the six to fourteen age group across the five blocks studied in Odisha. In two of these blocks, there were no dropout child while in two others, the proportion of dropout children was less than one percent in the sample HH Survey, 2023. This demonstrates that the programme has been quite effective in ensuring that all children of the relevant age group continue in school.

While the programme objective was only to prevent drop outs in the six to fourteen age group, we also checked the drop put proportions in the six to eighteen age group in our sample. This was done due to two reasons. First, the programme has been operational in the area since 2015 and many children who have been part of the intervention in the initial years would now have crossed the age of fourteen. We wanted to see if they would continue education even after completing primary education. Second, the programme aims to change the community mindset about the importance of education so that the community takes ownership. We wanted to see if children continued post-primary education in spite of challenges such as parents' lack of income and remote access to institutes of secondary and higher education. As we can see from the table, in all the blocks, there has been reduction in drop out proportion even in the expanded age group (as compared to a smaller age group at the baseline, hence this reduction is significant). While the reduction is not as much as in the smaller age range, this still points to a significant change.

The reduction in incidence of drop outs was also confirmed in findings from qualitative data. We conducted FGDs with parents, SMC members and school teachers in 10 panchayats and KIIs with Panchayat representatives and government education department officials. Almost everyone confirmed that there has been a significant reduction in drop outs and increase in children attending schools post TSP intervention. When asked to mention three important changes in children post TSP intervention, the most frequently mentioned changes were that children are now attending school regularly and that their interest in education has improved. They also mentioned that children now do not loiter in common areas and are engaged in studies both during and beyond the school hours. We next explore certain

intermediate indicators that seemed to have determined the pathway to change towards universal access

Box 1: Socio-economic and occupation profile of the dropout children

While the number of dropouts was very small, we tried to understand the socio-economic profile of drop out children in our sample. Table 2.2 shows that all dropout children belonged to Below Poverty Line (BPL) families. We also collected data on the occupational profile of children and found that all four dropout children in the 6-14 age group belonged to the ST communities and were working as daily wage earners. Among the additional 12 dropout children in the 14-18 age-group, five were engaged in domestic unpaid work while one was in paid wage-work. The remaining seven did not report being engaged in any form of labour as their primary engagement.

Socio-economic profile of dropout children

Age group	No. and proportion in sample	Religion	Caste	Ration card type
6-14	4	Hindu	ST	BPL
6-18	16	Hindu	ST (8), SC (7), OBC (1)	BPL

Source: Household survey conducted by CBPS during Dec, 2022 to Jan, 2023

Note: 16 children in 6-18year old age-group are inclusive of the 4 children in 6-4 age group.

2.3. Towards near universal access: examining intermediate indicators

Our explorations into the question of how this change was realised led us to four intermediate indicators of change that could have jointly led to this movement towards near universal access: (i) addressing the issue of 'low interest' in studies and consequent low aspirations, (ii) changing the functioning of schools to make it a more 'reliable' institution, (iii) addressing the issue of child labour and child marriage, and (iv) bridging the accumulated learning gap for age-appropriate school entry through a caring, flexible and responsive approach.

2.3.1. Impact on access through change in children's interest in education and aspirations

One of the key reasons for children dropping out of school is their facing difficulties in learning because of various reasons including lack of quality teaching and use of rote learning techniques in schools. Because of these factors, children are unable to understand and learn and thus develop a lack of interest in education, which emerges as a major reason for discontinuation from schooling.⁴ We tried to understand whether the programme has had an impact on the children's interest in education and their parents' aspirations for them. It is to be noted that these are

⁴ For instance, see NSS 71st Education Round, 2014

parents' responses about their perceptions as to the children's interest in education and attendance in school. While 96% (240 out of 250) of parents reported that their children enjoy studies and nearly 98% (244 out of 250) claimed that their children attended school regularly post-TSP intervention, 79% (197 out of 250) also reported that their aspirations for their children were now higher than before.

Although the programme has an ecological approach and hence every household is touched, we tried to see the difference between the households where at least one child has been part of at least one educational intervention of the programme (LEP, RBC, NRBC, Summer camp and lockdown learning) (referred to as TSP households; n=152) and households where none of the children have had a direct exposure to these educational interventions (referred to as non-TSP households; n=98), and found that the small numbers not reporting any positive shift largely or entirely came from the non-TSP households. This difference was marked in case of their response to aspirations.

Regarding the change in aspirations for their children's future, 81% of the TSP households mentioned that their aspirations have changed for the better since the intervention has taken place. The proportion which mentioned this for non-TSP households was 75%. While some mentioned that there have been negative changes or no change in their aspiration, almost 17% TSP households and 11% non-TSP households mentioned that they do not know whether their aspirations have changed post-intervention.

These findings are also corroborated from our interactions with parents and school teachers who mentioned children's increased interest in education as one of the key changes post the intervention (FGD with parents and FGD with school teachers, Dec 2022- Jan, 2023). Many of the LEP classes also provide exposure to music, dance and painting in addition to studies. This helps create interest in education as most of these activities are integrated with the learning components. Many parents spoke fondly of their children wanting not to miss school unlike earlier because they feel as if they would be missing out on fun and learning (FGD with parents, Dec 2022- Jan, 2023).

We also conducted FGDs with children at schools. In these FGDs, children themselves also spoke about how they are now interested in studying because their doubts are cleared in LEP classes and because they get to learn while playing games and through activities. We conducted these FGDs with children from 4 to 5 and 6 to 8 grades and most of the children were able to mention their own aspirations for the future.

This change in the child's interest in attending school and in education appeared to be linked to the LEP intervention, especially the implementation of play-based teaching methods in LEP classes. The LEP classes are typically conducted within the school premises with a few exceptions where the school authorities did not permit TSP to conduct classes within the school premises. In such cases, the LEP classes are conducted in places such as community centres and club houses within the villages. However, since in majority of cases, LEP classes are conducted within the school premises, this acts as an incentive and encourages children to attend school as they

also get to clarify their doubts in the LEP classes. Thus, effective access to education improves.

2.3.3. Impact on access through school functioning

The very remoteness of these habitations where schools sometimes do not open on time or face the problem of irregular attendance of teachers who come from other areas makes school functioning an issue. This leads to a perception of lack of usefulness of sending children to school as they are not going to learn anything and leads to poor attendance in schools (interview with ASPIRE personnel, Nov, 2022). The TSP works in conjunction with the government school system as the ultimate objective of the programme is to ensure sustainability of the initiative through adoption of some of its practices by the public education system. We tried to understand parents' perceptions of the functioning of government schools in the area. The findings are presented in table 2.2. Almost all indicators suggest that a large proportion of parents feel that post intervention, schools open on time and teachers attend the schools regularly.

Table 2.8: Parents perception of school functioning

Questions	Responses				Total
Does the School open on time	Yes- always	Yes- Mostly	No-never	Don't know	Total
	249 (99.6%)	1			250
Do teachers come regularly	Yes- always	yes- mostly	no	don't know	Total
	238 (95.2%)	4	1	7	250
Do more children continue going to school?	Yes	No	No change	Don't know	total
	241 (96.1%)	5	3	1	250

Source: CBPS household survey

Note: Figures in parenthesis are row percentages.

In our FGDs with parents and SMC members, they also mentioned that the schools do open regularly and teachers also are present regularly. SMC members sometimes mentioned that they ensure that teachers are coming, school is opening and mid-day meals are being served on time through regular checks. On our field visits to these areas, except in a couple of cases, we saw that the schools were open on time and teachers were in attendance, though not all of the teachers did not necessarily come in time. However, the SMC engagement with school was strongly visible and this is being discussed later in detail in the chapter on governance.

2.3.4. Impact on access through child marriage and child labour prevention

According to the programme documents, child marriage and child labour were two major challenges that were causing children to drop out of school. As per anecdotal evidence collected from ASPIRE and TSF officials, during the initial years of the programme implementation, there was high incidence of child marriages and elopement in many of these communities. Children were also often employed in

wage earning activities or unpaid carework at home and thus were unable to attend school. Working in mines in the nearby areas, cow / goat herding and carework were reportedly major occupations of children in these areas.

The programme tried to address these challenges through community mobilization and generating awareness about these issues in the community. They worked in close collaboration with the elected panchayats, SMCs, Parent teacher associations, SHGs and youth groups and sometimes with the district and block administration to stop child marriages and child labour. In our sample of 489 children (6-14 years) in the 250 households, only five children (almost one percent) were engaged in child labour (including four in daily wage labour and one in unpaid care work). These five children ranged from 7 to 14 in age. Similarly, the number of children who were married was only one, who was married at the age of nine. This is definitely indicative of the incidence of child labour and child marriage currently being low in these areas.

In most of our interactions with the community members, they mentioned that the incidence of child labour and child marriage is now very low if not absent. Parents in a particular panchayat also mentioned that they work closely with the GPCM to stop incidence of child labour. Many of the PRI representatives we spoke to acknowledged the role of and effort by TSP to stop child marriage and child labour. However, many communities also mentioned that this has happened over time and not just because of the programme. This change was attributed to many reasons including establishment of Anganwadi Centres (AWCs) and schools, presence of Accredited Social Health Activist (ASHAs), availability of more documentation of age and identity proof such as Aadhaar card, etc. (FGDs with parents, Dec, 2022 – Jan, 2023). They also mentioned that while the incidence has gone down, these practices are still prevalent in certain communities.

We also enquired about parents' perceptions about the change in child marriage and child labour post TSP intervention in our household survey. An overwhelming 94% of households felt that there has been a positive change in child marriage trends post the intervention while 96.4% felt the same for changes in child labour (table 2.3).

Table 2.9: Perceived changes in child labour and child marriage

Questions	Responses				Total
Changes in child marriage	Yes-positive change	Yes-negative change	No change	Don't know	Total
	234	1	2	13	250
Changes in child labour	Yes-positive change	Yes-negative change	No change	Don't know	Total
	241		1	8	250

Source: CBPS household survey

Thus, it is evident that while there has been a significant change in both child marriage and child labour trends, it is yet to be completely eradicated. It is understandable considering the dynamics of the community and area, and the long

time required to achieve social changes of this kind. It is also important to remember that this survey has been carried out soon after the pandemic which is known to have caused hardships to families already living in poverty. For child labour, sustaining the change is also very challenging as families migrate in and out of the areas.

2.3.5. Impact on access through RBCs and continuous tracking

RBC centres are established for underprivileged children who are either never enrolled or school drop outs with the main intention of mainstreaming them. The courses offered at these centres are usually of six months to one-year duration where children are taught intensively to bridge their learning gap.

In addition, children are also taught to live a disciplined life with time earmarked for activities including studying and extra-curricular activities. They are also taught the importance of hygiene, personal care and social interaction skills. These residential camps act as alternative homes where children usually experience a different life, make friends and learn new skills.

The objective of these centres is to get children enrolled in mainstream schools where they continue to study. These schools can either be residential or day schools. However, the preference is for residential schools as many of these children are from extremely poor and unstable families, and there are high chances of them dropping out of education if they are sent home after the course is over.

Our findings for RBCs are mostly based on qualitative data collected during the field work. We were able to visit five RBCs across Odisha and Jharkhand and collected feedback on RBCs from community members including PRI members and parents. We also interacted with teachers in RBCs and conducted children's FGDs at four RBCs that we visited.

RBCs are perceived as extremely useful by parents and PRI representatives, especially for destitute children and children who have had child marriages. While the course at RBC is supposed to get over between six to nine months, when the children do not have any place to go back to, they are provided accommodation in the RBC and enrolled in nearby government schools till they attain an age in which they can get admission to a government residential school. The RBC staff makes sure that the children are comfortable in the RBC: the meal plans, yoga classes, regular health check-ups, menstrual tracking for girls – all are geared to make children feel comfortable and develop a sense of belonging.

Post completion of the bridge course at RBC, children are mostly admitted to public residential schools such as Ashram schools and Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalaya (KGBVs)⁵. While seeking admission in a residential or day school during mainstreaming, documentation emerges as a major challenge. Many children do not have caste certificates, domicile certificates and Aadhaar cards and this acts as a

⁵ Ashram schools are residential schools which impart education upto secondary level to children belonging to scheduled tribes. Similarly, Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalayas (KGBVs) are residential schools at upper primary level for girls belonging to SC, ST, OBC and minority communities in educationally backward blocks of the country.

barrier to access for public schools. The programme staff help the parents in arranging the documents and coordinating with government officials to arrange these documents till the child is able to get admission. The FGDs and KIIs showed that as soon as the children are enrolled to RBC, the parents are informed regarding the documentation requirements. The GPCM helps the parents to get the documents, sometimes caste certificates are linked to domicile, so proof of land is required, during our field work, a number of cases emerged as evidence on how TSP staff worked with the PRIs and other relevant block officials to get this done.

Box 2: Residential Bridge Course Centre for girls, Joda

As one enters the RBC at Joda, located amidst iron and manganese mines and an abandoned township, one notices rich colours, written materials and smiling girls of all ages in two different 'classrooms'. A colourful time wheel made by girls displays the division of time and activities which girls would engage in throughout the day. The colorful Teaching Learning Materials (TLMs) of all kinds are on display in multiple languages like Ho, Hindi, Odia and English, along with a small section designated for library in these classrooms, which also serves as their bedroom in the night - their mattresses folded and kept neatly around the walls of the classroom making it obvious.

RBC Joda has a total strength of 146 girls and is managed by four teachers and one RBC in-charge. It has 10 rooms in total with a combination of kitchen, classrooms, dining halls and other office rooms. The building is gated and is monitored by a CCTV as well with enough space for the girls to play.

Children ranging usually between 9 to 14 years, often orphan/abandoned, long dropouts, never enrolled children and semi orphan kids make up the bulk of RBC children. Shanti (name changed), 15, tells us that she was earlier working as a manual labourer and her brother didn't want her to go to the RBC but the TSP staff convinced her brother (FGD with RBC children, January 2023). RBC centre which is now like a home for many of these girls seemed restrictive to them in the beginning; they used to cry and long for the free lives when they used to roam around in jungles. It took time in getting adjusted to sit in class but once they started making friends and enjoying the activities, it became easy. Playing and watching TV also made their stay easy (FGD with RBC children, January 2023).

A typical day at the RBC centre for these girls include individual activity, small group activity and hall (large group) activity. Most of these activities are thematic. In a hall class, if a question is asked, anyone can answer it but same is not true for individual or group activity as they are specific to that person or group (RBC staff interview, January 2023). A day at the RBC centre is a combination of classes, meals, play, review meetings, self-study sessions. Fridays are fixed for some cultural programmes at the RBC, on Saturday they have a committee review meeting – like food committee, health committee, etc. The members of the committees which mainly comprise of children keep changing so that all children get a chance to work in a particular committee. Sundays look different. They do their personal work like washing of clothes etc. and also get to meet their parents (RBC staff interview, 2023).

The activities at the centre are planned and curated by both students and the staff members, even the food menu is fixed (RBC staff interview, 2023). The girls at the RBC centre also do gardening, room cleaning and help the staff with chores, apart from attending their classes.

While we were there, an old man in his eighties walked into the campus. The RBC teacher quickly got a chair for him while Payal, 10, ran towards him. The teacher told that the old man was Payal's grandfather. She had lost both her parents in an accident and the grandfather was the only immediate family she was left with. Payal stayed in a neighbourhood that was considered very unsafe because it had a very high population of 'truck drivers' who were not necessarily locals or residents. Her grandfather was unable to take care of her at home as he often ventured out to collect forest wood which he sold in the market. The teacher also mentioned that he regularly came to visit Payal and see if she was doing fine. He had to walk around 10 Kms to reach the RBC. The RBC staff often offered him food if he came around lunch time.

Meena (name changed), now 15, came from a very impoverished family and the parents had sent her to work as domestic help with a family in Joda town. The man in that house raped Meena when she was barely 12-13 years old. Meena has been mentally disturbed since the time she came to the RBC, she doesn't talk much and when asked anything, she just smiles. The teachers try to help her, but they have not been able to be of much help. The girl also struggles with learning as she finds it difficult to focus (RBC staff interview, 2023). Such experiences of sexual violence and abuse were apparently not uncommon.

In the evening, the girls prepared to participate in the Joda mahotsava. They had prepared two- three dance numbers, and they were being choreographed by two women who were trained in dance. The shed where they had lunch in the evening was transformed into a space for dance, joy and expression. The girls coordinated their steps with their peers and took their practice very seriously. Later, once the rehearsal was over, they simply played their favourite songs to which all of them danced together. It was obvious that they felt safe and welcome. It was probably more than home for them. Many of the girls want to study more and help the situation at their homes, they want to take care of their siblings, want to become professional dancers and singers. They sang songs in Odiya, Hindi and English, and were keen to share how they have learnt to speak not only in their tribal language but also in Odiya, Hindi and even English.

Admission in a residential school is deemed as a big achievement and advantage by the communities. RBC's ability to get children admitted in these schools was cited by community members as one of the programme's major achievements (FGDs with parents and KIIs with PRI member, Dec 2022 – Jan, 2023). However, this is constrained by availability of limited seats at these residential schools and was mentioned as a major challenge by many RBC teachers (FGDs and KIIs with RBC teachers and in-charges).

Post mainstreaming too, many of the RBC teachers continue to engage with these children either as LEP teachers in the schools where they have been mainstreamed or through visits to their residential schools. Since the children have already built a relationship with the RBC teachers, this helps as the children are able to share any challenges that they are facing in the new school. For children who are attending day schools, the GPCM and LEP teacher continue to track whether they are attending school regularly. All these help in ensuring that the children remain in school.

There were many such children in the RBCs we visited who were enrolled in government schools nearby and continuing their education. We also witnessed cases where girls enrolled in residential schools come back to the RBC where she had studied during holidays for the lack of any other place to go to. This sort of responsiveness towards the needs of children and the flexibility provided by the organisation emerged to be one of the distinguishing features of the programme.

2.3.6. Maintenance of Village education Register (VER)

Village Education Register (VER) is a habitation-level child tracking system where the GPCM in each panchayat maintains children's details including name, age, gender, social category, and distance from house to school. VER also contains the enrolment status of children. VER is a critical document in tracking out-of-school children and formulating a set of activities to be conducted in a village.

Table 2.10: VER availability and presence of GPCM

Block	Availability of VER (Each block consists of two surveyed panchayats)	Presence of GPCM (Each block consists of two surveyed panchayats)
Koira	2	2
Harichandanpur	2	2
Joda	2	2
Danagadi	2	2
Sukinda	2	2
Total	10	10

Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

The VER verification conducted as part of the evaluation demonstrates that VER data is maintained and GPCM have been recruited in all the 10 panchayats (Table 2.4).

Table 2.5 shows that the details of children are maintained in 9 out of 10 panchayats, especially since 2027. In one panchayat in Sukinda block, the information recorded in the register was found incomplete even in recent years.

Table 2.11: Verification of information on children in VER

Detail information on children in VER (Odisha); Number (%)								
Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	7 (70)	8 (80)	9 (90)	9 (90)	9 (90)	9 (90)	9 (90)	9 (90)
Not available	1 (10)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete	2 (20)	2 (20)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10.00)	1 (10)
Total	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100.00)	10 (100)

Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

Data on Headcount at the habitation level is maintained in all the panchayats from 2019 onwards. From 2015 to 2019, in 9 out of 10 panchayats information on habitation level head count is maintained. Detailed information on the retention and transition of students to higher grades in VER is fully available in all panchayats from 2018 onwards. Detailed information on the enrolment status of children, dropout rates, and information on PRI and SMC members are also maintained. The information on CRPF members and AWC workers is also maintained but in one panchayat and two panchayats, the information on CRPF and AWC respectively is either incomplete or not recorded (Annex I). The information on the child-wise plan appeared to be comparatively less diligent. It is maintained only in 6 out of 10 GPs as part of VER (Table 2.6).

Table 2.12: Verification of detailed information on the child-wise plan in VER

Detailed information and Child wise plan (dropouts and never enrolled students) in VER (Odisha)								
Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	6 (60)	7 (70.)	7 (70)	6 (60)	6 (60)	6 (60)	6 (60)	6 (60)
Not available	4 (40)	3 (30)	3 (30)	4 (40)	4 (40)	4 (40)	4 (40)	4 (40)
Incomplete	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Total	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)

Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

The system of continuous personal tracking by GPCM and tools such as VER, even if not always complete in all respect, have indeed contributed in prevention of dropouts, as discussed earlier in detail.

2.4. Conclusion

Universal access of children in the age group of six to fourteen years to elementary education was one of the primary objectives of the intervention. It is evident that the programme has been almost able to achieve this with near universal access in the relevant age group.. Hundred percent of children in the relevant age group in our sample were in school in two of the five selected blocks. In the other three, the drop out proportion was below 2 percent. Hence, this appears to be a significant achievement of the programme.

The major initiatives which contributed to this achievement are the bridge courses at RBCs, direct enrolment, weekly headcount tracking, LEP classes and community mobilization initiatives. The programme has been designed in such a way as to envisage and address any needs of a child that is getting left behind. Adoption of such an all-encompassing approach and implementation on a large scale with significant amount of human resources at the ground level has ensured wide reach and effectiveness of the intervention.

While there has been a significant achievement of this scale, the very success has also thrown a few key challenges that would perhaps need to be addressed in future.

- **Transition to higher education:** While elementary schools are still relatively more accessible in these areas, secondary and higher secondary schools are less

so. Travelling to distant places for accessing public secondary or higher education entails both costs in terms of transportation and food and effort including safety risks due to need for travel in difficult terrains. As many of these children are first generation learners, if education does not lead to better life opportunities in the future, there are risks of disengagement from education itself. While TSP has already started engaging with these issues, and by itself cannot increase access to higher education, it can facilitate the community in lobbying for higher presence of higher education facilities and can also think of adopting direct advocacy efforts with the state government for this purpose.

- **Sustained collaborative relationships and institutionalisation of processes:** Close collaborative relationship with community members through engagement with parents, PRI members and SMC members has been one critical contributory factor to the success of the initiative. These collaborations need to be sustained to ensure that the programme keeps achieving its objectives. During the time of our field work, many newly elected panchayat members did not have sufficient understanding of education related issues. Almost none of the PRI members we spoke to had been trained on the usages and maintaining of Village Education Registers, which ideally should be maintained by them in the next phase. Developing strategy for handing over certain responsibilities to local institutions to ingrain deep ownership and institutionalisation of the initiative is called for at the next stage of implementation.

Chapter 3: Learning levels: notable progress

This chapter discusses the interventions and the impact seen on the learning of the TSP using both primary and secondary data. But before we delve deeper into these aspects, we first discuss the context of learning with reference to the students, schools, teachers, and the home environment which all form critical inputs to provide a learning environment and sustain learning for children.

3.1. The Context of Learning

Context of learning is a critical factor in ensuring effective and meaningful learning in children. Learning, as well documented in education discourse, has been seen as an individual process as well as social process where the social, cultural, and economic factors play a significant role in shaping the learning experiences of individuals (Young and Smith, 1997). The classroom and school environment which is an important input in learning are a factor of the relationships that students build with their peers and teachers which in turn are not just influenced by the classroom processes but are also dependent on the social and cultural identities of students (Kershner, 2008). For example, in a diverse classroom, where students come from various social and economic backgrounds the classroom processes that encourage inclusion would lead to better sharing of knowledge amongst peers and also facilitate the process of individual learning as students would be more comfortable and receptive without feeling excluded due to their social backgrounds (Walker and Baepler, 2018).

In addition to this, the language used in the classrooms also plays an important role. When the school language is different from the home language of the children, it can act as a barrier for children to understand and engage in the classroom processes. This is true for most developing nations, and especially true in the context of India. The use of home language of the children in classroom processes enhances the connect that the child has with their culture, aids in cognitive development, and also ensures learning of other languages (Nishanthi, 2020).

Parental education is another critical factor that influences learning, both at home and school. It is well known that the presence of a learning environment at home enables children to explore, revise and engage with not just what has been taught in school, but also provides an additional support structure for learning of concepts and skills that the students may otherwise find difficult to grasp at school. Not just this, parental aspirations related to the education of their children is also linked to their own education. Studies have consistently shown that when parents are educated, there is more likelihood of their children being able to attain educational levels that exceed that of parents. This is particularly strong for the linkages between mother's education and educational attainments of girls. As mother's education not only influences the educational levels and learning for children in general, but it has also been seen that when the mother is educated, there is more possibility of their girls to study more than what the mother has attained (Maitra and Sharma, 2009). Parental education plays a role in retention of children in schools, a report published by young lives in February 2018 showed children whose parents were relatively more educated and aspired for their children to complete secondary schooling, were most likely to complete their education by age 19, as compared to others.

The quality of learning in a school is also a factor of the kind of resources that are available for children, while these resources may comprise of direct learning resources like availability of teachers, age-appropriate books in libraries, or timely availability of text books for children, the other resources like provision of meals, school bags, functional and separate toilets for girls, boundary walls, all weather pucca building and clear drinking water play a key role (Kapur, 2018). And more so, for children who come from marginalised backgrounds as these supporting resources are necessary for them to be able to continue and sustain their learning in school in the absence of such resources at home or their parents' ability to provide for these.

While learning is highly dependent on all these factors, it also gets impacted by the rigid school expectations around high academic performance of students, uniform classroom processes which solely focuses on teacher inputs, high parental involvement in the education of children irrespective of their socio-economic capacities to do so. Rigid school systems seldom take into account the different socio-economic backgrounds of children, learning styles and abilities and the difference in support structures that are available for children. Therefore, any intervention that seeks to address learning deficits in children and enhance overall learning in children, needs to be cognisant of all these factors. This also makes the changes envisaged in the learning levels of children particularly complex as changing rigid

school structures or influencing learning environments at home needs sustained and intensive work for long periods of time involving multiple stakeholders.

The context of learning is therefore dynamic and changes not just from school to school, but from individual to individual. This chapter therefore seeks to locate the TSP and particularly two of its flagship interventions namely, the Learning Enhancement Programme (LEP) and the Residential Bridge Course (RBC) within the context of learning to see the kinds of changes it has been able to influence on the students, teachers, and schools.⁶

3.2. The TSP's Interventions on Learning

The main objective for the learning-based interventions by the TSP is to address the foundational learning deficits in children so as to enable grade-appropriate learning, while the end goal of this remains at what pedagogues call 'learning to learn'. In simple words, the programme tries to identify and address the basic learning gaps especially in language (including English) and mathematics for children, then moves on to other subjects like science and social studies, and gradually enables children to self-directed learning. This is the kind of progression that the programme aims for in its LEP classrooms. The context of the RBCs and NRBCs are different, since it is a bridge course, but the objective and progression remain similar, i.e., to identify the basic learning deficits in children and address them in order for them to be 'school ready' for age-appropriate enrolment. As per the programme documents, this is done through a digitised Bridge Language Inventory (BLI) tool mainly used to facilitate bridging the gap between the home language and the language of instruction in schools.

In addition to these, the programme also strives to embed the LEP pedagogy into the regular government school classrooms through demonstrations and training of teachers. Here the main objective is not just to influence the classroom processes to be more learner friendly, but to also ensure sustainability of the impact and more importantly, the pedagogy of LEP classrooms. Focus is given to context specific learning, which children can relate to and inculcate a sense of 'knowingness'. This is done through the syllabus of the LEP and RBC both being rooted in the local context of the children by highlighting indigenous cultures practices and knowledge systems. In order to facilitate creativity and expression through art, both in LEP classes and RBCs, the programme encourages children to express themselves through drawings and craftwork. The children also have the opportunity to showcase these skills in child festivals that are organised at a regular basis. The communities and teachers are encouraged to participate in these festivals (1000 schools' program – A work primer, 2019; Interviews with ASPIRE and TSF Team, November, 2022)

As discussed above, learning is intrinsically connected with other school-based inputs like regularity of teachers, teacher motivation, presence of a 'learning environment' at school, if not at home. In order to address these needs, the

⁶ The evaluation team could not observe any NRBC as they were not operational during the field visit.

programme works with community-based institutions like SMCs to enable and establish teacher accountability, provision of entitlements like Mid-day Meals (MDM) and libraries in all the schools. Teacher training and working with the education department at the block and cluster level also form important aspects of the intervention. Summer camps are also organised to ensure continuity of learning for children when schools are closed for summer vacations. In these camps, not just the children enrolled with LEP, but others who are interested to join are encouraged (Interviews with the TSP team, Nov, 2022). Another important aspect of the programme which is based on the constructivist idea of students being active participants in their own schooling process, is that of the 'child parliaments'. These are functional in all schools, RBCs and NRBCs where students assume various portfolios like health minister, cleanliness minister, discipline minister, food minister in order to supervise various administrative and managerial aspects of their respective institutions of learning.

We now highlight some of the critical features of the two flagship interventions by the 1000 schools programme – i.e., LEP and RBC/NRBCs

3.2.1. Main Features of the Learning Enrichment Programme (LEP)

As discussed above, LEP is based on a student-centred pedagogy that facilitates learning in children present in the government schools where the 1000 schools programme intervenes.

- Rooted in the Right to Education (RtE), 2009 provision of 'special training'
- Acts as a sustainable, scalable, proof of concept – based on teaching methods that are child friendly, contextual and activity based. Extensive use of Teaching Learning Materials (TLM) for academic support
- Active progress monitoring through baseline, midline and endline, weekly and monthly testing of children, in addition to supervision of LEP teachers by LEP co-ordinators which allows for dynamic course correction and mitigation of challenges.
- Enrols the worst performing children (assessed through baseline survey) in a school, in order to bring them at par with the age-appropriate learning levels.
- Gradual progression from simple, basic concepts to more complex ones and treats learning deficit as a compounding concept.
- Philosophy of LEP embedded in understanding the connection between the learning levels of children and the historical marginalisation of indigenous communities and the continued apathy towards their learning
- Located within the school premise, classes take place before and after school in two batches of three hours each
- Three stages – LEP 1, 2 and 3 – L1 is for grade 3, 4 and 5 based on foundational concepts of grade 1 and 2. Students then progress to L2 which focuses on foundational concepts from grade 3-5, L3 is for students in grades 6,7 and 8 based on foundational concepts from grade 5 and 6.
- Based on a 20-week action plan for L1 and L2, six weeks for L3 – with syllabus curated at the state level

- Combination of individual, small groups and the whole class – presentations in class form a critical part of LEP classes
- Teachers and education department as critical allies

3.2.3. Main features of the Residential Bridge Course (RBC) and Non-Residential Bridge Course (NRBC)

As the name suggested, RBCs are residential spaces where the 1000 school programme's bridge courses are run and a similar course is run in a non-residential setup called NRBCs.

- Established for underprivileged children who are either never enrolled or school drop outs with the main intention to mainstream them
- Duration in RBC is 6 months to one year, although children who need a residential setup to continue their education do stay longer (as seen in field work)
- Teacher identified from local communities who are trained to undertake the bridge courses offered at both the RBCs and NRBCs
- Activity based and TLM supported learning which encourages individual learning as well as group work
- Extra-curricular activities like dance, songs and participation in sports and cultural events
- Child parliament present in all
- Monitoring of child's progress through baseline, midline and endline and regular weekly and monthly tests. After the baseline, children are clubbed on the basis of their performance in three groups A, B and C (High, Medium and Low)
- NRBCs present only in extremely remote locations
- Once mainstreamed children are tracked regularly by the RBC/NRBC staff and the local 1000 school programme staff

3.3. The Evaluation Approach

Data that is used in this chapter is triangulated from three main sources. Firstly, secondary data from various literature sources is used to set up the context of learning; secondly, a comparison of the baseline, midline and endline data collected by the ASPIRE team on various learning levels of children from the Learning Enrichment Programme (LEP) programme, Residential Bridge Course (RBC) and Non-Residential Bridge Course (NRBC) have also been analysed. Here, we also use secondary data from large-scale learning assessment surveys like Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) and National Achievement Survey (NAS), to establish some markers of comparison in the learning assessments. Thirdly, we use the data that we collected. The learning data collected by CBPS is taken from two methods of data collection. One is from learning-based surveys of children which formed a small section of the survey that was conducted with parents. After the survey was completed with the parents, the CBPS team conducted a small reading assessment with one child from each household. The children were graded as per the level of ease with which they could read a word, sentence, and a paragraph in Odiya (for Odisha) and Hindi (for Jharkhand). Since this chapter is focussed on the Odisha

based intervention, we will only discuss the results from children in Odisha in this chapter.

From all the five blocks where the TSP was active, 250 children across the age group from 10-18 years were assessed. Out of the 250 children who were assessed about 61% had some experience with learning interventions of the TSP, the numbers also showed that most of these children were a part of LEP, while some had also attended the summer camps and seven children were a part of the RBCs. For the purpose of the study, while discussing the survey data we use two categories, children directly a part of the learning initiatives by the TSP (CL-TSP) and others as (CL-Non-TSP)

The last few questions for children in the survey went beyond assessment of reading levels, as conceptual questions that were based on critical thinking were also included. We also use the qualitative data collected from FGDs and interviews with parents, teachers, SMC members and the TSP personnel like LEP teachers, LEP co-ordinators, RBC in-charge, RBC teachers to name a few. In addition to this, CBPS also conducted in-depth FGDs with children to understand their learning levels in basic mathematics and Odiya, for children who were in grade 4 and above. The Odisha curriculum and text books for Odisha state government schools were reviewed to develop tools that were age and grade level appropriate. The FGDs also went a step further to assess other critical skills that contribute to learning, like ability to participate in group activities, ability to communicate, mathematical thinking, language thinking and critical thinking.

3.4. The status of resources and students' entitlements in sample schools

Before going in details about the TSP's impact on learning, we provide a little bit more context to the resources present at the school level and the key entitlements that are provided to students, as these too play a role in ensuring the conducive environment for learning. We conducted field work in ten schools from the five blocks that were a part of the sample. In all these schools, the LEP programme was operational. A detailed school resource mapping was conducted to understand the availability of teachers' vis-a vis students, the presence of critical infrastructural facilities and entitlements like Mid-day Meals (MDM) as mandated by the Right to Education (RtE).

We found in almost all the schools, the Pupil Teacher Ratio (PTR) was close to the normative requirement of 1:30 for primary and 1:35 for upper primary. This showed that even though most of the schools functioned as multi-grade classrooms, which is the case for most rural schools in India, teacher shortage was probably not an issue. The average qualifications of teachers were also in lines with the state requirement for primary school teachers to have at least passed standard 12th. We also found the average teaching experience of teachers in the ten schools close to 10 years, with a few exceptions where the average experience was between 5 to 10 years.

In terms of the infrastructural facilities as seen in table 3.1, all the schools had a pucca all weather building, most schools (except for one in Danagadi) had a boundary wall and Teaching learning materials (TLM) in the form of charts, figures, cut-outs were

found to be present in most classrooms. However, the presence of functional playgrounds, ramps, functional and separate toilets for girls and availability of clear drinking water seemed to be an issue. Most importantly, we saw that out of the 10-school visited, only four had functional toilets for girls with some facility for water and cleanliness. All these four schools were located in Danagadi and Joda. Surprisingly, the same schools did not have clean drinking water facilities for students, except for one school in Joda.

Table 3.13: Infrastructural facilities present in the schools

Blocks	Pucca Building	Boundary wall	Playground	Ramps	Toilets for girls	Drinking water	TLM
Danagadi	YY	NY	YY	YN	YY	NN	YY
Harichandanpur	YY	YY	NN	YY	NN	NN	YY
Joda	YY	YY	YN	YY	YY	NY	YY
Koira	YY	YY	NN	YN	NN	YY	YY
Sukinda	YY	YY	YN	NN	NN	NY	YY

Source: Data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022-Jan 2023

Note: YY – present in both schools, NY – present in only one school, NN- not present in both schools

As seen in table 3.2, school entitlements like free text books, uniforms, scholarships and hot Mid-Day Meals (MDM) were provided in all the ten schools.

Table 3.14: Entitlements provided to children in the schools

Blocks	Text books	Uniforms	Scholarships	MDM
Danagadi	YY	YY	YY	YY
Harichandanpur	YY	YY	YY	YY
Joda	YY	YY	YY	YY
Koira	YY	YY	YY	YY
Sukinda	YY	YY	YY	YY

Source: Data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022-Jan 2023

Therefore, the schools seemed to be largely compliant of the RTE norms for teachers, infrastructure and entitlements, though the critical infrastructure that are essential for a supportive learning environment and retention in schools like functional and separate toilets for girls seemed to be missing. Although neither the presence or absence of any infrastructure or facility can be attributed directly to the programme, the TSP has made a difference to the school functioning, as we would see in the subsequent chapters while discussing the issue of school governance.

3.5. Impact of the Programme on Learning

We first discuss the impact of the programme as seen through the baseline, midline and endline surveys conducted by the TSP team, and then move on to discussing the impact as seen by the quantitative and qualitative data collected by CBPS.

3.5.1. Impact on performance of children assessed through the Baseline, Midline and Endline Surveys

All children in schools that the LEP programme is present in are first administered a baseline test on language and mathematics. These tests are scored at a total of 50, while maths has two sections – maths 1 and 2, we have assumed that the total score for mathematics is 100. Those children who score below 30 in the baseline are selected for the LEP programme. Once the children complete the 20 weeks of L1, the same test is repeated in the form of endline. The questions for both the tests remain the same in order to facilitate comparison and understanding of progression. The tests also remain the same irrespective of the grade in which the child is enrolled. If L1 is to start in the school, then the baseline tests are administered to children in grade 3, 4 and 5. Similarly, if L3 has to be introduced in the school, then all children in grade 6, 7 and 8 are assessed for baseline. Midline testing, as per the primer document shared by ASPIRE is not a norm, although desirable, and usually conducted for a smaller sample.

As seen in table 3.3, it is clear that there is substantial improvement seen in the performance of all children in LEP, irrespective of the blocks, subjects and gender. A clear progression in performance is also visible across the blocks, subjects and gender, where the children score higher in midline and more so, in the endline. There is no gender wise variation seen in the data, boys and girls have performed equally well across the blocks irrespective of subjects. Variation, however, exists for blocks, as one can see that the progression in average score has been the best in Koira, where the performance of girls has improved by about 25 marks in language and 65 marks in mathematics. The performance of boys is close, as they have improved by 22 marks in language and about 59 marks in mathematics. The performance of children enrolled in LEP, for Joda and Danagadi block seem similar.

Table 3.15: Average scores attained by LEP children in baseline, midline and endline tests

Block / Subject	Girls			Boys		
	BL	ML	EL	BL	ML	EL
Joda						
Language	6.83	21.52	28.78	5.71	20.13	26.89
Mathematics	16.48	47.01	64.42	14.85	43.45	63.09
Danagadi						
Language	10.24	22.48	31.20	9.07	20.97	30.08
Mathematics	21.76	49.90	69.74	20.56	48.27	69.53
Koira						
Language	8.94	22.78	34.35	7.27	19.28	29.58
Mathematics	13.69	57.28	78.84	15.96	52.50	74.54

Source: Data shared by the TSP Team

Note: BL – Baseline, ML – Midline and EL – Endline

3.5.2. Impact on Learning Levels of Children Assessed through Focus Group Discussions (FGDs)

In each school, one round of FGDs were conducted with children either from class 4 and 5, or with children from classes 6 to 8 depending on their availability and the type of school. Out of the 10 FGDs conducted with children, six were with children from grade 4 and 5, while four FGDs were with children from grade 6 to 8. Care was taken to ensure that children who were a part of the LEP programme were also a part of the FGDs.

Two sets of tools were developed for the FGDs, while the concepts and competencies that were tested remained the same, the questions were calibrated based on the grade level competencies and syllabus. The activities were designed to show progression from simple to more complex, this was mainly done to ease the children into participating freely in the FGDs. For example, the first activity that was conducted with children was for them to make a height-wise line in ascending order. Once this was done, they moved on to performing more complex activities like folding paper to make shapes of various sizes which enabled us not just to assess their ability to follow simple Odiya and communication skills with each other, but also mathematical thinking. Children were first given an introduction to why and what the FGDs contained, they were also told that there was no right or wrong answers and they could do whatever they felt like as it was not a test.

The research team was extensively trained on how to conduct the FGDs and assess children accordingly. Most importantly, the team was cognisant of the limitations of spot testing by unfamiliar persons and therefore we refrained from grading children but stuck to assessments based on group competencies rather than individual tests.

Box 3.1: FGD with children: assessing competencies through collaborative work

The key competencies that the FGDs with children explored were – language comprehension, mathematical thinking, language expression, collaboration and peer learning, communication skills, understanding of geography, culture and knowledge of their own state (Odisha), understanding of colours and creative thinking and an added competency of critical thinking was also assessed for grade 6 to 8. These parameters were assessed through various activities that children were asked to perform in pairs, that were either mixed in terms of gender, or single sex pairs. All FGDs were conducted in Odiya. The purpose for doing this was firstly, to assess collaborative and group work in children, and secondly, for them to feel comfortable and learn from their peers. The idea was to also assess if peer learning was taking place, not just within groups but also between groups. Like, if one group of children could finish a task successfully, say folding the paper into the smallest possible rectangle, then the FGDs also assessed if others who were struggling, saw that group and followed what they had done. Children were not scored as per their abilities, but the competencies were observed and noted down for particular groups. For example, under language comprehension, one of the parameters was the children's ability to understand and follow simple instructions in Odiya, based on how children performed we assessed children based on four categories, all children could do it

with ease, most children could do it with ease, most children struggled and lastly, all children struggled.

Table 3.16: Competencies as seen in the FGDs for class 4 and 5

Blocks	Language Comprehension	Mathematical Thinking	Language Expression & Communication	Collaboration and Peer Learning	Understanding of geography, culture and Odisha	Understanding of colours	Creative Thinking
Koira	√	√	X	X	√	√√	X
Harichandanpur	√√	√	√	√√	√√	√√	√
Joda	√√	√	√√	√	√	√√	X
Danagadi	√	√	√	√	√	√√	√
Sukinda	√√	√	√√	√	√	√√	√

Source: Data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

Note: √√ = all children exhibited this competency, √ = most children exhibited this competency, X= most children did not exhibit this competency, XX= all children did not exhibit this competency

Table 3.17: Competencies as seen in the FGDs for class 6, 7 and 8

Blocks	Language Comprehension	Mathematical Thinking	Language Expression & Communication	Collaboration and Peer Learning	Understanding of geography, culture and Odisha	Understanding of colours	Creative Thinking & Critical Thinking
Koira	√	X	√	X	X	√√	XX
Harichandanpur	√√	√√	√√	√√	√√	√√	√
Joda	√√	√	√√	X	√	√√	XX
Danagadi*	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
Sukinda	√√	√	√√	√	√√	√√	X

Source: Data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

Note: √√ = all children exhibited this competency, √ = most children exhibited this competency, X= most children did not exhibit this competency, XX= all children did not exhibit this competency

*In both the schools of Danagadi, children from class 4 and 5 were a part of the FGD

Tables 3.4 and 3.5 show the block wise competencies in children for grades 4 and 5, and also grade 6 to 8. The data clearly shows that children from all blocks irrespective of class could easily perform tasks that required them to identify colours. Language comprehension in Odiya terms of both following the instruction and communication within themselves was clearly exhibited by almost all children, barring a very small number. In terms of mathematical thinking, while most children from grade 4 and 5 across blocks could exhibit this competency, we found a few children struggling with higher level competency of mathematical thinking. For example, most children could arrange themselves in height-wise lines of ascending order, but when it came to application of mathematics to shapes and folding the shapes from papers that was given to them, many found it difficult. This was despite the fact that the shapes like rectangle and triangle were a part of the Odisha state

government syllabus for grade 3 and 4, while mathematical concepts like perimeter were a part of the syllabus for grade 4 and 5.

Collaboration and peer learning which was assessed through the children's ability to work in groups, learn from each other and help each other perform tasks did not seem to be very challenging for children from almost half the schools. The children also seemed to have a fairly good understanding of basic geography and knowledge about their own state irrespective of the class in which they studied. Having said that, the competencies that seemed to be most challenging, especially for children in grades 6 to 8, was creative thinking.

Majority of the children from the schools of Harichandanpur irrespective of their grades displayed these skills including creative thinking, and Dangadi was the next. The children from the schools of Koira, again irrespective of the grades, seemed to struggle relatively more when compared to others in competencies like collaboration and peer learning, and also in creative thinking.

Achievements as seen through FGDs with Children

The performance of children in terms of language comprehension and expression needs to be noted as a big success as the LEP classes are focussed on language. The interviews and FGDs with LEP teachers and facilitators clearly showed that the difference between the home language and the school language is a challenge and therefore the need for bridging was critical for all LEP classes. From the data it was clear that there was possible positive impact in this direction. The data also showed that children could easily express themselves in Odiya, which required not just knowing and understanding a particular language, but the ability to think in a particular language. In sum, the language competencies were one of the key impacts that could be attributed to the LEP classes.

Children also showed a good understanding of their own state and culture, as they could perform tasks of group formation based on pairing of concepts/objects like Patachitra and art. All children irrespective of their grades or blocks showed very good understanding of colours.

LEP also focuses on mathematics, and mathematical thinking is directly connected with the application of mathematics. The data showed the students, irrespective of their classes were able to perform the simple mathematics application-based tasks.

Challenges as seen through FGDs with Children

Our interviews and review of the programme documents shared by ASPIRE also revealed that the LEP classes allowed for group work and peer learning, but this seemed to be a challenge for many children. What was observed during the FGDs was a lack of ease in communication and working together between mixed gender groups, and sometimes the boy and the girl even refused to talk to each other, and the discomfort with sitting in mixed group settings was clearly visible. In one of the FGDs, which had both single sex group and mixed sex groups, we found that only the girls who were paired together were conversing with each other in order to perform the task of learning about each other's hobbies, preferences, likes and

dislikes. When probed and asked further, the mixed-sex group children merely repeated what the other groups had said about their partners.

Box 3.2: LEP in Bareigoda, Harichandapur

Bareigoda is a small village located in the Harichandapur block of Keonjhar district in Odisha. Located between the mountains and surrounded by a small stream of water, the village is remote and is inhabited mostly by ST population. The TSP has been running its LEP initiative in the panchayat since 2015 (ASPIRE staff interviews, December 2022), Primary school Turukipada located towards the end of the village is a two room small school with a separate mid-day meal kitchen. With two teachers catering to the total strength of 73 children, the help and assistance by the LEP teacher is desired not only by the students but is also something which is acknowledged by the government teachers who are usually pressed hard with the administrative work (FGD Government Teachers, December 2022).

The LEP classroom is always full of TLM like flashcards which are tied in the classroom with a string and displayed words and letters. The LEP teacher who is often fondly called ‘tuition master’ by parents and children starts his work for the LEP class one day prior to the actual class, one day prior he prepares the tasks which he would do with the student on the next day. The day for him starts with a morning prayer in the school followed by activities like ‘thought of the day’ and a ‘small quiz’ where questions like what’s the name of our country is asked. He mentions that this enables a lot of learning, “children learn from each other, if one knows something everyone learns”(ASPIRE staff interviews, December 2022).

He then takes a 2 hour long class. He tells students words like ‘plastic’ and explains them what it is and asks them to locate objects made of plastic. The storytelling session in the classroom moves away from mere repetition of the story from the book. He narrates the story to the students, asks them to repeat the story along with him and asks them about the main characters of the story. The work of the LEP teacher doesn’t end even after the class ends, he goes for home-visits to the homes of those students who didn’t come to the school on that particular day. A short break to his home allows him to prepare and get ready for the support class in which he teaches students concepts of Foundational Learning and Numeracy (FLN) through TLM (ASPIRE staff interviews, December 2022).

The children attending the LEP classes actively participate when the TSP team organise awareness programmes on child labour, child marriage, mother’s day, youth day showing their confidence and interest (FGD Government Teachers, December 2022). Many school teachers here admire this and have learnt to integrate TLM like flashcards in their own classroom processes to make it more engaging (FGD Government Teachers, December 2022). Parents also admire this ‘tuition teacher’ and say that the teaching methods and the efforts of the teacher are unique, as he makes students learn through singing, dancing and storytelling and many of their children go to the tuition much before the time of the class. Their children particularly enjoy the tuition classes and they have become very fond of him. If the tuition teacher does not come to school, then the children also refuse to go (FGD

Parents, December 2022).

We also found that children who found collaboration difficult, also struggled with critical and creative expression. This was also due to the design of the task, which was dependent on conversation with the partner as it needed them to talk to their partners about what they liked the most about them. We also found that the children from higher classes (6 to 8) struggled much more in this than those from grades 4 and 5. One possible reason for this could be the age and gender factor, as most of these children were at the brink of adolescence, it is possible that their apprehensions to freely talk and express themselves in mixed group got more inhibited due to social norms and structures, which are very embedded in children of that age group.

3.5.3. Impact on Learning Levels of Children Assessed through a Simple Reading and Comprehension Test

As discussed in the introduction chapter, almost all children in the sample of 250 households belonged to marginalised sections by virtue of their caste, BPL status and remote habitation. A typical child in the sample therefore was most likely to be a child belonging to the Scheduled Tribe (ST) category, except for Danagadi where most children belonged to the Scheduled Caste (SC) category. We also found that most of these children, with the exception of Danagadi were first generational learners. All 250 children except for 18 drop outs who were surveyed were enrolled in school.

Table 3.18: Reading levels by caste, BPL status and educational status of parents

Number and Percentage (%)	Able to read fluently	Able to read with difficulty	Able to read some letters / words only	Unable to read	Child too shy to do the test	Total
Total	134	47	49	13	7	250
%	54%	19%	20%	5%	3%	100%
ST	59	26	32	11	6	134
%	44%	19%	24%	8%	4%	100%
SC	43	11	11	2	1	68
%	63%	16%	16%	3%	1%	100%
BPL	120	42	46	11	7	226
%	53%	19%	20%	5%	3%	100%
Both parents at least primary completed	54	9	14	2	0	79
%	68%	11%	18%	3%	0%	100%
Both parents illiterate OR mother illiterate	60	31	29	8	7	135
%	44%	23%	21%	6%	5%	100%

Source: Survey Data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

The simple reading test administered for 250 children asked them to read three lines in Odiya and their ability to read was accordingly assessed on five parameters, as shown in table 3.6. The data on reading assessment showed that nearly three fourth (72%) children could read the sentences; more than half of the children (54 %) were able to read fluently, while close to 18% children exhibited some difficulty in reading, but could eventually read all the three sentences. Only 13 children out of the sample of 250 could not read even a single word. Although strict comparisons are difficult, these numbers read better when compared to the ASER 2022 report on learning levels of children in central and northern Odisha where Jajpur, Keonjhar and Sundargarh districts were a part of the sample.

It should be noted here that out of the total of 68 children who belonged to the SC category, 45 children resided in Danagadi block where the proportion of households with literate parents was also high. Also, unlike children from tribal communities, Oriya is more commonly spoken among SC communities and the familiarity with the language could have played a role in the ease of reading. The distribution across parameters was almost the same for the children from BPL families as that of the total, as they formed the bulk of the respondents. These findings also reinforced the fact that the educational levels of parents make a clear difference: children who had both parents who had at least completed primary did very well in the reading test, as 68% could read fluently and an additional 11% could read with some difficulty.

The above analysis makes it clear that household characteristics make a difference in children's learning abilities, at least in the initial years. We then tried to see if there was any difference in reading abilities between children with direct exposure to TSP's learning interventions and those with no direct contact with learning interventions. Table 3.7 presents these figure for three of the five parameters. We found that the difference existed though these were not always large; the number of children who had exposure to the learning interventions by TSP could read fluently was higher by 11 percentage points. There was a 25 percentage point difference in this category (ability to read fluently) between SC children with exposure to learning interventions as compared to those who did not. It was also evident that when children with both parents with some school educations are also supported by other learning interventions, it impacts their levels of learning positively.

Table 3.19: Reading levels by caste, BPL status and educational status of parents for CL-TSP and CL-non-TSP

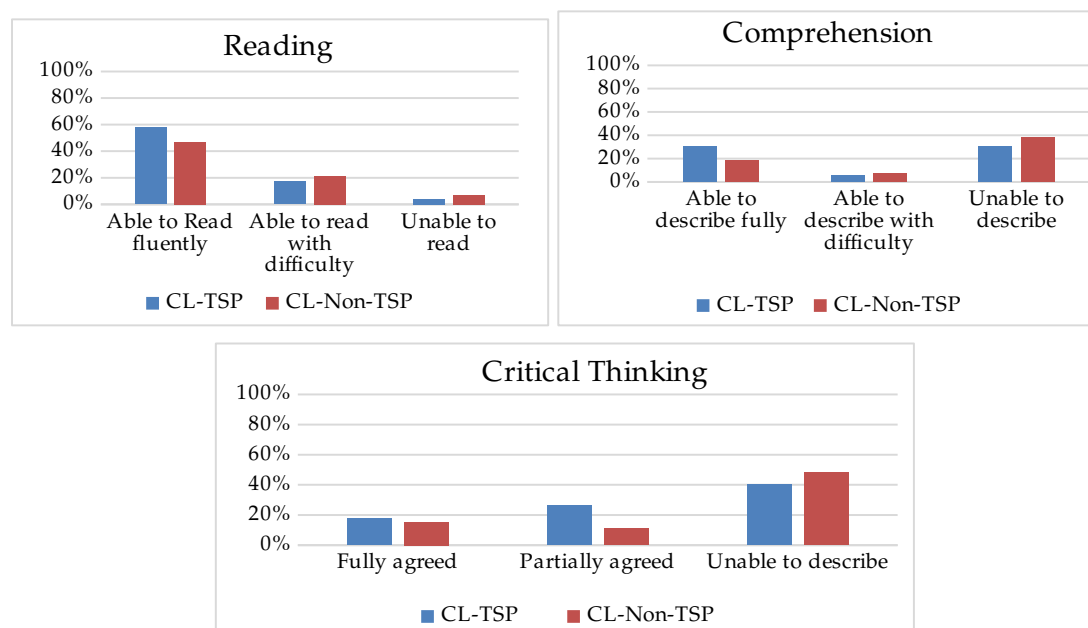
	CL- TSP			CL- Non-TSP		
	Able to read fluently	Able to read with difficulty	Unable to read	Able to read fluently	Able to read with difficulty	Unable to read
Total	88	26	6	46	21	7
%	58%	17%	4%	47%	21%	7%
ST	36	18	4	23	8	7
%	43%	22%	5%	45%	16%	14%
SC	30	4	2	13	7	

	CL- TSP			CL- Non-TSP		
	Able to read fluently	Able to read with difficulty	Unable to read	Able to read fluently	Able to read with difficulty	Unable to read
%	73%	10%	5%	48%	26%	0%
BPL	77	23	5	43	19	6
%	57%	17%	4%	47%	21%	7%
Both parents at least primary completed	40	4		14	5	2
%	82%	8%	0%	47%	17%	7%
Both parents' illiterate or mother illiterate	35	19	5	25	12	3
%	42%	23%	6%	48%	23%	6%

Source: Data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

To assess the comprehension levels of children, after they completed their reading assessment, they were asked to explain the meaning of the sentences in Odiya. The data for language comprehension showed that only 26% of the children could fully describe the three sentences with ease, while a majority (close to 33 %) were unable to describe even one sentence. Nevertheless, similar to the data on reading ability, in terms of language comprehension and communication also, there is a clear difference between the CL- TSP and CL non-TSP children, with a greater number of children CL- TSP demonstrating the ability to fully describe the sentences that they had read in their own words (see figure 3.1).

Figure 3. 1: Reading, Comprehension and Critical Thinking Abilities of Children



Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

The three sentences were carefully chosen to not just talk about tribal and indigenous peoples, but also include certain common stereotypes about these populations. This was deliberately done in order to assess if the children are able to take any stance regarding the statements, reflecting their ability to think critically. For this, the children were asked if they fully agreed, partially agreed or disagreed with the three statements and their reasons for the same, with 'partially agreed' being the most nuanced answer. We found that while most of the students (about 43%) were unable to describe the sentence and therefore could not decide whether they agreed or disagreed, a significantly higher proportion of children from the CL-TSP group said so (partially agreed) as compared to the CL non-TSP children (Figure 3.1).

What emerged clearly from these analyses is that even though majority of the students could read the sentences, relatively fewer could comprehend it without difficulty and even fewer could analyse the statements critically. However, in all three criteria, children with direct exposure to one or more TSP education interventions performed better than those with no direct contact. This pattern continued even when the data was bifurcated for two age-groups: 8-11 and 12-15 year olds⁷ (table 3.8). The older age group children understandably performed better than the younger ones but the CL-TSP children fared better than CL-non-TSP children in all three categories for both the age groups.

Table 3.20: Reading, Comprehension and Critical Thinking by Age

Age	Reading			Comprehension			Critical Thinking		
		8-11	12-15		8-11	12-15		8-11	12-15
CL-TSP	Able to Read fluently	54%	69%	Able to describe fully	27%	39%	Fully agreed	14%	27%
	Able to read with difficulty	15%	16%	Able to describe with difficulty	4%	8%	Partially agreed	22%	33%
	Unable to read	6%	0%	Unable to describe	36%	18%	Unable to describe	46%	31%
CL-Non-TSP	Able to Read fluently	29%	58%	Able to describe fully	8%	26%	Fully agreed	6%	23%
	Able to read with difficulty	25%	21%	Able to describe with difficulty	6%	9%	Partially agreed	10%	7%
	Unable to read	13%	2%	Unable to describe	54%	26%	Unable to describe	58%	42%

Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

The difference between CL-TSP and CL-non-TSP holds largely true even when we examine the block-wise data (Figure 2). Among the blocks, Koira, one of the remotest

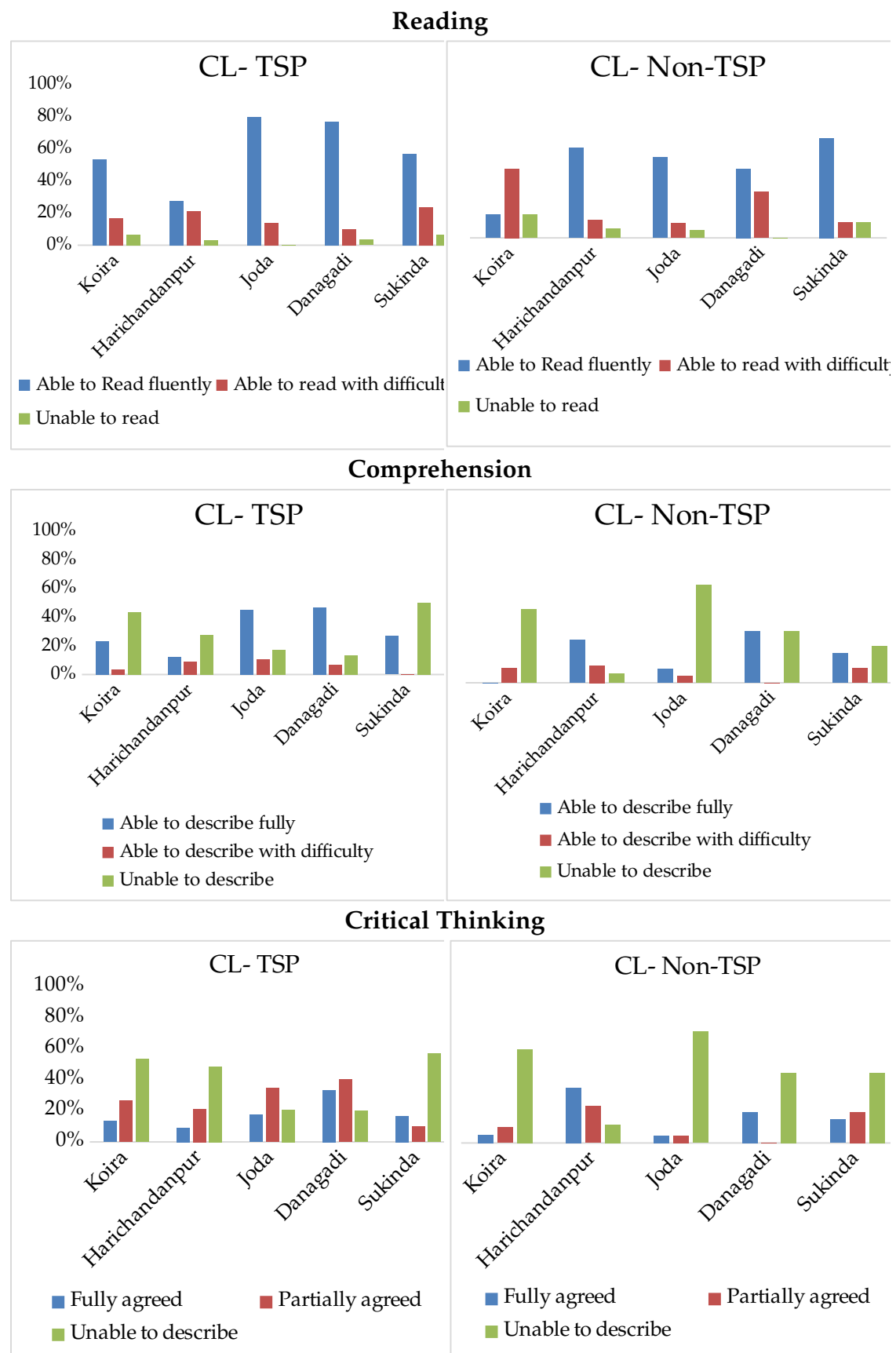
⁷ Those in 17-18 age group were removed because of the small number in that category.

and most educationally backward block out of the five, is performing relatively worse than the other blocks in almost all parameters of learning while Danagadi performed relatively better than others. The children from Danagadi also performed better in completing the tasks based on mathematical thinking or tasks that required collaboration and group work during their FGDs. The household characteristics in Danagadi seem to play a role: low proportion of ST population, higher parental education and lower incidence of landlessness. The parental representation in PRIs and SMC was also higher as compared to other blocks as per the data received from the household survey.

The comparison between CL-TSP and CL-non-TSP assumes significance because ideally the CL-TSP children, who have been part of the TSP intervention for being either a dropout / never enrolled child (e.g., RBC/NRBC), or having lower levels of learning (e.g., LEP) should be expected to fare worse than their counterparts. Therefore, the fact that they are in general, faring better in reading, comprehension as well as critical thinking, shows the high success of these interventions. Harichandanpur is an exception to this pattern (figure 3.2) the cause for which needs to be investigated further. This is despite the fact that the parental and school-teachers' feedback from this block on the LEP teachers has been very positive, as we would see in later discussions.

This comparison, and the fact that CL-TSP children are performing better despite starting from a position of disadvantage, however, raises the question whether it is justified to select only the 'low performing' ones, especially in the case of LEP, as even others who are not necessarily performing badly may be in need of better pedagogical experiences and more engaged, interesting teaching learning processes. This is something that many parents also expressed in our interactions with them, something that we analyse a little later.

Figure 3. 2: Reading, Comprehension and Critical thinking by blocks



Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

3.5.4. Parental and school-teachers' perception of the child's learning

We have already discussed about parental perception 'the child's greater interest in studies' and 'better school functioning' and its role in influencing access in the previous chapter. These are also the factors that influence learning. Here we examine parental perception about their children's learning.

Table 3.21: Parental perception of the child's learning

Block	Fully satisfied with the child's Odiya learning	Fully satisfied with the child's Maths learning
Koira	84%	68%
Harichandanpur	80%	54%
Joda	88%	74%
Danagadi	90%	74%
Sukinda	92%	72%
Total	87%	68%

Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

Most parents expressed their satisfaction with the way in which their children studied Odiya and Mathematics, with 87% parents saying that their children could fully read, write and understand Odiya, and 68% parents feeling the same about mathematics learning and comprehension. The parents in Harichandanpur expressed least satisfaction, which matches with the children's relatively lower performance there, also reflecting that despite not being very educated, parents seem to have a general understanding of their children's learning trajectories.

Table 3.22: Odiya Language and Maths Competencies as expressed by parents/guardians (CL TSP and CL non-TSP)

Block	Fully satisfied with Odiya learning		Fully satisfied with Maths learning	
	CL-TSP	CL- Non-TSP	CL-TSP	CL- Non-TSP
Koira	90%	75%	77%	55%
Harichandanpur	79%	82%	55%	53%
Joda	93%	81%	83%	62%
Danagadi	90%	90%	80%	65%
Sukinda	90%	95%	70%	75%
Grand Total	88%	85%	72%	62%

Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

When bifurcated for CL-TSP and CL non-TSP children, the percentage of parents being fully satisfied with Maths learning is consistently higher for the CL-TSP in all blocks, the average difference being that of 10 percent points. The same is not true for language learning where this percentage for CL-TSP is higher than that for CL non-TSP children in two blocks, lower in two blocks and at the same level in one block (table 3.10). This means that some local reasons could be at play, especially as the TSP does not have full control over government school teachers with whom children are spending much more time than the LEP teachers, with whom parents expressed their happiness with in unequivocal terms in every sample GP. Some parents

shared that earlier the children would spend their entire time loitering around the village once the school was over, but now they attend LEP classes which has not only improved their learning capacities but also made them more disciplined (FGD with parents, Harichandanpur, 14 December 2022). Most of them across blocks said that their children would find it difficult to read and write before the LEP classes, but now they have picked up these skills and are also able to converse in Odiya.

The school teachers also acknowledged that they had seen a positive change in children's engagement with learning. Most teachers marked an improvement in the understanding of basic concepts like addition and subtraction and said that this had impacted the classroom processes directly, lowering their burden to deal with children having very diverse learning levels. Some teachers characterised the LEP classes as 'revision classes' for children, positively impacting their learning. Many teachers also pointed out that students were more engaged in extra-curricular activities like drawings, sports and music. In one of the schools in Harichandanpur, the teachers spoke extensively about how the LEP teacher encouraged children to play kabaddi and by joining them when they played, the LEP teacher helped students open up and be more expressive. This also helped the teacher-pupil relationships in the regular classrooms (FGD with teachers, Harichandanpur, 15 December 2022)

The LEP approach does not use the system of marks. This sometimes means that they face pressure from parents to give marks and provide certificates to their students (FGDs with LEP teachers and FGDs with parents, December 2022-January 2023) This did not seem unusual, because the educational system in India is now geared towards increased testing and marks and certificates are seen as the only tangible outcome for educational attainments. A counter strategy to educate parents regarding why marks is not used might be helpful. Some LEP teachers also pointed towards the need for integrating the LEP curriculum with the subjects and syllabus that was taught in school. This was a need that was articulated by the parents also. This takes us to examine the impact on schools and school-teachers.

3.6. Impact of the Programme on Teachers and Schools

In order to assess the impact of the TSP on schools and school-teachers, we asked the parents/guardians questions related to teaching-learning processes in the classroom, regularity of teachers, school timings, the practice of corporal punishment and the functioning of child parliament in the schools. This was not just to assess the impact of the teacher training and the accountability practices that community-based organisations like SMC had established in the schools, but to also understand these as critical factors that add to the learning environment in the school and affect the experience of education for a child.

Ninety per cent parents admitted that they have noticed a positive change in the teaching process, and understandably there was not much difference between CL-TSP and CL non-TSP parents, as this change is for the entire school, and not specific to the children who attend LEP or any other TSP educational intervention (table 3.11). The patterns remained the same for responses to questions related to regular

attendance of teachers and the practice of corporal punishment. Almost all households said that the teachers did not practice corporal punishment any more. The FGDs with parents and SMC members also revealed that the teachers were more regular to schools after the TSP became operational and it meant that the schools opened on time. Parents also attributed better school functioning with improved teacher and student attendance to more active SMCs, as that had a direct impact on the learning of their children.

Table 3.23: Change in teaching processes in the classroom

Block	CL - TSP	CL - Non-TSP	Total
	Positive change	Positive change	Positive change
Koira	97%	80%	90%
Harichandanpur	85%	65%	78%
Joda	100%	100%	100%
Danagadi	93%	95%	94%
Sukinda	93%	85%	90%
Grand Total	93%	86%	90%

Source: Data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

However, a major difference was seen in the responses of the CL-TSP and CL non-TSP households with regard to the functioning of child parliament. Nearly 57% CL - TSP respondents/parents said it was functional whereas only 4% CL- non-TSP respondents mentioned that it was functional, showing their unawareness about it.

The positive change in the teaching-learning process, as acknowledged by parents has come through a combination of activities. Most teachers during the FGDs expressed that they had learnt through observing LEP classes and by actively trying to inculcate some of the LEP pedagogies in their classrooms. Many teachers gave examples of the TLMs that were used by the LEP teachers and said that TSP had also provided them with TLM kits, which they now used in their classrooms. When asked an example of how the teachers incorporated the LEP pedagogy in their class, the most common example that was given was teaching of basic mathematics through beads, shapes, ludo and language learning through pictures and cut-outs of letters.

Some teachers also expressed the view that they would like to include more activity-based learning in their classrooms, but due to the pressures of syllabus completion, they always face paucity of time. While acknowledging the fact that teachers are under pressure to complete syllabus, these statements also pointed out that the teachers viewed activities to be separate from learning that was based on the syllabus. Therefore, hinting towards the possibility that even though there was diffusion of the LEP pedagogy within the classrooms, the teachers perhaps needed more training to develop a deeper understanding of the pedagogical approach, going beyond just the use of TLM. We found that out of the 10 schools that were a part of the sample, teachers from only four schools had attended any form of training by TSP. Those who attended said that they were trained on the use of TLM and Foundational Learning and numeracy (FLN) which they found very useful.

The school teachers' notion of the LEP teaching being 'additional' to the syllabus, despite invariably acknowledging the LEP's role in enhancing children's learning levels, was also obvious from the displeasures that many of them expressed towards the LEP classes running beyond the stipulated time, which took time away from assembly and other morning rituals for children. In most schools, the expectation was that the LEP teachers should take full day classes as the school teachers, and it was considered unfair that the LEP teachers were allowed all flexibilities in terms of time, resources like TLMs, lower Pupil Teacher Ratio (PTR) and no pressure to complete the syllabus which was not the case with the school teachers. While most LEP teachers and school teachers mentioned an amicable relationship between the two, in a few schools the teachers did not see the role and functions of LEP teachers as equal to them and therefore, justified their demands for greater time to be spent by LEP teachers in teaching syllabus based curriculum, in other words, to act as substitute teachers. The feedback form parents suggested that often LEP teachers do act as substitute teachers if the regular teacher is absent or busy with administrative work – something that is not part of his or her duty. This points out to the obvious power dynamics between school teachers and the LEP teachers, and the legitimacy that comes from being part of the government as against coming from an Non-Government Organisation (NGO). This is also an areas that the TSP may want to address in future.

The issue of the need for more teachers, especially in view of the absence of subject teachers, kept resurfacing. Although the PTRs were not high in any of these schools, this expectation may be arising from the high load of teachers in administrative duties and other non-academic work like attending meetings and trainings which takes time away from their teaching responsibilities. This too needs to be investigated further.

3.7. Learning in the Residential Bridge Courses (RBCs)

We conducted FGDs and detailed interviews with children and teachers present in four RBCs in Joda (1 RBC) , Sukinda (1 RBC) and Koirā (2 RBCs) . The FGDs that were conducted with the children in the RBCs did not have the group activities for testing of competencies but were mainly structured around their experience at the RBC and their opinion on the impact on learning. What was seen overwhelmingly across all FGDs with children from RBCs was the change in learning levels. Almost all children said that when they first came to the RBCs, they were unable to converse in Odiya, so much so, that girls from one the RBCs said they were sceptical of talking to the RBC teachers at first because they did not know if the teachers would be able to understand what they were saying. It was gradually that they started to learn Odiya and were now fairly comfortable with the language. The girls from one of the RBC said that they often ask their RBC in-charge to show them their baseline test papers to see what their learning levels were when they first came in and how it had changed substantially. These girls also expressed the desire to retake the test so as to perform better. This not just showed the confidence in their learning levels, but also the desire to do better in studies that the girls in this RBC had. In the same RBC the girls also spoke extensively about the time that they had to study, which was not

available at home. They said that the expectation to earn, take care of the household chores and additional care responsibilities of younger siblings was very high in their homes which left them with no or little time to pursue studies or academic learning.

The RBC routine that was shared by the RBC teachers and students also allowed for ample time to the children to engage in learning but also to reflect, practice self-learning and co-curricular activities of their choice. The classes were structured around a pre-fixed curriculum and lesson plans that are sent to the RBC teachers. Group activities, presentations, asking questions and self-study are encouraged in all RBC classes. Early evenings are spent on various play and activities like dance, music, gardening to name a few by the children. The latter part of the evenings are dedicated to reflection and self-study, where children are encouraged to reflect upon what they studied during the day and practice revision of concepts. The ones going to schools, could use this time for home work.

All RBC teachers mentioned that they had to attend an orientation training of about 4 to 5 days. This was residential training. The content of the training ranged from the objectives of the RBC, contexts of children who come to RBCs to RBC pedagogies. The teachers also said that refresher or new trainings are organised on regular basis depending on need. Although some teachers also pointed out that the frequency and the regularity of the trainings should be increased. The teachers found the trainings very useful since teaching in the RBCs was very different from syllabus-based teaching. As one of the RBC teachers who had prior experience as a tuition teacher mentioned:

“this is nowhere close to teaching for a particular class or syllabus-based teaching, one needs to understand how children learn. Now I feel confident that I can teach any concept without a book” (RBC teacher interview, 12 January, 2023).

One critical aspect in which the need for training of RBC teachers came across significantly was related to sensitisation towards sexual abuse, counselling and understanding of sexualities. For instance, one girl’s RBC had students previously exposed to sexual experiences, some also in the form of abuse. Therefore, the teachers said that given their histories, these girls often behaved differently and were ‘easily’ attracted to men who came to the RBC for various work. They were also afraid that some of these girls had developed ‘feelings’ that was ‘inappropriate’ for other girls and would often indulge in physical proximity that the RBC teachers considered undesirable. This issue needs greater attention.

3.8. Conclusion

It is clear that children in these areas have demonstrated and are experiencing a significant shift in their learning – the feedback from the programme data, reading /comprehension /thinking tests as well as the group work activities through the children FGD, all point towards that. This becomes even more evident when one analyses this result from the perspective of both the household and public-school context of these children. Parental as well as school-teachers perceptions support this observation.

It is also obvious that the TSP has contributed significantly to this positive shift. While the learning related interventions such as LEP, RBC/NRBC or summer camps have contributed towards this, the change has also occurred due to an overall focus on improving school functioning by creating greater stakes for everyone concerned – parents, school-teachers, community, parents and children. It is the holistic approach where all factors that impact learning – school timings, teacher attendance, the child’s attendance, the school facilities, and classroom processes, earning resources, supportive and reflective pedagogical experiences – have been touched by the TSP, and the change can be attributed to this ‘whole’ rather than to any individual intervention. We will further discuss this in the next chapter on governance.

Individual and locational variations have been noticed and analysed in the chapter. The TSP team can take these findings further by unpacking the reasons for these variations and integrating the responses in their future planning. In that context, some clear pointers have emerged that need greater attention in future and those are listed here.

- **Deepening the pedagogical approach in the LEP and schools:** While bringing this kind of change in the context of rigid and dysfunctional public-school systems, low parental literacy and insecure livelihood conditions in a period of a few years is a tough task, these areas/schools are now in a position to move to the next stage. The current LEP approach has worked well in terms of developing reading and numerical competencies and developing confidence and this can be deepened further to integrate (i) gender and diversity concepts, (ii) reflexive skills and (iii) independent thinking in the content as well as pedagogical experiences. While it is not easy to introduce those in the government schools, there are several examples of successful integration, and the area seems ready for such integration. The following suggestion may also help in this regard.
- **Making the LEP curriculum more flexible and equipping teachers to adapt:** Some of the LEP teachers pointed towards the rigidity of the curriculum which is set at the block level and does not allow individual LEP teachers the flexibility to contextualise their classes as per the needs of their students. In explaining this, some LEP teachers gave the example of students with varied learning levels and competencies, and how the same activities and class structure does not work for all. The teachers also pointed that multi-grade teaching can sometimes be challenging and they expressed the need for more training in that regard. Multigrade teaching, when done well can be used as an advantage since it can allow for cross learning, peer learning, spiralling and revision of concepts. Having knowledge of a range of activities that can be used is usually helpful as compared to having only one set of activities that can be done with children.
- **Training of RBC teachers on sexuality and abuse:** Although some of the RBC teachers had attended a training on child counselling from NIMHANS, the need for more training on sexuality and abuse was clearly visible. These are difficult and complex concepts, and a one-time training cannot be expected to provide

clarity and direction to teachers who have the tough task of dealing with these issues that many a times challenge their own social norms and biases. But it is important to address this need, as the experiences of children in RBCs critically linked to their learning that can have a lifelong impact.

- **A clear strategy for school teachers' capacity development:** The TSP orients school-teachers and sometimes even organises training but given that they are also transferred, besides coming from a position of power, the school-teachers we interacted with seemed to be in need of much closer and deeper engagement, especially in terms of pedagogical practices. Since they have already adopted practices such as not using corporal punishment, coming on time, engaging with parents, etc. the time is ripe for introducing a block-wide capacity development plan. This can be linked with LEP curriculum and its deepening, and also be part of the vision where the teachers in six TSP blocks form a critical mass for a larger institutional change.

Chapter 4: Lockdown Learning Programme (LLP): A responsive model

The Indian government announced a nation-wide lockdown in March of 2020 in response to the global pandemic. There seemed to be no clarity on how long the lockdown would last but as we crossed the first couple of months of being in lockdown, it became clear that normalcy would take time and lockdown would stay for long. The impact of lockdown across various sectors have been analysed by various studies but education remained one sector which would need to respond quickly and dynamically, as the education sector in India is largely structured around physical classrooms and institutions, the closure of schools pushed students out and technological solutions were put in place to mitigate learning loss across different levels of education.

The Indian education system which is already plagued with numerous issues of inequality was put in even more distress during the pandemic and those on margins had to face the brunt of it more than anyone else. ‘The Effect of the Covid-19 Pandemic and Economic Distress on Education: A View from the Margins’ a report by Centre for Budget and Policy Studies, Bangalore, highlighted that during the time of emergencies like the Covid-19 pandemic, the impact on those at margins is the highest and no amount of technological intervention can help in mitigating these structural inequalities which are further aggravated in emergencies (CBPS, 2022). A similar study pondering upon the question of usage of digital mediums to impart education during the pandemic in India, highlighted that the concept of digital education which was popularized during the advent of COVID 19 outbreak failed to look at the structural inequalities which exist in the Indian society and something which was hailed a paradigm shift failed in reaping desired benefits (Ayoob et al., 2022). The digital divide and the absence of technological tools in the remote areas meant that children belonging to Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes were discriminated and the lack of technical access, poor internet infrastructure and allied costs of digital education made sure that the principle of universal access of education were put in jeopardy during the pandemic. (Ayoob et al., 2022) The one-size-fit all approach, therefore needs to be examined and the initiatives which tried to tackle the learning loss especially in the context of students from marginalised communities can serve as a potential tool for the future. In this context we look at the Lock-Down Learning Programme by TSP in this chapter.

As discussed in the previous chapters, the TSP is structured to address three critical areas simultaneously in order to create a model of ‘Universalisation of Elementary Education’ in the states of Odisha and Jharkhand. The three critical areas, namely, access, learning and governance were all put under extreme jeopardy as the lockdown was put in place. This chapter looks at the ‘Lockdown Learning Program’ (LLP) which was formulated in response to the lockdown induced closure of schools. The primary data collected during our fieldwork has been analysed in this chapter to look at how TSP managed to curb the learning loss during the lockdown through its LLP programme. We consider different perspectives as gathered from the field and juxtapose them with each other to understand ‘LLP’, in that we take the perspectives

of the TSP staff, community (including parents, children, SMC members and members of Panchayati Raj Institutions), and the staff employed by the state (CRC, government teachers and BEOs) into account.

4.1. What is LLP?

The year 2020 was planned as a growth for the TSP but with the outbreak of Covid-19 pandemic most of the activities hit a standstill. The focus then shifted to realign the goals to mitigate the negative impacts of the pandemic on the children, community and schools. The redefined focus was structured around the following goals:

- Supporting: Providing the support to local government to curtail the spread of the pandemic.
- Providing: Ensuring safety nets to the population for food and economic security.
- Tracking: Ensuring that children do not fall into child labour and child marriage.
- Maintaining: Ensuring that the villages which have achieved Child labour free zone (CLFZ) status maintain it.
- Creating: Creation of a model of distance learning which take in account the differential needs of students in remote areas and those who have poor digital access.
- Taking: Using the strengthened relationship with the sarpanch and PRIs to launch local governance capacity building initiatives.
- Support to students for their secondary board exams: 2597 children were to be supported in preparation for their secondary board exams.

Source: [The Silver Linings of Covid-19, ASPIRE Annual Report, 2020-21.](#)

On the learning front, the TSP team carried out a village-level digital access mapping to assess the status of the availability of internet access or availability of smartphone in a household means with children. TSP has been running the LEP with roughly 30,000 children in grades 3 to 8 in 19 blocks of Odisha and Jharkhand since 2015. As per the information provided by TSP, their survey revealed that out of the 30,000 students who were part of their LEP program only 14% had access to internet or smartphones. As a result, TSP decided to reach out to children physically; the teachers met children individually or in small groups in the villages and hamlets with just one student were also covered (Bhatia & Leighton, 2022). The teachers received the tasks or activities digitally (in some cases, in-person – on a weekly basis) and they shared these with children through in-person interactions. While the first visit was to introduce the tasks, children's work was assessed during the next visit before introducing the new activity. The 700 TSP teachers were assigned the villages along with 2700 freshly recruited volunteers who would teach the children in a hybrid-mode (using both online as well as offline means).

The first phase of LLP started in March 2020 with 35000 children, to target those 86% children who didn't have access to smartphones by physical visits which also covered the siblings of the LEP going children. In January 2021, this was expanded to reach non-LEP children as well, adding approximately 1,00,000 more students to the

programme, and the programme was called Lockdown Learning Expansion (LLX). The children in these programmes included children from both primary (3 to 5) and upper primary (6 to 8) grades, these children were spread over 5555 villages in 19 blocks in Odisha and Jharkhand. (Bhatia & Leighton, 2022). The implementation of the LLP was facilitated by the fact that TSP was a designated NGO partner of the Odisha government, which helped them with movements during the lockdown. The fact that 98% of its staff was local to the villages, it also helped them to move easily (Bhatia & Leighton, 2022).

The tasks which were given to children as part of LLP moved a step ahead from the normal classroom curricular based tasks, as the objective was also to keep the children meaningfully engaged in a period when most other activities had come to a standstill. For instance, students were motivated to learn from things which exist outside school boundaries like observing a cattle birth or observing how much time it takes for a seed to germinate and go through different stages of growth. There was also a focus on promoting gender equal norms by using materials such as UNICEF documentaries on 'Meena and Distribution of Mangoes' (*aam ka bantwara*) and similar other material (TSP staff interviews, December 2022).

4.2. What does the data from the field reveal?

The implementation of the LLP in the field was clearly based on a well-planned delivery model taking the availability or absence of local resources into account while also allowing local participation. The TSP team carried out a process of mobile mapping in the villages to understand the availability of internet in the areas and then children were grouped in a manner that would ensure a mix of children with mobile phones and children without mobile phones. The LEP teachers formed Whatsapp groups of teachers and communicated through it, tasks were assigned to children through text messages and in case of inaccessibility of mobile phones, the TSP volunteers visited directly to assist those children (Block coordinator interview, December 2022). Teaching children in groups of 5 or 6 followed by tasks given for self-study were two common pedagogical approaches followed in LLP. A large number of volunteers participated in LLP to make it more efficient and around 300 volunteers were reported to have participated in LLP for free (TSP staff interviews, December 2022). The feedback received from a range of stakeholders clearly showed that the programme had a positive impact in terms of continuation of learning for the participating children.

PRI members from different panchayats in our sample highlighted the importance of LLP and almost all of them were aware of the initiatives carried out by TSP during the lockdown. They mentioned that TSP teams used to assemble 5-6 children in groups at open spaces in the village to teach, and according to them it helped the children to remember whatever they were taught in the schools (Interview with PRI members, December 2022-January, 2023). Similarly, in our FGDs with SMC members, it was found that LLP was carried out in all the villages of our study and TSP teachers used to teach the children during lockdown in public spaces, they also highlighted that government teachers didn't do anything for their children and would only come to clean up the school, while the TSP teachers conducted physical classes (FGDs with SMC members, December 2022-January, 2023).

The TSP's approach was not restricted just to learning but they also helped the people by raising awareness about the pandemic, distributing dry ration, motivating children to wear masks and helping the return-migrants who faced stigma (because they were seen as outsiders and virus spreaders). Parents who had smartphones were requested by the TSP team to help others who did not have these devices (FGDs with SMC members, December 2022-January, 2023).

Parents also validated the responses which we gathered from other stakeholders. They mentioned that school teachers didn't do anything for their children and even if they would come to visit the village, once in the village they would not teach anything. According to them it was just because of TSP that their children managed to study during the lockdown, TSP hired volunteers to help their children with learning and due to the LLP, their children were not idle during the lockdown and continued their learning. Government schools focused on online education and videos were sent to parents on their mobiles. This was a problem because many of them could not access it at all and even those who had phones struggled to pay attention in these classes, while the classes by TSP were organised in the village itself and the children could easily attend the classes. The parents were also happy with the regularity of LLP by TSP and mentioned that each and every hamlet received help from TSP and the classes ran in two or three sessions every day from Monday to Saturday with Sunday being a day for dance and music classes. These activities prevented children from roaming around aimlessly. (FGDs with parents, December 2022-January, 2023).

Box 4.1: LLP at Ollala, Danagari, Odisha

Ollala panchayat is located in the Danagadi block of Jajapur district in Odisha. The SC communities have been living in this panchayat and now the new settlements of the ST communities have relocated here after being displaced by Tata and JSL. The impact of the pandemic in Ollala was as stark as anywhere else: the school remained closed and even though efforts towards online learning were carried out by the school, it remained largely a non-starter because the mobile phone and internet penetration in the area is very low. The lockdowns also impacted the livelihood options of the family.

When LLP was introduced, which, unlike LEP, targeted all students in the villages, Biplab Kumar Perai, a dedicated LEP teacher till then, was joined by three other volunteers to hold community-based group classes. The four teachers including Biplab conducted classes in four different hamlets - two Dalit hamlets and two adivasi hamlets. Classes were conducted 7 days a week in two sessions – a morning session from 7 am to 9 am and an evening session from 4 pm to 6 pm.

During weekdays these teachers focused on the lockdown curriculum including learning materials and weekly tasks designed at the state level. On weekends the focus was given to extracurricular activities including music, dance and drawing. They also distributed masks and sanitisers to the students. Students, SMC members and Parents appreciate lockdown learning classes conducted by ASPIRE and cite it as the most important contributor to children's learning during the time period:

“Our children were roaming here and there due to the school shut down. When ASPIRE initiated lockdown learning, our children focused more on study rather than spending time roaming”, Rajani Jena, parent

Besides holding these regular community-based classes, the LEP teachers, the newly hired lockdown learning volunteers, GPCM and other ASPIRE staff visited houses to make sure that children were learning in their homes during the school closure time. The SMC members testify that the TSP staff also helped community members to seek health assistance if required during the time period clearly showing their close connection with the community members.

One specific problem faced in Ollala during the pandemic was the social tension that arose due to stranded migrant workers in the area. The migrant workers from another locality of Odisha moving to their home town were stranded in the Ollala area. People in this unfortunate situation had to face ostracism from the community as they were branded as outsiders and virus spreaders initially. The TSP staff took the initiative in mitigating the tension and initiated efforts to arrange lodging facilities for the stranded migrant workers in community halls and schools. They were able to communicate with the community and gain support from the community in their efforts by orienting them regarding how viruses spread and why no one should be stigmatised.

The data collected from the household survey confirms the feedback received from the interviews and FGDs. Table 4.1 captures the responses of the parents about learning of their children during the lockdown induced school closures. More than 82% of parents in Odisha responded positively to the question regarding the child’s learning during Covid and mentioned that their children indeed managed to learn some things during the lockdown despite the schools being closed. In three of the five blocks, an overwhelming 88% responded in affirmative while the percentage was a little lower in the other two: Harichandanpur (70%) and Koira (78%). This was perhaps due to two reasons: (i) remoteness of at least one of the two sample GPs in each of these two blocks and (ii) high incidence of Covid 19 in one of the two GPs in Koira. It is important to mention that the responses in these two blocks are consistent with overall feedback on learning and other parameters as discussed in previous chapters. Eighty-four percent of respondents in the Jharkhand block also responded yes to this question.

Table 4.24: Learning during the Pandemic: Parents’ Perception (Number and percentage)

Block (Odisha)	Question: Did your child learn anything during the Covid induced school closures? Number and percentage (%)			
	Yes	No	Don’t know	Total
Koira	39 (78)	11 (22)	0 (0)	50 (100)
Harichandanpur	35 (70)	14 (28)	1 (2)	50 (100)
Joda	44 (88)	6 (12)	0 (0)	50 (100)

Danagadi	44 (88)	6 (12)	0 (0)	50 (100)
Sukinda	44 (88)	6 (12)	0 (0)	50 (100)
Total (Odisha)	206 (82)	43 (17)	1 (0.4)	250 (100)
Noamundi (Jharkhand)	42 (84)	8 (16)	0 0.00	50 (100)

Source: Data Collected by CBPS in Dec 2022-Jan 2023

The follow up question enquired the parents on how did the children continued to learn. It is clear from the responses that LLP played a major role. This was a question where the respondents could choose more than one answer, and the fact that the top three responses refer to the self-study, group-teaching by TSP teachers and the TSP teacher's home visits, shows that the continuation of learning was associated with LLP. The fact that neither the school teacher nor the TV educational programme was reaching the children at all, shows the limitations of such approaches. The distribution of responses was more or less similar in the Jharkhand block.

Table 4.25: What helped in Learning during the pandemic: Parents' perception (Odisha)

How did your child learn these things?	Number and percentage (%) of responses (N=206; those who said yes in response to the question on whether they learnt during Covid)
Self-study by child	97 (47.09)
TSP teacher made study groups in the village	92 (44.66)
TSP teacher used to come to the house	58 (28.15)
Family members used to teach	55 (26.70)
Tuition classes	34 (16.50)
Watched educational programmes on You Tube etc.	21 (10.19)
TSP/SMC/other committees linked with TSP used to send materials online through phone	17 (8.25)
School teacher used to send content/reading materials through phone	6 (2.91)
School teacher used to come to the house to teach	2 (0.97)
Watched educational programmes on TV	0 (0.00)

Source: Data Collected by CBPS in Dec 2022-Jan 2023

Note: this was a question where the respondents could choose more than one response

Table 4.26: What children learnt: Parents' perception (Odisha)

What did your child learn?	Number and percentage (%) of responses (N=206; those who said yes in response to the question on whether they learnt during Covid)
Learnt odiya/hindi language-speaking, reading and writing	155 (75.24)
Practice reading and writing	142 (68.93)
Learnt mathematics	84 (40.78)

Learnt English language	71 (34.47)
Learnt how to use internet	35 (16.99)
Learnt art and craft	33 (16.02)
Learnt about science and environment	22 (10.68)
Learnt how to make study maps	14 (6.80)
Learnt how to do self-observation	2 (0.97)
Learnt how to categorise and describe things	1 (0.48)
Learnt about women achievers	1 (0.48)

Source: Data Collected by CBPS in Dec 2022-Jan 2023

The survey also included a question on what children learnt using LLP tasks. Like the previous question, this too could have more than one answer, and the Table shows that language learning and practice is mentioned by a significantly high number followed by mathematics and English learning. Considering that these are foundational subjects and skills, these have the potential of preventing the learning loss that has been witnessed in many parts of the country as well as elsewhere. Also, important is to note that art, craft and science also found a place, which is a positive indicator while the fact that only a smaller proportion of parents reported these learnings also poses a challenge. It could either be an issue of less attention to those or parents not paying attention to these areas of learning as they do not consider these critical.

The data coming from Noamandi in Jharkhand shows slightly different pattern where mathematics learning does not find much of a place (10%) though language learning (88%) and practice (81%) remains a top learning area identified by parents.

4.3. What do the government functionaries think about LLP?

Discussion with CRCs revealed that the government teachers relied mostly on the online mode of education as schools and education offices were closed during the pandemic. They recognized that the technological penetration in these villages was abysmal and TSP's approach of reaching out to the children and conducting physical classes actually worked better. They mentioned that the online classes were attended by very few students and TSP teachers went from home to home and made sure that the children remained in touch of education and managed to mitigate the learning loss (Interviews with CRCs, December 2022-January, 2023).

Most government teachers who we interviewed shared similar views and highlighted that TSP teachers used to make groups of children and teach them either at the village *chaupal* (common community spaces) or at someone's house. The teachers, just like the CRC, also responded that their reliance on online methods didn't work and TSP's approach of going door to door actually helped in reducing the learning loss created by the pandemic. Headmaster (HM) of one of the schools highlighted that the usage of TLM by TSP during the lockdown helped in children's development (Teachers/HM's Interview, December, 2022). Senior level staff like the BEOs and ABEOs also acknowledged the work done by TSP during the lockdown and mentioned that TSP followed the covid guidelines and gathered students under

the trees to study, their approach of going home to home was also appreciated by the senior level staff (Interviews with education department officials, December 2022-January, 2023).

It is important to add here that there were some teachers who in our interactions were more apprehensive about the role of the LLP/LLX. For instance, one teacher opined that while the government teachers tried to do the same, they acknowledged that the TSP teachers were able to spend more time with the children (Teachers/HM's Interview, December, 2022). This needs to be viewed in the context of dynamics between school teachers and TSP teachers including the institutional roles and expectations, where an acknowledgement of TSP's role can also be viewed as an acceptance of the school/teachers' failure. Despite this backdrop, in most of the interviews and FGD which we conducted with the government functionaries including teachers, the respondents acknowledged the work which TSP has done during the lockdown and appreciated their efforts. This was perhaps also enabled by the fact that TSP was designated as an official Covid-relief partner of the Government of Odisha, and hence most of the government functionaries viewed them as partners rather than as competitors with respect to interventions during the pandemic.

4.4. Conclusion

In conclusion, we largely agree with the following conclusions arrived at by another evaluation conducted jointly by TSP and an external expert of this particular intervention, i.e., LLP:

- a. TSP's application of a hybrid model i.e., clubbing the students who had access to technology with those who didn't, and combining it with physical visits can be seen as a potential solution to mitigate the learning loss which can happen as reliance on technology increases (Bhatia & Leighton, 2022).
- b. TSP's LLP acted as a bridge between the students and learning especially during the lockdown, as government teachers couldn't conduct physical classes. The curriculum shift on learning from topics outside the classroom also made the learning process more engaging for the children in LLP and LLX. Spaces outside the classroom became learning spaces for children and the focus was on self-directed learning (Bhatia & Leighton, 2022).

Another important conclusion in the context of the impact of LLP during Covid relates to the learning areas. There is perhaps a need to understand why mathematics was not identified as a major learning that continued in Jharkhand (with the caveat that the total number of households in Jharkhand was only 50 as against 250 in Odisha, and therefore it could mean comparison is not full proof) and also why other learning areas are not identified as markers. Nonetheless, the fact that language learning and practice definitely continued everywhere is indeed a major achievement as language is the base for learning every other subject.

Going beyond the impact of LLP on learning and the continuation of the learning, some of the LLP related planning processes have apparently also impacted the planning and implementation of LEP and related activities (TSP staff interviews,

December 2022). We, however, discuss those while analysing aspects of training and governance.

Chapter 5: Governance: Strengthened Local Units

This chapter discusses the TSP interventions related to governance and community ownership of schools. As in the case of other verticals, this dimension is also being examined using data generated through diverse sources, and their triangulation.

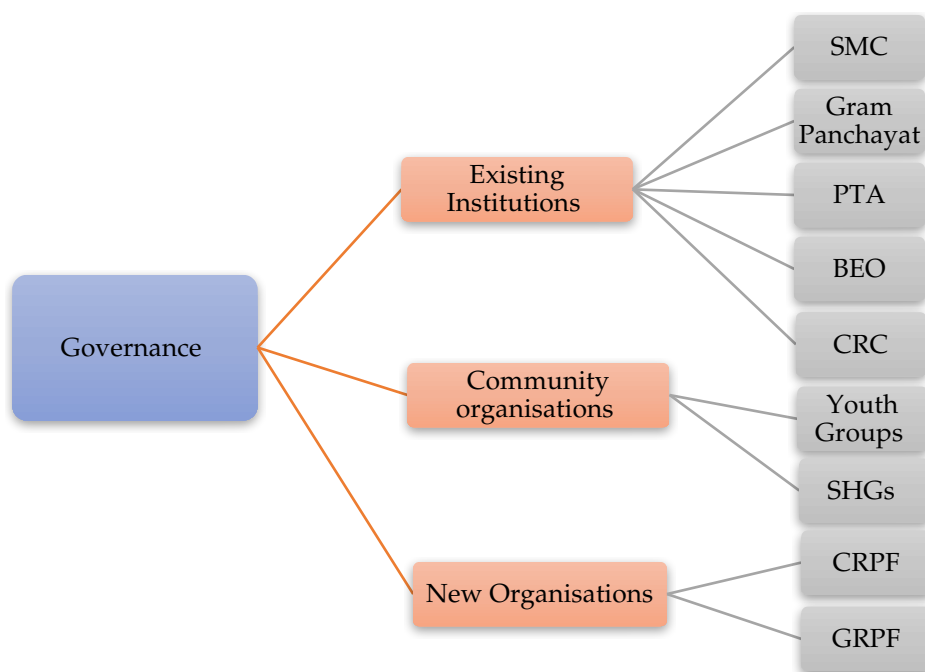
5.1. Introduction

The TSP recognises improving school governance as a major component of strengthening public education. Its agenda of improving school governance goes beyond school management. That is, it not only seeks to improve school management by targeting school-based institutions; but also, to improve community engagement which directly or indirectly affects the education of the children. In other words, the governance vertical of the TSP aims to build community ownership over education to strengthen public education.

The governance vertical, therefore, mainly focuses on strengthening the capacities and accountability of the institutions through three kinds of interventions:

- (i) The first is through its engagement with the already existing institutions responsible for school governance such as Parents Teacher Associations (PTA), School Management Committees (SMC), and Panchayat Raj Institutions (PRI). The TSP attempts to influence the functioning of these institutions by ensuring regular conduct of the mandatory meetings and encouraging meaningful participation of concerned members in the meetings through continuous engagement with them. The TSP also engages in capacity building of these institutions by providing orientations and training on their roles and responsibilities according to the Right to Education Act, 2009 guidelines. In addition, the TSP maintains regular contact with government offices such as that of Block Education Office (BEO) and Cluster Resource Centre (BRC).
- (ii) The second intervention by ASPIRE is through building new mechanisms such as Child Rights Protection Forum (CRPF) and Girls' Rights Protection Forum (GRPF). CRPF and GRPF are groups of volunteers working on issues related to child rights. GRPF is constituted of women volunteers and exclusively works on the rights of the girl child. These mechanisms act as special support groups from the community for the TSP to improve awareness about education and intervene in issues related to child rights.
- (iii) The third pillar of the governance axis is awareness building among the community about the importance of education through engagement with self-help groups, youth groups, Anganwadi centres and also participation in community meetings. Community engagement is facilitated through cultural events such as children's festivals, rallies on child rights and other similar activities. Observing child rights day is an example (Fig. 5.1).

Figure 5. 1: Framework of TSP engagements in the governance vertical



Source: As understood by the CBPS team

Gram panchayat community mobiliser (GPCM) is the key TSP staff in charge of implementing governance-related initiatives with the help of LEP teachers and CERC teachers if present in the community. Block coordinators and Cluster facilitators (CF) supervise the work of GPCM at the block level and cluster level respectively. Apart from monitoring, Block Coordinators and CF also have an important role in planning the initiatives. This chapter assesses the relevance and effectiveness of the initiatives in realising the objectives and challenges they face.

5.2. School Management Committee

Article 21 of the Right to Education Act, 2009 mandates that every government-funded school should have a School Management Committee to ensure community and parental involvement in the school functioning. The TSP before its interventions found that in practice SMCs existed only on paper and the SMC members in some cases were not even aware of their memberships. The meetings did not happen regularly and the resolutions were mostly decided by the headmasters⁸. Other studies have also confirmed these trends. For instance, a study that examined the community engagement with schools in five Indian states including Odisha and Jharkhand concluded that the process of SMC formations was not necessarily democratic, and the functioning was also not necessarily inclusive.⁹ Another study on the functioning of SMCs in Jharkhand also corroborated these findings and recommended the institutionalization of a democratic process of SMC formation and handholding of the elected SMC for their capacity building¹⁰. The TSP took many initiatives to activate the SMCs in the schools, including these two, and we found

⁸ 1000 schools programme: A work (Primer), *ASPIRE* (2019)

⁹ https://cbps.in/wp-content/uploads/SMC_SCF_5states.pdf

¹⁰ https://cbps.in/wp-content/uploads/Report_-SMC-Study_Jharkhand_March-2016_CBPS_FINAL.pdf

that the not only communities acknowledge the role of these interventions, the SMC members are actively engaged with school and education related issues.

By triangulating data from various sources (surveys, FGDs and interviews), we found that:

- (i) The TSP tries to make the election/selection process of the SMC members democratic and also encouraged the members to attend the meeting regularly,
- (ii) The TSP provides them with training and orientation on the responsibilities of the SMC member and the issues of child marriage and child labour,
- (iii) The TSP staff on the ground level always remain in touch with SMC members and also participate in SMC meetings to help them make plans for the development of the school and make meaningful interventions; in other words, handholding them to work more effectively and train them on the spot by this handholding.

The involvement of the TSP brought about many positive changes in the functioning of SMC in the school, as evidenced by our interactions. We list some of these here. Firstly, most of the SMC members in FGDs reported that the SMC meetings are happening regularly and could even report the days of the meetings. Secondly, the SMC members who participated in the FGDs were aware of the SMC's role and responsibilities and could articulate their views openly and strongly. They strongly expressed that SMC should have a definite role in school functioning for a variety of reasons including that the teachers need to be oriented about children's lives and circumstances, as they come from faraway places or other localities and are not familiar with the socio-economic environment of the locality where they teach. Thirdly, they shared that SMC members undertake the responsibility of regular monitoring in the schools; they mostly monitor the quality of mid-day meals served to the children, teaching quality and infrastructure development works in the schools (FGDs with SMC members, December 2022-January 2023). The same interactions also pointed towards certain remaining challenges, however, the fact they could identify the limitations and remaining challenges for their own school/area is also reflective of their involvement and capacities towards the SMC they belong to.

The improvement in the functioning of the SMCs in the schools has been explicitly reflected in our household survey wherein the guardians of the children were asked to provide feedback on the SMC in the nearest school. From Table 3.1, it is observed that more than 70 per cent of the guardians or families reported that there is a positive change in the four aspects of SMC i.e., functioning of SMC, SMC meetings, SMC composition and SMC selection/election process.

Box 5.1: SMC in Salijunga, Danagadi block, Odisha

The primary school Neelkanthpura school is situated in Salijunga panchayat of Danagadi block in the Jajpur district of Odisha. The TSP's first interaction with the SMC in school happened during the initiation of TSP in Salinjunga Panchayat in 2015. During the initial stage of the programme, state officials (BEO, DEO) were sceptical about TSP. The TSP staff were denied permission from the concerned BEO and DEO to open LEP classes within the school premise. The TSP team then

approached the SMC of the school, with an intent to not only convince them of the objectives of the programme but also to orient them about the authority of SMC in deciding on activities conducted in school. The SMC members along with other parents collected signatures for a petition demanding that the TSP should be allowed to conduct LEP classes within school premises and approached the BEO and DEO. Upon the demand of SMC members and parents, state officials permitted LEP classes in the school.

The incident was critical in creating solidarity between the TSP and SMC members. The incident was also an eye-opener for SMC members as they come to terms with their authority in the functioning of the school. The TSP continued to engage with the SMC members. Sahadev Sahoo, a junior teacher in PS Neelkanthpura says, 'the SMC members themselves were not aware of the roles and responsibilities of the committee but ASPIRE made them aware of the same'. The TSP provided a three-day training for the SMC members about school governance and monitoring. Parents also attest to the fact that SMC meetings are conducted regularly, and they are proactive and regular in inspecting school-related functions.

SMC members are selected in an open meeting of all parents. Dedication, availability of time and awareness of child-related issues became the major criteria for the selection process of SMC. SMC meetings are conducted every month. SMC members regularly inspect if midday meals are served properly, and whether teachers and children are attending classes regularly and on time. Apart from the functioning of the school, the learning level of children is also discussed in the SMC meetings. SMC members are also involved in the making of the School Development Plan. The SMC members have internalised the concept of community ownership of the school; when any problem is identified, they report it to the panchayat representatives or/and Block development officers. SMC members also credit the TSP staff for their assistance support to reach state officials in various ways including writing of applications. One SMC member, who has been a member for three years, says,

"earlier SMC members rarely monitored midday meal or teaching process but now we do. We also ensure that the classrooms remain clean which were dirty before. More rooms were also built due to SMC initiatives. All these things are happening because ASPIRE trained us on how school should function."

SMC members also ensure that teachers are coming to school more regularly. With the combined efforts of SMC members, teachers and the TSP staff, the learning level of children in this school has also improved. More children are now eligible for merit-based scholarships and are getting admissions to Navodaya Vidyalaya and Adarsha Vidyalaya.

Table 5.27: Feedback from guardians/families on SMC in the nearest schools

Questions	Response (positive change)	Number & (Percentage) (Total=250)
Have you noticed any difference in the functioning of	Yes	180 (72.00)

SMC at your child's school in recent years?		
Have you noticed any difference in SMC meetings at your child's school in recent years?	Yes	187 (74.8)
Have you noticed any difference in the SMC composition in recent years?	Yes	181 (72.4)
Have you noticed any difference in SMC election/selection in recent years?	Yes	181 (72.4)

Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

The household survey also informs us that there has been a change in the SMC election/selection after the TSP involvement and this might be due to the consideration of various criteria to select SMC members such as i) the person should be able to dedicate some time for SMC meeting, ii) person should be able to work for the school development, iii) person should be aware of children's issue (education, health etc.), and iv) education qualification. These criteria were also reported in most of the FGDs with SMC members, therefore confirming the feedback received from the survey. Most SMCs have a combination of new and old members, which is a positive sign indicating that both experience and new ideas have a place there. Nearly 50 per cent of the SMC members who participated in the FGDs have retained the SMC membership for two or more years. Moreover, about 24 per cent of them are in SMCs for five or more years (Table 5.2).

Table 5.28: Number of years served as SMC member

Block	For how many years has the person been an SMC member				
	1 or less than 1 yr	2 to 4 yrs	5 yrs and above	Do not know	Total
Koira	3	1	0	0	4
Harichandanpur	7	0	0	0	7
Joda	6	1	2	1	10
Danagadi	4	4	6	0	14
Sukinda	6	2	3	0	11
Total	26 (56.52)	8 (17.39)	11 (23.91)	1 (2.17)	46 (100.00)

Source: FGD by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

Participation in the SMC meetings currently appeared to be low in some places, particularly in the mining areas (FGDs with SMC members and Interviews with ASPIRE staff, December 2022-January 2023). We observed from our survey that most of the families are poor as the members who participated in the FGDs were found to be involved in labour work (19.15%), farming (6.38%) and unpaid domestic work (48.94%) (Table 5.3). They find it very hard to lose a day's earnings due to the SMC meeting. Thus, their livelihood challenges adversely affect their participation in SMC meetings. Therefore, it was obvious that it is going to be a continuous challenge to secure their participation and orient them to the responsibilities, especially in case of new members. For instance, some new members of Kashira panchayat in Koira block have become SMC members recently after returning from their place of migration and expressed their inability to talk about the changes happening to the school over time and shared their concern about the need to go for wage work every day.

Table 5.29: Occupational profile of SMC members

Block	Occupational profile of SMC members				
	Wage Work	Farmer-own land	Unpaid domestic work	Others	Total
Koira	2	0	1	1	4
Harichandanpur	2	0	5	0	7
Joda	3	0	6	2	11
Danagadi	2	1	7	4	14
Sukinda	0	2	4	5	11
Total	9 (19.15)	3 (6.38)	23 (48.94)	12 (25.53)	47 (100.00)

Source: FGD by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

Table 5.30: Education qualification of SMC members

Block	SMC Highest Qualification								
	Illiterate	Literate with no formal schooling	Primary	Upper Primary	10th pass	12th pass	Graduate / PG	Do not know	Total
Koira	1	0	2	0	1	0	0	0	4
Harichandanpur	4	0	1	1	0	1	0	0	7
Joda	4	0	2	1	1	2	0	1	11
Danagadi	2	0	1	4	7	0	0	0	14
Sukinda	1	0	0	1	3	2	4	0	11
Total	12 (25.53)	0 (0)	6 (12.77)	7 (14.89)	12 (25.53)	5 (10.64)	4 (8.51)	1 (2.13)	47 (100)

Source: FGD by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

The need for training also emerges from the fact that the level of education is low among the SMC members. Out of the members who participated in FGDs, more than 50 per cent have not completed matriculation and of this 50 per cent, 25 per cent are illiterates (Table 5.4). Although regular handholding contributes to capacity building, it may also be helpful to have a series of well-connected training programmes, especially given the poor educational levels of the members. While most SMC members had received training in Salijanga panchayat of Danagadi block, Gobarghati panchayat of Sukinda block and Deojhar panchayat of Joda block, many in other blocks mentioned that they had not received formal training till then from TSP. The SMC members who had received training in these three GPs were aware of the school development plan (SDP) while most of them in other GPs did not appear to be fully aware of the SDP.

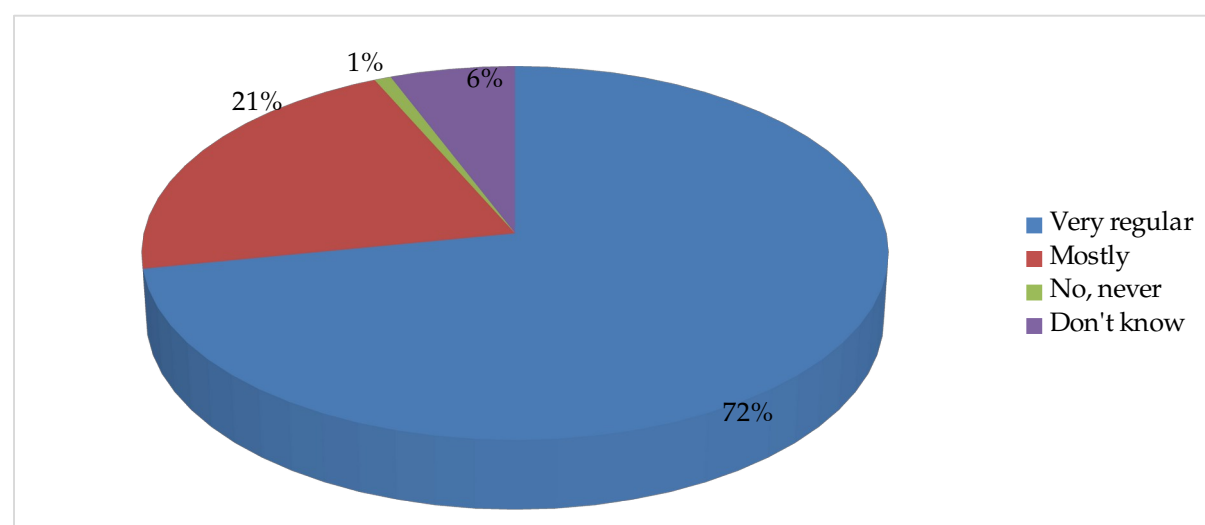
5.3. Parent-Teacher Association

TSP considers parents and community members key stakeholders in the improvement of the educational status of the children and therefore, tries to involve them directly or indirectly in their interventions. It also recognizes that illiteracy, economic backwardness, and alcoholism are the major reasons behind the lack of awareness and concern among parents for their children's education. As a result, they are unable to provide their children guidance in terms of education (Interviews with ASPIRE staff, December 2022-January 2023).

The TSP's engagements with parents of school-going children take place through many activities: i) mobilizing parents to attend PTA meetings, ii) conducting monthly meetings with parents and informing them about their children's education, iii) LEP teacher pays home visits, and iv) parents are informed about the educational status of their children i.e., mid and end line test results. The TSP staff also remain present in the PTA meetings. Our investigation show that these initiatives/strategies have brought about many positive changes in the community as well as in the school. Firstly, as per the opinion of the parents in FGDs, parents' participation in the PTA meeting has increased and they are now vocal about the development of the school. In our household survey also, we found that 93 per cent of the interviewees

responded that regular parent-teacher meetings are conducted regularly in the schools where their children study (Fig. 5.2).

Figure 5. 2: Are regular parent teacher meetings conducted in the school your child studies?



Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

Secondly, guardians now show concern about their children’s learning. They send their children to LEP classes and schools regularly. In the focus group discussions with parents, it was observed that parents have high aspirations for their children and they want to educate them well. They stated that they do not want to see their children working as daily wage labourers like them. In many FGDs parents listed out the problems they are facing due to their illiteracy and lack of education such as problems in travelling to faraway places, being unable to access various government services and becoming victims of bribery, etc. They strongly felt that their children should not face such kinds of problems when they grow up.

The parents we interacted with in the FGDs acknowledged that their attitude towards girls’ education has changed substantially after the TSP contact. In most of the FGDs, parents opined that the girls should also get equal opportunities in terms of education. They mentioned that earlier when they were going for labour work or to the forest to collect wood, they were leaving aside the household chores under the responsibility of female children in the house. But now they do not force their daughters to do the household work and send them to school. Further, in an interview, a GPCM from Harichandanpur block informed that due to awareness about girl’s education among the people, now two girls are studying in Kalinga Institute of Social Science (KISS), Bhubaneswar and about 10-12 from the village are currently pursuing their higher studies. Parents also reported cases of corruption in midday meals and distribution of certificates in two GPs and expected the SMC to play a more active role in controlling that, reflecting their awareness about the school.

Parents also shared that the TSP engagement has also helped in other aspects of their lives. It was shared that alcoholism among parents has also declined to some extent.

Fourthly, earlier people used to take the help of exorcism, but now they go to health care centres for treatment.

The parents expected the TSP to address the issue of the shortage of teachers in the school and ensure that teachers pay more attention to the children. Parents also explicitly stated that the ban on corporal punishment in the school has deteriorated the learning outcomes of the children as they became undisciplined (FGD with parents, December 2022-January 2023). While it is clear that the TSP cannot solve all the school-related problems on its own, these feedbacks are indicative of the need for continued engagement with parents for their orientation on issues such as corporal punishment and with schools and SMCs on issues of corruption and accountability in specific areas.

5.4. Panchayati Raj Institutions

A panchayat is assigned the responsibility to monitor and implement the RTE Act at the panchayat level. The sarpanch handles all the education-related issues with the help of different committees such as the School Management Committee at the school level and the Standing Committee on Education at the panchayat level and in addition, with the Child Rights Protection Forum at the habitation level in the TSP areas. The TSP primarily aims to train and orient the panchayats to ensure the good functioning of the schools and quality education reaching every child.

To assess the impact of the TSP on education through PRI, we pursued many questions related to panchayat's involvement in education such as panchayat's responsibilities, power and rights related to education, activities done by them and the TSP's engagement with them. Since the PRI members were newly elected (one-two month before the fieldwork), many of them were not very familiar with the TSP interventions and the panchayat's initiative for the development of schools. However, some of them had been a member earlier and were more familiar with the TSP's work. The findings presented here need to be interpreted with this fact in mind.

Most PRI members could spell out their responsibilities towards education such as ensuring all children are in school or Anganwadi (as applicable) and that schools are functioning well, quality checks in school through school visits, conducting awareness programmes about education, eradicating child labour and marriage, etc. Some of them share their experiences of closely working with the TSP staff in bringing back the dropout children to schools and eradicate child marriage and labour. One PRI member shared how with the help of the TSP they had conducted a procession called *Shiksha Ratha* to spread awareness about the importance of the prevention of child labour. Another PRI member shared with us that there was an orphan girl in the panchayat who dropped out of school and her schooling was arranged by putting her in RBC for a longer period. She completed her intermediate and was currently pursuing a nursing degree.

Table 5.31: Parents/guardians' feedback on the functioning of PRI

Questions Have you noticed:	Response	Number (Percentage) (Total=250)
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any difference in the functioning of the gram panchayat in recent years?	Yes, positive change	203 (81.2)
any difference in the gram sabha in recent years?	Yes, positive change	190 (76.00)
any difference in the gram panchayat elections-like reasons behind electing a particular gram panchayat mukhiya in recent years?	Yes, positive change	203 (81.2)
any difference in engagement with education that the gram panchayat has in recent years?	Yes, positive change	177 (70.8)
any difference in child marriage in your village and panchayat in recent years?	Yes, positive change	234 (93.6)
any difference in child labour in your village and panchayat in recent years?	Yes, positive change	241 (96.4)

Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

In our household survey, we found encouraging feedback on the improvement in the functioning of panchayats in recent years. About 81 per cent of the respondents in our survey said that there has been a positive change in the functioning of gram panchayat and panchayat elections in recent years. About 71 per cent of the interviewees feels that there has been a positive change in the engagement of panchayat with education in recent years. Similarly, more than 90 per cent of the interviewees also answered that there has been a positive change in child marriage in their villages and panchayats in recent years (Table 5.5). Moreover, a GPCM, on the changes in the community due to the TSP intervention, stated that now people have become aware of their rights related even to MGNREGS and using it better. The PRI members could list a number of development-related activities that they have facilitated in the schools, e.g., the renovation of buildings, toilet and boundary wall construction, provision of borewells and playing accessories. In one village, they provided the building for the RBC centre. Most of them considered the shortage of teachers in schools a major issue and also shared how they have managed to get Periphery Development Committee¹¹ (PDC) teachers in their schools from mining companies. Most of them also reported that dropping out of school after upper primary due to the unavailability of high schools and colleges has been a serious concern.

The TSP organises training sessions for PRI members on their roles and responsibilities according to the Right to Education Act, of 2009. It also organizes training whenever any amendment is brought to the RTE framework or whenever the need arises¹². Given that many of the PRI members we interviewed were new, out of our 10 PRI interviews, only three reported having received any such training and

¹¹ Under the Scheduled Areas Development of Mine Bearing Area Regulation-2013 the Peripheral Development Committee collects funds from the mining lessees. This fund is utilised by the PDC for setting up and maintenance of community assets such as water resources, hospitals, schools, drinking water, sanitation, communication, and road infrastructure in Scheduled Areas. <https://www.dailypioneer.com/2013/state-editions/new-move-for-funds-from-mines-for-tribals-welfare.html>

¹² 1000 schools programme: A work (Primer), *ASPIRE* (2019)

only these three could confidently tell that they have the Standing Committee on Education in their panchayats. Their understanding of their power in the panchayat was also weak and many were not aware of the Right to Education Act. However, they all know about the LEP classes happening in their schools and they occasionally visit for quality checks, and have positive feedback on it. They were aware of the objectives of the TSP, i.e., no dropout children, eradication of child marriage and child labour. However, most of them did not know what is Village Education Register (VER).

We also tried to assess the understanding of the concept of Child Labour Free Zone (CLFZ) among the PRI members and found that they knew about the concept and the process. They could share that a panchayat is declared CLFZ when there is no single out-of-school child in the panchayat. For this, a survey is conducted to confirm that every child of the panchayat is in school. It is also ensured that the status remains so by conducting a headcount of children after the second class and recess in the school on a particular day of the week. When a panchayat is found with zero out-of-school children, a rally or procession is organized jointly by the TSP staff, village and PRI communities on the occasion of any particular day of importance like Mahila Diwas, Children's Day. Through this rally, they also spread awareness about child rights and declared the panchayat as CLFZ. In our sample of 10 panchayats, only two (Gobarghati in Sukinda block and Bareiguda in Harichandanpur block) have been declared as Child Labour Free Zone till now (Interviews with PRI members, December 2022-January 2023). While this finding could be attributed to PRI members unawareness regarding the CLFZ status of their panchayats, even such a finding demands attention as panchayats should be driving the process of child labour eradication for local ownership and sustainability.

These PRI-related outcomes show that while ASPIRE interventions and work with Panchayats have made a major difference. However, these call for continuous engagement till the point it reaches a stage where the institutions become very mature and people are highly aware.

5.5. Child rights protection committee (CRPC)

CRPC is envisioned as a community ally of the TSP. CRPC is also known as the Child Rights Protection Forum (CRPF) and Shishu Adhikar Suraksha Samiti (SASS) in Odisha and Bal Adhikar Suraksha Samiti (BASS) in Jharkhand. CRPC members typically consist of representatives from parents, SMC members, panchayat members, ASHA workers, Anganwadi workers, and ANM along with other concerned individuals from the village. The objective for forming CRPF is to be the torchbearers of child rights, prevent incidents of child labour, child marriage, child trafficking etc. along with supporting ASPIRE staff in tasks such as ensuring full enrollment of children in school, house visits, maintenance of VER data etc. CRPFs are formed at habitation, Panchayat and block levels.

CRPFs are also envisioned as a major contributor to sustainability and the self-reliance of the community in dealing with the matters of child rights without support from external agencies such as the TSP itself. ASPIRE staff repeatedly expressed their

hope in having CRPC continue the work even in the absence of ASPIRE. According to a joint review of the 1000 school programme by Tata Steel Foundation and ASPIRE, CRPFs have been formed in all Panchayats in the selected five blocks except in Danagadi where only 15 panchayats out of 23 have formed a CRPF.¹³

Table 5.6: CRPFs' presence in different blocks

Block	Total GP	Panchayats having CRPF
Sukinda	25	25
Harichandanpur	25	25
Danagadi	23	15
Joda	19	19
Koira	15	15

Source: Joint review by Tata Steel Foundation and ASPIRE April-Nov 2021

CRPCs were constituted in all panchayats visited as part of this study as confirmed by the respective GPCMs. We heard examples of child marriages being prevented by CRPF. For instance, in one case, a 6th class girl was married to a driver in Joda block whose marriage was made null and void through the collective effort of TSP and CRPF. The girl was able to continue her education post this incident. As mentioned earlier in Chapter 2, 94 per cent of the households in the survey said that there is a positive change in the situation related to child marriage.

CRPF's involvement in issues other than child protection is not common but such examples exist. One such example is that of the CRPF engaging in a letter campaign to address the issue of children being unable to get admission to school due to not having an Aadhaar card in one block. As an ally, CRPF members also help in community outreach activities of the TSP such as cultural events and rallies.

Interviews with GPCM suggest that they work when an incident of child labour, child marriage or child trafficking occurs or when an event is organized by the TSP. Day-to-day involvement of CRPF members in school monitoring, child tracking, and mainstreaming of students did not appear to be very prominent except in most places. Though the state TSP coordinator expressed their intention to shift the responsibility of maintaining VER to CRPF members, in all the visited villages, it is still maintained by GPCM. Only One GPCM mentioned the involvement of CRPF in house visits.

It was also noted that though the panchayat-level CRPFs are fairly active, the same did not seem to be true for the village-level CRPFs, probably due to the lack of enough enthusiastic people at the village level (Block coordinator Interview, December, 2022). Majority of the households (68%) were also not aware of this committee, even when all the names were used to ask about this familiarity. Though panchayat members are supposed to be part of this committee, no panchayat representative except from one panchayat, who mentioned about Girls' Right Protection Forum could mention CRPC as one of the mechanisms associated with the TSP. There appeared to be variation in the fulfilment of the objectives of CRPF in

¹³ Latest data may be different.

different blocks and the presence of the Girls' Right Protection Forum as a separate group also appeared to be weak by all accounts. One reason could be that these committees are composed of PRI members, SMC members and TSP staff, and people associate particular people with their prime responsibilities rather than this committee.

5.6. SHGs and youth groups, Anganwadi centres

The TSP conducts outreach activities with the support of Self-Help Groups and youth groups in the villages. For instance, on Mother's Day, they jointly organise the programme and try to spread awareness among mothers about child malnutrition, and how they need to take care of their children. Then they also discuss the issue of child labour and marriage with them. On National Youth Day, they organise a programme for youths and aware them of child labour and marriage and tell them how they can play a role to eradicate these problems. Rallies are another method used by the TSP. For example, a large *mashal* (torch) rally was conducted in Koira block about the importance of education and child rights.

They were also able to motivate youth groups to engage in awareness generation programmes beyond the regular sports events conducted by them and routinely participate in such events. The relationship between the TSP staff and youth is also extended through Coimmunity Education Resource Centre (CERC) where young people are given basic computer education. CERC centres are also helpful for youth to apply for or prepare for Jobs. Maintaining regular connections with them through different ways like these helps to build rapport and also invokes youths for volunteership in promoting the agenda of the TSP more diligently.

The TSP staff participate in the SHG meetings and talk about child rights, the importance of educating children, child marriage and child labour. They also help in the functioning of SHG by helping them in reaching out to government officials through writing applications and letters. SHGs greatly help the TSP when any hostile situation occurs. In a particular example from Sukinda block, a GPCM had to face harassment from some society members due to his/her involvement in preventing a case of child marriage. But she/he was able to withstand the pressure with the support of SHG members. Along with the school, Anganwadi centres are also a major contact point for the TSP's community interaction. Anganwadi acts as a location for orientation for adolescent girls. The TSP staff take part in matru committees and jaanch committees' meetings. Instead of organising separate training sessions for SHG members or youth groups, the TSP staff attend the regular meetings of SHGs to push forward the agenda of child rights and child education.

The feedback regarding the TSP working with local NGOs was mixed. The state coordinator mentioned that TSP works with other NGOs working in the area of livelihoods, the block coordinators of all the sample blocks share that they do not work together with any other NGOs even though they maintain cordial relations.

5.7. The government institutions (CRC, BEO)

As is well-known, the state's administrative machinery at the district and sub-district levels depends on the channel of District Education Officer (DEO) and the Block Education Officer (BEO) for its regular school administration. The role of DEO and BEO consist of administering, monitoring, supervising, and guiding the educational sector of the district and block respectively. Cluster resource coordinators selected from the government school teacher community are appointed by Samagra Shiksha Abhiyaan to facilitate teacher training, school management and community mobilization initiatives at the below-block level in the educational sector.

The very nature of the TSP's work is such that the relationship between them and the government has multiple dimensions. While the need for active coordination and collaboration is critical, there is also always tension because of contestations and contradictions. This means facing the continuous challenge of engagement and since transfers are common, it also means starting all over again when a new official takes place of the old. The data discrepancies between those emanating from the government sources and the TSP is one example that could cause tension and contestation. We observed that all these challenges were present and the TSP staff were used to handling those as they came, as is clear from the statement of a TSP staff,

"One of the previous BEOs now retired was not very supportive in the beginning. At that time, we had 72 girls total in RBC centres in Harichandanpur block. But according to government records, there were only 51 out-of-school children. So, he considered it a challenge to the state. But once we communicated our desire to see children learning and asked him to observe things by himself, he was convinced."
(TSP staff, December 2022).

Several examples of government officials initially refusing to grant permission for LEP classes, later turning into support emerged through their conversations with the ASPIRE staffs. What is important is that these negotiations were mediated through the presence of community members and SMCs, reflecting their involvement and capacities.

The situation seems to have largely changed over the years, as all the BEOs interviewed as part of the study maintained a similar stand in terms of engagement between the TSP and the BEO office. They were familiar with and acknowledged the work of the TSP. The TSP staff also consistently maintained that state officials are on cordial terms with them. However, the direct interactions between TSP staff and education officers are still limited in nature, and this fact was reflected in interviews with both TSP staff and education officers. Few BEOs even suggested that TSP should try to collaborate more with the BEO office in future. But the state coordinator explained that this is deliberate as they aim at making the community self-sufficient and ask for themselves rather than use their contacts for getting approvals and support: *"ASPIRE is in good terms with district education administration. So, it will be easier to get necessary resources like empty buildings for RBC centres, if we request. But we*

ask community members to request BEO and collect signature so they get familiar with the ways citizens can demand their rights.”

There is a lot more direct interaction between the TSP staff and CRCs compared to BEOs mostly because both of their work is located around schools. CRCs are regularly invited to the events conducted by the TSP as guests. CRCs also participate in training sessions for LEP teachers and volunteer teachers. CRCs across clusters also said that they take direct support from the TSP teachers to deal with teacher shortages when they are called upon as substitute teachers.

Although orientation for CRCs is part of the TSP primer document and mentioned by the state TSP coordinator, none of the CRCs interviewed reported having received any such formal training, though they were well-aware of the programme. CRCs are entrusted by the state government with the responsibility of community mobilization, improving classroom retention and preventing dropouts. CRCs acknowledge that ASPIRE intervention in reducing the dropout rate and building community awareness complement the works of CRC.

The TSP staff also use CRC as a mediator of tension between the TSP staff and school teachers if any. CRCs are more accessible to the field-level TSP staff. In one GP, when the HM of a school denied admission of some students due to the lack of proper documentation, TSP staff contacted the CRC to facilitate the admission of those children. Some TSP staff shared that though they involve CRCs to resolve these issues, they generally avoid direct confrontations with teachers.

What emerged is that since the TSP-government relationship is critical yet fragile, caution is used and the focus is either on resolving issues amicably or enabling the community to make their demands. This is a strategic choice that has worked for the TSP so far except that it has not helped in addressing some of the major institutional issues. For instance, the issue of documentation where children are denied admission to school because they are unable to produce Aadhaar card or caste certificate is resolved for the particular child or school but no effort to change that requirement itself has been made so far.

5.8. Conclusion

Overall, what emerges is that the TSP has tried to work with what can be loosely referred to as an ecological approach where they engage with all important institutions related to school education in some manner. The principle of engagement is also that these institutions themselves should be able to negotiate and demand – and hence the TSP views itself as a facilitator and capacity-builder, rather than an interventionist.

Their engagement with SMCs is most intense and in general, the SMCs in these areas came across as far more inclusive and active, in comparison to what they had been in the past (as suggested by our survey, interviews and FGDs), and also as compared to how they usually function (as suggested by the literature). The same seemed to be true for panchayats but the feedback was not as strong or as unequivocal as was the case for SMCs. This could partly be due to the fact that these GPs were relatively newly formed. Known by different names, CRPF is a new association created with

the TSP's support working against child labour and child marriage both at the block and village levels. This appeared to be more active at the block level as compared to the village level, and many success stories exist. The TSP also works actively with Youth groups, SHGs, Anganwadi workers and the like – creating awareness both about the organisation and their objectives and also engaging them too to the cause. Despite variations, these have largely been successful in creating a common cause for universal school education.

We have the following challenges that we think the TSP needs to pay attention to:

- **The need for more intensive training of selected SMC / PRI members:** this is especially true for those coming from the most deprived within a context of marginalisation (e.g., illiterates, landless, women) focusing on rights, skills and action.
- **The need for strategizing advocacy:** this is needed for a few systemic changes in terms of influencing a few governance practices in the state schools (e.g., need for Aadhar card for admission) that impact inclusion adversely.
- **The need for a clear strategy and pathway for an exit strategy:** this could be a long-term plan but it needs to exist.

Chapter 6: Examining TSP's Replicability Potential

6.1. Introduction

An effort was made to examine the TSP's replicability potential by assessing the programme implementation and impact in one block, Noamundi, in West Singhbhum district of Jharkhand state. The TSP, which initially started in six blocks of Odisha in 2015 (which is the main subject of evaluation) was extended to 13 more blocks in Odisha, 18 blocks in Jharkhand, and one block in West Bengal between 2016 to 2021¹⁴. The extended project was called Education Signature Programme (ESP). This programme was started in the Nomaundi and Jagannathpur blocks of West-Singhbhum district in 2016.

The methods of interventions followed under ESP are similar to that of the TSP. Both in Odisha and Jharkhand, ASPIRE/TSF operates on the principle of large-scale intervention, area saturation model, community-centric approach, and local hiring. Further, ESP's interventions are also organised in three verticals - Access, Learning and Governance. The activities such as village level survey, establishment of RBC and NRBC centres and interventions in schools through LEP and teacher training etc. were replicated in Jharkhand.

In order to facilitate cross learning and knowledge sharing, the ESP staff from Noamundi were taken to the Harichandanpur block in Odisha for an exposure visit. The Cluster Facilitator of Noamundi remarked that they could learn about the working of NRBC and RBC from their visit to Harichandanpur. Moreover, there has also been instances of transfer of TSP staff in Odisha to Jharkhand (Interviews with ASPIRE staff, December 2022-January 2023), which ensured continuity.

Before we analyse the findings from our evaluative research in Noamundi, we discuss the socio-economic and educational profile of Odisha and Jharkhand to understand the similarities or dissimilarities, and assess the challenges of replicability.

6.2. Socio-economic and educational Profile of Odisha and Jharkhand

Odisha and Jharkhand have been amongst the least developed states in terms of socio-economic indicators. In terms of per capita income, Jharkhand is ranked 26th and Odisha, 20th, out of 28 states in 2020-21 (Jharkhand Economic Survey 2022-23). Moreover, as per the Tendulkar Method on Mixed Reference Period of 2011-12, about 33 and 37 percents of the state's population of Odisha and Jharkhand respectively live below the poverty line, which is much higher than the national average i.e., 22 per cent¹⁵.

Table 6.32: Dropout rates among different social groups in Jharkhand and Odisha (2021-22)

Social	Primary dropout rate*	Upper primary dropout	Secondary dropout rate***
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¹⁴ <https://aspire-india.org/projects/education-signature-program/>

¹⁵ <https://www.rbi.org.in/scripts/PublicationsView.aspx?id=19887>

Group				rate**					
	Jharkhand	Odisha	All India	Jharkhand	Odisha	All India	Jharkhand	Odisha	All India
Scheduled Tribe	2.90	0.42	2.83	5.37	8.77	6.03	12.71	33.12	16.62
Scheduled Caste	2.33	0.00	1.46	5.80	8.14	3.56	11.39	31.22	12.55
Other Backward Castes	0.00	0.00	0.51	2.71	7.66	2.99	11.28	33.30	12.87
General	7.39	0.00	2.54	2.87	2.66	1.51	0.00	0.00	10.94
Total	1.77	0.00	1.45	3.85	7.31	3.02	9.31	27.29	12.61

Source: UDISE+ Report (2021-22), Department of School Education & Literacy, Ministry of Education, Government of India

Note: *Proportion of pupil from class 1 to 5, enrolled at a given school year who are no longer enrolled at any grade in the following school year.

** Proportion of pupil from class 6 to 8, enrolled at a given school year who are no longer enrolled at any grade in the following school year.

*** Proportion of pupil from class 9 to 10, enrolled at a given school year who are no longer enrolled at any grade in the following school year

These two states also consist of a sizable percentage of the scheduled tribe and scheduled caste population. According to the Census of India (2011), in Odisha, scheduled castes constitute 17 per cent and scheduled tribes, 24 per cent of the state population while in Jharkhand, the figures stand at 12 per cent and 26 per cent respectively. The poverty rate among these social groups in these states is also relatively high (Pradhan et al, 2022). Furthermore, the dropouts among these marginalised communities in the two states are higher than the national average except for the primary dropout of Odisha. The national average of upper primary dropout is 3.02, while scheduled tribe's dropout rates in Jharkhand and Odisha are 5.37 and 8.77 respectively. In the case of secondary dropout rate, Odisha has the higher dropout rates for all social groups except the general category (Table 6.1).

Table 6.33: Dropout among different social groups in West Singhbhum (2021-22)

Social Group	Dropout in West Singhbhum		
	Primary dropout rate	Upper primary dropout rate	Secondary dropout rate
Scheduled Tribe	0.00	4.30	18.99
Scheduled Caste	7.45	7.78	17.84
Other Backward Castes	0.00	1.96	14.49
General	0.24	6.57	0.00
Jharkhand total	1.77	3.85	9.31

Source: UDISE+ Report (2021-22), Department of School Education & Literacy, Ministry of Education, Government of India

West Singhbhum is a scheduled tribe-concentrated district in the state of Jharkhand with 67.3 per cent of the district population being from the ST communities and is

also an Educationally Backward District¹⁶. The scheduled caste population constitutes about 3.8 per cent. The dropout rates of the children of these social groups are relatively high at the upper primary and secondary levels. While scheduled caste children's dropout rate is higher than that of scheduled tribe children at the primary and upper primary levels, the scheduled tribe children's dropout is higher than others at the secondary level (Table 6.2)

It is clear that Odisha and Jharkhand, especially the project areas selected for the TSP and ESP interventions are similar, and there is also a geographical continuum as they these blocks are adjacent to each other. However, though these similarities and continuum make the replication easier, the administrative, policy and language differences between the two states could make the replication challenging.

6.3. The evaluation approach and household profile

We adopted the same evaluation approach except for the fact that we adapted the qualitative tools (FGD Guidelines and Interview schedules, etc.) to include replication-focussed questions and translated the survey as well as all other tools to Hindi. The children FGD questions were changed to include Jharkhand focused questions and we also matched those with the state curriculum while retaining the competencies and difficult levels as similar to those used in Odisha. We ensured the presence of the knowledge of Hindi for the research team including enumerators. Since the analyses is based on fieldwork in only two panchayats in one block, this should be viewed as a dipstick, rather than a full-fledged assessment on the replicability potential of programme.

As a part of the evaluation, in addition to interviews and FGDs, 50 households from two panchayats i.e., Dudhbila and Kotgarh in Noamundi block were surveyed. Out of the 50 households surveyed, 60 per cent household belong to scheduled tribes, while 10 per cent and 30 per cent belong to scheduled caste and other backward caste groups respectively (Figure 6.1). Furthermore, 90 per cent of these households fall below the poverty line and 78 per cent households do not own more than one acre of land (Figures 6.2 & 6.3).

Figure 6. 1: Social group composition of surveyed households in Noamundi

Figure 6. 2: Status of surveyed Households based on ration card in Noamundi

¹⁶ Educationally backward districts identified by UGC in 2008 on the basis of Gross Enrolment Ratio (GRE) being less than national average. List of educationally backward districts
https://www.education.gov.in/sites/upload_files/mhrd/files/upload_document/EBDs_List.pdf

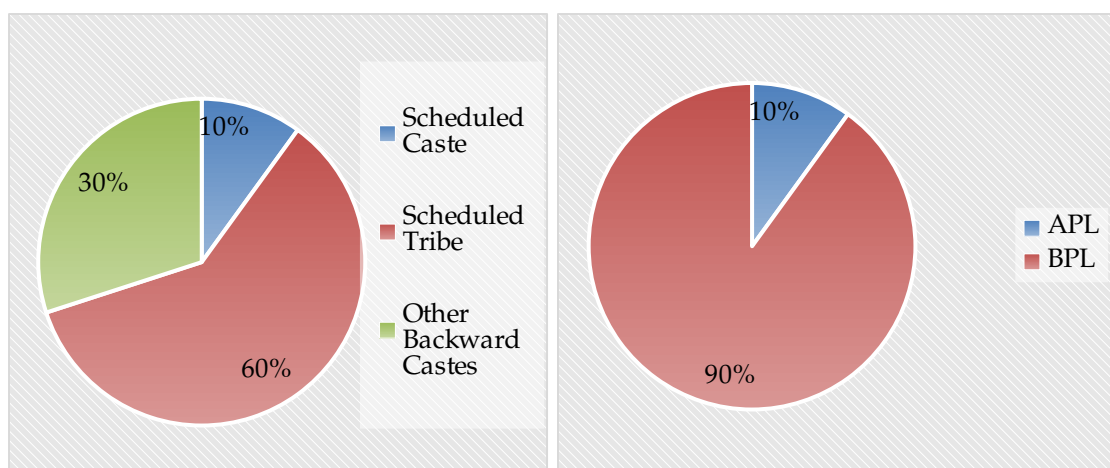
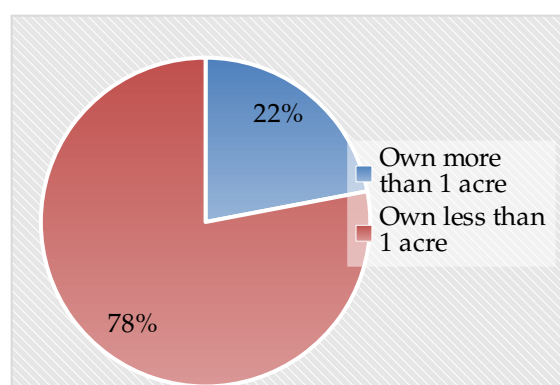


Figure 6.3: Status of surveyed Households based on ration card in Noamundi



Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

6.4. Impact on Access

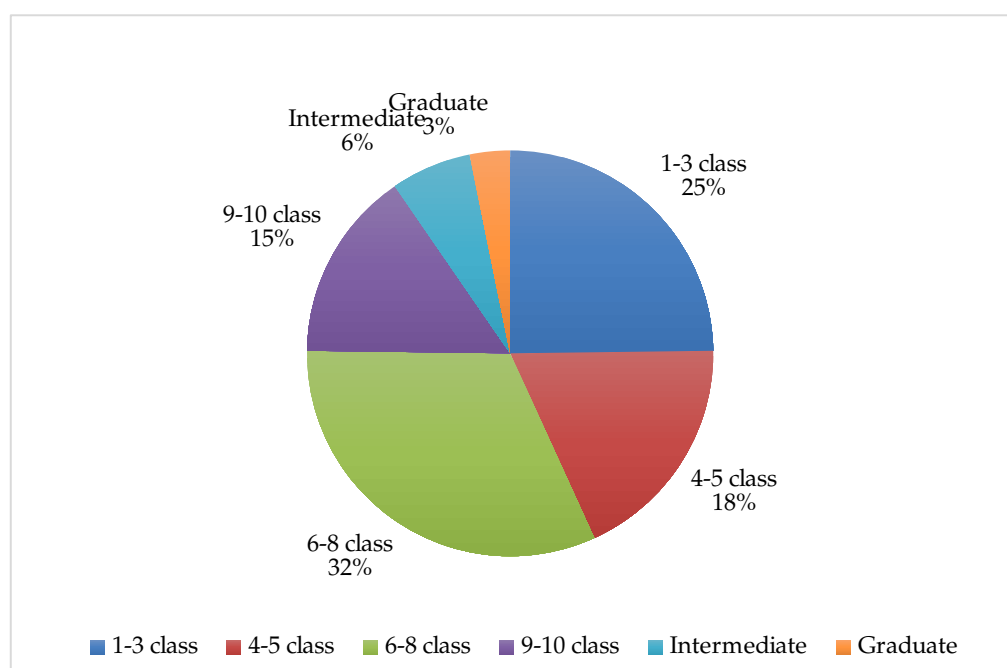
The 'Access' vertical of the ESP aims to ensure that every child is in school. The ESP's access-related interventions began from the initial household survey conducted to assess the situation of enrolment in the villages. According to GPCM of Kotgarh, initially, a targeted survey of two villages was conducted in the panchayat and NRBC centres were opened accordingly. In 2018 a full version of the village survey was conducted. The survey helped to identify the dropout and never enrolled children. About 155 dropout children were identified in Kotgarh panchayat alone.

To realise the objective, the ESP followed the same interventions done in Odisha i.e., mainstreaming through RBC and NRBC, direct enrolment, child tracking and preventing child labour¹⁷. We collected current status of enrolled and attending for all children in the age group of 6-18 years in the 50 households that we surveyed and found that all 122 children are enrolled in and attending schools. We also found that all others in the age group of 19-22 were attending higher secondary and undergraduate education. Out of the total children enrolled, more than 50 per cent have completed elementary education and are enrolled in upper primary, secondary, and higher studies (Fig. 6.4). This also indicates the successful transition of children of the age group 6-18 years to higher grades over time. This is

¹⁷ Follow the previous chapters on Access, Learning, and Governance for comprehensive analysis of the interventions.

also reflecting that the situation currently in this block is much better than what one sees for the West Singhbhum district in 2021-22 (Table 6.2).

Figure 6. 4: Classes in which children are currently enrolled



Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

We have already discussed the importance of the child's interest in studies and regular attendance in ensuring both schooling participation and learning. Similar to what we noticed in case of Odisha blocks, parents reported that their children enjoy the studies and attend school regularly (Table 6.3). Almost all parents, irrespective of whether their children had any direct contact with the education related interventions or not, felt that their children enjoy studies and the community-level interventions of the ESP could have played a role. However, direct contact with the ESP's education related interventions seemed to make a difference when it comes to changing aspirations: 84% parents whose children had experiences either RBC/NRBC/LEP shared that they now have a higher aspiration for their children, as against 74% parents with no contact with the ESP educational interventions saying so.

Table 6.34: Parent's feedback on children's attitude towards studies and schooling

Parameter / Responses	Child enjoys studies	Child attends school regularly
Always	48	47
Sometimes / mostly	2	3
Total	50	50

Table 6.35: Parent's feedback on school functioning

Question	Responses: number (%)		
	Yes, always	Yes, mostly	Total
School open on time	50 (100)	0 (0)	50 (100)

Teachers come to school regularly	49 (98)	1 (2)	50 (100)	
	Yes	No, less children go	Total	
More children continue to go to school these days	50 (100)	0 (0)	50 (100)	
	Yes	No teacher	Total	
Teachers practice corporal punishment	0 (0)	50 (100)	50 (100)	
	Yes, all	Yes, most teachers	Total	
Teachers teach well	49 (98)	1 (2)	50 (100)	
	Yes, positive	Yes, negative	Not sure	Total
Change in the way teachers teach	47 (94)	1 (2)	2 (4)	50 (100)

Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

One of the major reasons that hamper the children's access to school is the dysfunctionality of the school. The school timetable, school infrastructure and teachers' behaviour determine the child's interest towards schooling. Nearly all parents who were part of the survey in Noamundi had positive feedback on various indicators of the school functioning such as the school opening on time and teachers regularly coming to the school (table 6.4). Moreover, none of the households reported corporal punishment being practised in the school. They also reported that now more children are going to school continually. Furthermore, 94 per cent of the households stated that there has been a positive change in the case of child marriage and labour practices in their habitations.

However, in one of the parents' FGDs, parents complained that teachers do not teach in the class and that it is the regular LEP class that has improved the learning outcomes of their children. The ESP Block coordinator of Noamundi in our interview revealed that the shortage of teachers is the major problem in the Noamundi region. As per the data presented by him, there are about 23 schools in the Noamundi block which function with only one teacher.

6.4.1. ESP strategies for influencing access Residential Bridge Courses (RBC)

The opening of the RBC in the block seemed to have played a major role in ensuring the progress in enrolment and transition that is visible on the ground. From the FGD with children in the girls' RBC, we found that the bridging course has brought about a substantial change in their learning levels and aspirations. Most of the children who have Ho as their native language can now communicate in Hindi, the official medium of instruction in school. The RBC teachers have created a conducive atmosphere for learning the language by actively incorporating both languages in classroom activities. The teachers talk to children in Hindi and children respond in Ho. The RBC centre also has a Ho to Hindi dictionary for the use of children. Besides, the children also learn English and Mathematics. This has resulted in an improvement in sense of self-worth among children. One girl child in FGD stated that being able to answer mathematics questions correctly and able to understand

concepts well, gives them huge confidence. This obviously is going to have major favourable implications for their learning in future when get enrolled in a school.

From our discussions and observations at the RBC centre we found that the functioning of the RBC centre is similar to that of in Odisha. The RBC children are mainly out-of-school children who were in the labour market before getting admitted to RBC. Interviews with the RBC coordinator and RBC teacher suggest that the RBC administration follows the same holistic development approach, as the daily schedule includes time for classes, self-learning, sports, extracurricular activities and play activities. RBC staff are also very caring towards children; in one instance, we were told that the RBC teachers pooled money to buy dresses for children having very few clothes.

The official recognition of the RBC centres ensures that children here get other opportunities that are available for in-school children. For instance, one girl from the RBC centre visited and participated in the football tournaments conducted at the district level in Chaibasa and state level in Ranchi. More than anything else, it was clear from our conversations that RBC centres act as spaces to rekindle ambitions among children. Children in the RBC centre aspire to be teachers, doctors, police, and football players. One child also expressed her interest to become GPCM when she grows up indicating the impact of ESP in the lives of the children. During FGD children also repeatedly expressed their hope that education will lift them out of poverty and give them a better life.

Bal Adhikar Suraksha Samiti (BASS) and Kishori Groups

Child marriage and child labour are understood as the major factors causing dropout and therefore, the ESP takes various measures to prevent them. The intervention on this issue in Noamundi is mediated through BASS, similar to the functioning of CRPC/SASS in Odisha. From interviews and FGDs it was found that BASS has undertaken many successful interventions in cases of child protection and child rights. It also emerged that the role BASS members was critical in providing legal assistance to sexual abuse survivors in one case.

Further, the ESP (Education Signature Program) has also formed the Kishori group and all young girls are considered members of it. The girls in this group are given training on personal development, gender equality, and issues like good touch and bad touch, awareness about the ill effects of alcohol etc. To spread awareness among the people, the ESP organises many activities and celebrations like Bal Adhikar Divas, Yuva Divas, candle march from village to village against child labour and child marriage, etc. These interventions have led to a reduction in dropouts, cases of child labour and marriage in the panchayat, as shown by the household survey results. About 94 per cent of the surveyed household reported that there has been a positive change in the cases of child marriage and child labour in the community (Table 6.5).

Table 6.36: Households feedback on the status of child marriage and labour

Questions	Response	% of households
Have you noticed any difference in child marriage	Yes, positive change	47 (94.00)

in your village and panchayat in recent years?		
Have you noticed any difference in child labour in your village and panchayat in recent years?	Yes, positive change	47 (94.00)

Source: Household Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

Child tracking

The ESP has adopted similar tools of attendance tracking, house visits and maintenance of VER in Jharkhand as existing in Odisha. This also contributes in maintaining the retention and in preventing dropout. We verified the documents maintained by the ESP which showed that GPCM have been recruited and VER is maintained in both panchayats. Further, in our verification, we found that detailed information on children, headcounts at habitation level, retention and transition of children to higher grades, enrolment status and dropout details of the children, child-wise plan, PRI members, SMC members, AWC members and BASS members were available fully (ANNEXURE I).

GPCM at the panchayat level, LEP teachers, LF, CF at the cluster level and BASS members take part in the child tracking process. We also observed that GPCMs pay regular school visits, identify irregular students and also pay a visit to the houses of irregular students and convince them to go to school regularly. Furthermore, our field survey suggests that access to the school by each student is given individual attention by ASPIRE staffs instead of only relying on mass campaigns. This has indeed contributed in securing universal enrolment in these two GPs.

6.5. Impact on Learning

The ESP follow a similar approach of interventions that we have discussed for Odisha. The feedback from household survey showed that an overwhelming majority of parents (88%) felt that teachers' feedback for children learning has improved in the last few years. Similarly, a huge majority (92%) responded that their children were learning Hindi fully (reading, writing, and understanding) and 86 per cent informed that their children were learning mathematics well (Table 6.6).

Table 6.37: Learning outcomes of the children

Questions	Responses in number (%)			Total	
	Yes, fully	Yes, knows a few thing	No, does not understand the subject		
Child learning Hindi (reading, writing, understanding)	46 (92.00)	3 (6.00)	1 (2.00)	50 (100.00)	
Child learning mathematics well	43 (86.00)	6 (12.00)	1 (2.00)	50 (100.00)	
	Yes, positive	Yes, negative	No change	Do not know	Total
Change in the teachers' feedback on	44 (88.00)	4 (8.00)	1 (2.00)	1 (2.00)	50 (100.00)

your child					
	Yes, always	Yes, sometimes	No never	Do not know	Total
Your child handles things independently	34 (68.00)	8 (16.00)	5 (10.00)	3 (6.00)	50 (100.00)

Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

The same test on reading, comprehension and thinking was part of the survey here as well and similar patterns were visible in the results except for the fact that average performance was lower.¹⁸ Seventy six per cent of children could read fluently and 10 per cent could not read while the remaining could read with varying levels of difficulty (Table 6.7). For comprehension, 48 per cent could describe what they read fully, while 10 per cent could describe with difficulty, and 18 per cent could not describe. In case of taking a position, reflecting their abilities of critical thinking, and where ‘partially agreed’ was the most nuanced answer, only 16 per cent of children stated so, this being significantly lower than what we saw in Odisha. This lower progress in learning as compared to Odisha may be attributed to the late start of ESP and it is believed that the learning outcomes will catch up with the outcomes in Odisha in near future.

Table 6.38: Reading, comprehension, and critical thinking (Noamundi block, Jharkhand)

Block	Ability to read						
	Able to read fluently	Able to read with difficulty	Able to read some words/ letters only	Unable to read	Child too shy to do the test	Total	
Noamundi	38 (76)	3 (6)	3 (6)	5 (10)	1 (2)	50 (100)	
	Language comprehension of children						
	Able to describe fully	Able to describe with difficulty	Able to describe some bits only	Unable to describe	Child too shy to do the test	Unclear	Total
Noamundi	24 (48)	5 (10)	5 (10)	9 (18)	5 (10)	2 (4)	50 (100)
	Agreement and disagreement registered by the students						
	Fully agree	Partially agree	Do not agree /cannot decide	Unable to describe	Child too shy to do the test	Unclear	Total
Noamundi	17 (34)	8 (16)	0 (0)	10 (20)	13 (26)	2 (4)	50 (100)

Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

6.6. Lockdown learning programme (LLP)

The lockdown intervention under ESP involved both learning and non-learning activities. Lockdown learning classes were held every day from 2 pm and 5 pm. SMC

¹⁸ Follow chapter 4 “Learning” for detail description of the test and the analyses of results.

members and parents said that the LL programme of ESP was a huge contributor to children's learning since schools were closed during the lockdown, and teachers made no effort to children's learning other than sending online learning material. Most of the parents in our FGDs reported that the lack of digital devices had made online teaching highly ineffective. SMC members from Kotgarh in the interviews mentioned that ESP staff also provided pencils, notebooks, and books during the Covid-19 period. BASS members also pointed out that they distributed masks to prevent the spreading of coronavirus. It was obvious from our interactions that the LLP was perhaps the most important intervention at the time of Covid 19 and helped children continue their studies, and then also in preparing the community for the pandemic.

6.7. Impact on Governance

Like the interventions in Odisha, ASPIRE targeted the functioning of SMC and PTA in Noamundi. The involvement of PRI and other existing agencies at the grassroots level in the school functioning was also considered an important aspect of the intervention. The interventions have brought out many positive changes, even though many challenges continue to persist.

The two SMCs in the two sample GPs presented dissimilar status on their functioning. While the SMC meetings were taking place regularly in both the places, the members in one SMC (say A) were very clear about their roles and responsibilities, aware about the specific problems of their school and participative in solving those problems. The members of this SMC were elected after a general body meeting through a secret ballot. They also reported that the role of ESP was substantial in training of SMC members, the regular conduct of the SMC meeting, school-monitoring and maintaining the school development plan. SMC members also shared that the ESP staff trained them to place their demands at the panchayat office and motivated them to be part of house visits conducted by the ESP team.

The other SMC members (say, GP B) reported that they had not received any training either from the government or the ESP, and were unable to figure out their responsibilities as SMC members. They could not answer the question of whether SMC should have a role in school functioning. From the FGD with both SMC members and parents, it was also obvious that most of the SMC members were linked to the same family. The weak functioning of this SMC also gets reflected in the feedback from parents on the SMC functioning collected through the Household Survey. Although 62 per cent of the households stated that there has been a change in the functioning of SMC, SMC meetings, SMC composition and SMC election/selection, this percentage is much lower than that in Odisha (table 6.8).

Table 6.39: Changes in SMC functioning

Questions	Response	% of Household (Total=50)
Have you noticed any difference in the functioning of SMC at your child's school in recent years?	Yes	31 (62.00)
Have you noticed any difference in the SMC meetings at your	Yes	31 (62.00)

child's school in recent years?		
Have you noticed any difference in the SMC composition in recent years?	Yes	31 (62.00)
Have you noticed any difference in the SMC election/selection in recent years?	Yes	31 (62.00)

Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

The difference in the functioning of two schools and therefore also in the SMC/PTA functioning also emerged in the feedback received during the parents' FGDs despite the fact that regular parent-teacher meeting was conducted in both the GPs. The parents in GP B stated that there is no discipline in the school and the school environment is not good for children to learn. The HM does not monitor the children or even the MDM menu. There is always a shortage of food when the MDM is served. No school inspection happens. They also mentioned that they have written letters to government officials, but received no response. Even when the SMC resolution has been passed, no initiative was taken. Moreover, they complained that the teachers do not pay attention to children. It is only during the LEP class that children study. The classroom processes are also boring, no play-based education happens. They also said that their children only do LEP-based homework at home. What also emerged in the process was the parents were aware of the school's poor functioning while being fully committed to education of children, including girls. In addition to linking girls' education with an intergenerational effect, they also connected with her own freedom in terms of her own earnings and ability to manage finances better. The parents regularly interact with ESP team members and acknowledged their role in raising commitment towards education of their children. The poor school and SMC functioning could be a specific problem in this particular village/SMC but it indeed presents a challenge to the ESP team on the ground.

Table 6.40: Parents' feedback on the functioning of PRI

Questions	Response	% of household (Total=50)
Have you noticed any difference in the functioning of the gram panchayat in recent years?	Yes, positive change	44 (88)
Have you noticed any difference in the gram sabha in recent years?	Yes, positive change	45 (90)
Have you noticed any difference in the gram panchayat elections-like reasons behind electing a particular gram panchayat mukhiya in recent years?	Yes, positive change	44 (88)
Have you noticed any difference in engagement with education that the gram panchayat has in recent years?	Yes, positive change	40 (80)
Have you noticed any difference in child marriage in your village and panchayat in recent years?	Yes, positive change	47 (94)
Have you noticed any difference in child labour in your village and panchayat in recent years?	Yes, positive change	47 (94)

Source: Survey data collected by CBPS in Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

The households feedback on the GP functioning was much better in comparison of the SMC. Nearly 90 per cent of respondents in the household survey stated that there has been a positive change in the functioning of the panchayat, gram sabha and gram

panchayat election. Moreover, 80 per cent of respondents felt that the engagement of panchayat with education has increased in recent years (Table 6.9). Since PRI members were elected recently, no standing committee on education has been formed in their panchayats. Moreover, in absence of training the members were found to be unaware of RTE Act, when interviewed. However, they mentioned ensuring every child is in school and no dropout in the panchayat as their responsibilities towards children's education. They also stated that they pay a visit to schools to check whether teachers are teaching in the school. Further, they informed us that they are involved in awareness-spreading activities in the panchayat. Besides, they were aware of the ESP interventions in their panchayats. They stated that the ESP organises tuition class for the children and reduce the dropout in the panchayats. However, one of the interviewed PRI members was not aware of VER.

6.8. ESP and government education offices

Based on the interviews conducted with the government officials, it appears that the ESP's relationship with them is active and of mutual dependence. The previous success stories from Odisha helped in building credibility and helped ESP staff in Noamundi to gain greater acceptance early in the project. The ESP block coordinator in Noamundi informed in the interview that, during the initiation of ESP, the learning outcomes of the children from the TSP-intervened blocks in Odisha were presented in the form of a PPT to government officials in Jharkhand to build trust. Resultantly, a cooperative relationship has been built between the ESP staff and government officials. The BEO in the interview mentioned that now they cross-verify government data with the ESP data for discrepancies so that an effective change is brought in the education sector in the project areas.

6.9. ESP and Manki Munda system

The Ho tribe of Noamundi practices the Munda system of governance¹⁹. The ESP in Noamundi incorporates Munda as an important stakeholder. They consulted Mundas during the initiation of the programme to gain community support. Further, the ESP included them for a field visit to Harichandanpur to orient them about the programme. The ESP also gains assistance from them on various issues. For example, it needs their assistance and support in bringing orphan children from Maoist-affected areas to RBCs and school. To strengthen the relationship with them and government officials and other community organisations, the ESP conducts regular meetings with them, and this came across clearly in our interactions where Mundas were also part of the SMC or parents FGDs.

6.10. Conclusion

The key from the ESP programme is that the TSP model successfully implemented in Odisha was largely able to be replicated in the same structure in Jharkhand too. The fundamental principles of large-scale intervention, community-

¹⁹ The head of the village is Munda and the head of the an inter-village panchayat is headed by 'Manki'. Munda of all villages participates in the interstate panchayat.

centric practices and local hiring have helped in all three verticals of intervention that is access, learning and governance. It is to be noted that the socio-economic condition of the surveyed blocks in Jharkhand and Odisha looks same. This aspect has also contributed in making the TSP model successful in Noamundi also.

One key factor promoting replicability is the anchoring of activities at the block level. block coordinator has the key role in planning and assessing the programme based on the situation and the block coordinator has the flexibility to prioritise and plan at the block level i.e., planning has a bottom-up approach. Anchoring of activities at the block level has facilitated the integration of local differences into the fold of the TSP/ESP intervention. The integration of the Munda Manki system in Noamundi is an example of programme flexibility and the ability to adapt.

Chapter 7: Conclusions and Way Forward

This chapter answers some of the evaluation questions linked to relevance, effectiveness, impact and sustainability using the analyses of the findings discussed so far. The chapter first answers these questions and also presents suggestions for the next phase of operation. The next section separately presents a way forward based on those inferences and the discussions presented earlier.

7.1. Relevance

1. To what extent are the objectives of the Programme (set in 2015) valid today and worth working towards?

The objectives of the programme continue to remain valid and worth working towards. Several reasons guide this response. While the TSP has attained or moved towards attaining several of its objectives, there is a need for deepening these interventions in order to both move towards achieving all the objectives fully and also sustain these gains in the long run. For instance, while there is enough evidence to show that there has been a considerable movement towards building community awareness and ownership of the school (Chapter 5), leading to transparency and better accountability and management of schools, there is need for more work, as new members join the main governance bodies such as SMCs and GPs every four to five years, and they need to be engaged with and trained afresh. The period of six to seven years that the TSP has been operational in these areas, is not enough to create a pool of trained and aware individuals who would in turn will ensure that bodies such as SMC or GP remain committed to community ownership of schools, irrespective of change in the membership. The prevalent low-literacy levels and livelihood constraints make it further challenging.

Similarly, while there has been a definite shift towards universal access and visible gains in children's learning levels (Chapter 2 and Chapter 3), at present it is highly dependent on the presence and active involvement of the TSP team with the community, SMC, PRIs and the community at large. The need for institutions such as RBCs and NRBCs continues, especially in the post-Covid19 phase, because of the socio-economic stress that continue to exist for the families in these areas. While efforts are underway to make the community and local governing bodies take ownership of these initiatives through trainings and other capacity building initiatives, in our opinion, the presence of a facilitating agency is still needed both from execution and financial support perspective.

The LEP and other related interventions including LLP have played a major role in improving the learning levels of children but there is still a long way to go in making these learners into 'independent and self-directed learners (See Chapter 3).' These are transformational shifts that call for longer and close engagement at various levels. While the TSP has successfully engaged with teachers at local level in sensitizing them to adopt 'innovative and child friendly teaching learning practices and classroom organisation', another programme objective, the stage is ready for a concerted strategy that needs to be developed to deepen their understanding of

transformative pedagogy, and even more so, for institutionalizing this through CRCs, BRCs and DIETs in the system. These aspects need to be strengthened in future.

The strengthening of the advocacy efforts for integrating transformative changes in the system including the acknowledgement of the need for a mediating programme such as TSP on the ground, is important for both sustainability and replicability. The TSP has already moved to other geographies successfully but in the long run, the TSP needs to develop an exit strategy based on institutionalisation of the change mechanisms and processes, which was not visible to us. For instance, while the long term objective of the program is to institutionalize the pedagogic practices within the government schools, we found that the change in government school teachers teaching practices is not significant barring adoption of teaching learning materials. Most of the government school teachers we spoke to acknowledged that they are helped in preparation of TLMs by ASPIRE personnel and that they find it difficult to adopt play based teaching methods because of the workload. Similarly, while SMCs and PRI members are trained on their rights and responsibilities, there is still a long way for them to take ownership of these initiatives. Hence, there is a need for reinforcement of the efforts for ensuring sustainability.

2. To what extent are the strategy, activities and outputs of the Programme consistent with the overall goal and the attainment of its objectives?

The programme strategies, activities and achievements are completely in line with the overall objectives of the programme. The strategies are also in tandem with each other, which has led to the notable achievements in access, learning and governance (Chapter 2, 3 and 5). However, there is a need for a restrategising some of the interventions to deepen the impact of the programme, especially in the light of sustainability of the gains. This is not to say that the strategies are not in line, but to stress that the need for shifts in strategies arise from the very successes that the programme has already achieved. The report discusses the directions of these shifts in various chapters (Chapter 2,3 and 5) and are not being reiterated here for the sake of brevity.

3. To what extent was the work done during the lockdown, with the inclusion of the lockdown learning model, consistent with the attainment of the Programme's objectives?

The inclusion of LLP in the programme has been completely consistent with the programme's objectives. This helped in retaining the gains made in all major objectives: access, learning and governance till then and prevented the learning loss, commonly seen among children coming from marginalized groups in many other parts of the country, to take roots (Chapter 4).

7.2. Effectiveness

1. To what extent was the management of the Programme, including the roles played by ASPIRE and TSF and the coordination between them, a factor in the Programme achieving (or not) its stated goal and objectives?

We did not explore this issue fully due to time and resource constraints and hence can respond to this only partially, and mainly pertaining to the management of the programme at the ground level. The practice of local hiring through local advertisements followed by a rigorous process of written tests, group discussions and interviews has helped the TSP establish a credible system of recruitment. Once recruited, the staff get at least 4-5 days of initial training followed by on-the-job learning through shadowing of experienced colleagues. Commitment to the cause and deep engagement with the children visible among most employees. Local hiring is a great advantage as it helps build connection with the community and children faster. In addition to other advantages such as managing difficulties of language and the cost of living for the personnel.

Career progression also exists as mostly LEP teachers and GPCMs are promoted to higher levels within the organisation (LFs, CFs, LEP coordinators, Block coordinators, etc.), which also acts as a motivator. Many employees have continued their own higher education while employed and they acknowledge the support provided by ASPIRE senior management and leadership in this process.

We also noticed a few challenges that the TSP may like to address. The remuneration remains low by all account, and this was raised by many of them while interacting with us. Many of them spoke about the high work related travel costs in view of the rising fuel expenses and that after accounting for fuel cost, they struggle to meet the expenses of the family. In addition, high workload and multiplicity of work related expectations, at times causes stress. Sporadic cases of strife with community was also reported and this points towards the need for some safety mechanisms and protocols so that immediate action can be taken in case of an adverse incident. Since they deal with sensitive issues such as prevention of child marriages and child labour, especially when they are new to a place, they sometimes feel threatened. While many of them acknowledged the help they receive from their seniors and colleagues in case of any such incident, they felt that having some formal mechanisms would help.

In general, there is a democratic culture where staff at all levels have a formal channel in the form of periodic meetings where they can share their feedbacks and experiences. However, their actions are largely determined by the plans that they receive from their state teams, this being especially true for the learning vertical. While the remaining activities related to governance structures and processes, RBCs and related interventions have greater flexibility to adapt, the LEP plans appeared to be less flexible. This could be due to the 'technicalness' of the learning interventions, where language and mathematics activities are planned based on feedback received, and the time constraint within which the LEP classes are conducted. Nevertheless, there is a need to rethink this strategy, where the guiding principles and activity

framework could be shared with the implementing team with the flexibility to adapt within the given framework, and considering the emergent needs of participating children.

Although ASPIRE is the implementing agency, TSF also plays a very active role, especially in the learning vertical. The state team that develops detailed activity plans for the LEP as well as other related interventions receives continuous guidance from the TSF team. The TSF representation is also sought for recruitments at various levels. As per our understanding, there is active coordination between the TSF and ASPIRE teams at all levels; however, our understanding may be limited in this regard.

2. How effectively is the Programme being monitored for results? Does the monitoring framework inform key stakeholders of progress towards the Programme's objectives?

The programme has developed detailed and effective monitoring strategies which are based on period monitoring and strong feedback loops for all interventions as well as to understand the progression towards the objectives. For instance, the Village Education Registers (VER) is maintained to track every child's enrolment and retention details, and the record-keeping has improved over the years with introduction of digitisation. Similarly, the practices of baseline and endline learning surveys for RBCs and LEPs are well-established.

For programme monitoring, the system of numerous periodic meetings with diverse stakeholders are in place, and have contributed towards achieving the programme objectives. The initiatives such as an internal evaluation of LLP leading to a published paper is also reflective of the presence of a strong monitoring mechanism.

3. To what extent does the Programme contribute towards achievement of SDG 4?

SDG4 focuses on education and aims to "ensure inclusive and equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all." The TSP is directly contributing towards strengthening the public school system to make them 'inclusive and equitable quality education'. All the strategies are directed towards this goal.

The programme is also working towards building greater accountability towards key stakeholders, and the stakeholders are being continuously oriented and trained through a variety of mechanisms including hand holding, and this can be viewed as an example of promoting lifelong learning.

4. To what extent is the Programme known within the education sector in India and recognised for its achievements? What has the Programme done to communicate its achievements to external stakeholders, and how successfully has it done this?

The TSP since its inception has worked closely with the M V Foundation, and as mentioned earlier, the influence of the MVF programming is clear in many respects,

especially in the context of universal access, removal of child labour and child marriage, and creating local accountability. Some of the key personnel in the TSP have earlier worked with the MVF, and that experience has helped the programme in its implementation. The senior management interviews also suggested that the programme design has used learning from several experiments that existed then. The learning related interventions have also seemed to have learnt from existing experiments that has tried to promoted play-based pedagogy using constructive frameworks

In recent years, the TSP has established contacts with a number of universities to be able to strengthen the element of research. This is indeed a good initiative and would help in getting the programme better known. The programme appears to be well-known in certain circles, as it also hosts internships to university students. However, our own enquiries with certain education networks suggested that there is a lot of scope for improving networking and mutual learning with a large number of grassroots organisations that are also operating in similar space.

However, it is important to add here that we have not explored this question fully and hence our response perhaps answers this question only partially.

There is also ample scope for documenting the successes and failures of the programme more diligently and using a framework that can contribute in theorizing and knowledge production, which can then help in connecting with the outer world. This, however, calls for involvement of either an external agency or in-depth training of the local staff.

7.3. Impact

1. Are the impact numbers generated by the Programme management accurate?

Our evaluation did not undertake a detailed large sample based verification of programme data. However, we verified the presence of VERs as well as certain random data points mentioned within the VERs in the GPs where we conducted our fieldwork. On that basis and because the scope of our study did not include validation of the impact numbers already generated, we can say that the number generated through programme were accurate in our sample sites. .

We also analysed certain programme data, such as LEP learning achievement data being generated from baseline, midline and endline. The trends that emerge from that data set largely match with the trends emerging from our own survey and hence, that also points towards the programme data being accurate.

2. To what extent can the identified changes be attributable to the Programme?

This was a one-time evaluation and hence it is not possible to establish causality through quantitative analysis of change, directly attributable to the programme. The evaluation was also limited to only the programme areas due to a paucity of time, and hence the comparison with non-programme area too has not been undertaken,

which would have allowed us to see whether the changes that have been observed or reported in these areas are similar or dissimilar to other areas.

However, we have tried to establish attribution through triangulation of data collected through diverse means: household survey, interviews of key stakeholders from government, community, local government and the TSP staff, and focus group discussions with children, parents and school management committee members. Through that analysis, we can say that a number of changes, especially in the area of access and learning can be attributed to the programme.

The accuracy of the attribution can be strengthened if a comparative approach is adopted in future evaluations with requisite time available for the evaluation, and by building-in the evaluation component right since beginning in the new geographies.

3. What are the intended and unintended, positive and negative, direct or indirect, counterfactual effects of the Programme on people and institutions?

We did not observe any negative impact of the programme in our evaluation. We have not carried out the counterfactual analysis either.

One indirect positive impact that was reported to use was how the focus on enhanced accountability to local bodies have empowered them to question gaps in other schemes and entitlements such as Mahatma Gandhi National Employment Scheme Act (MGNREGA). We did not explore this aspect fully and hence have not reported in detail.

4. How do the children, parents, and community see the impact themselves and how do they describe the changes?

The children, parents and community view the impact of the programme in a very positive light and our analysis in various chapters discusses that in detail.

5. Are there any best practices from the Programme that can inform the education sector in India?

The programme reinforces the need for a holistic or ecological approach, where multiple interventions covering all aspects of school functioning and teaching, as well as that of the child's lives are given attention to, for bringing a change in moving towards universal access and learning goals.

This becomes important to put forward this view and back it by evidence, especially in view of the ongoing debates on learning deficits where short-term, teaching oriented solutions are put forth to address deep gaps that occur for a variety of reasons and hence cannot be addressed just in the classroom.

However, towards that direction, the programme would need to create in-depth evidence building exercises using the rich data it already has and combining it with new evidence deliberately worked towards to fill the gap in existing data.

7.4. Sustainability

1. To what extent are the benefits of the Programme likely to continue after its closure?

The benefits of the programme has been ensured largely because of the mediation of an external agency through its team of mobilisers, teachers and coordinators, who have handheld local institutions and created processes that ensure greater and more-informed action at diverse platforms.

In the absence of the programme, which would also mean absence of the mediation, the benefits will continue only if the processes are self-sustained and a deep culture is built that changes the entire ethos of indifference to that of deep commitment for all key stakeholders such as teachers, SMC, PRI, communities, parents, etc. In our assessment, the programme is not yet reached there; it needs to build an explicit strategy for consolidation and institutionalisation of culture and processes, which would allow the gains to be sustained in the long run.

The scale of the programme, which is sufficiently large, lends itself to converting into a sustainable model if the principles and processes are consolidated and a clearly developed plan for advocacy and capacity-building is carried out to ensure that these take roots and not stopped in the absence of the programme. Given that public systems are largely driven by policies and practices coming from above, the risk of fall-back is serious in absence of a 'mediator' unless mechanisms are in place and the culture is deep-rooted.

2. What were the major factors that influenced/would influence the achievement or non-achievement of sustainability of the Programme?

The factors that are likely to positively influence the sustainability of the ongoing programme are the following:

- a. Focus on community institutions: The TSP has worked closely with the institutions like SMC and panchayat, and even though the members keep changing, they all come from the community. This will contribute in making the programme sustainable.
- b. Focus on public system of education: The TSP has worked with local schools and although though the institutions such as RBC and NRBCs have contributed to its achievements, the focus has been on school, and that would also help in sustainability.
- c. Responsiveness at the local level – decentralised action: The programme has promoted a culture of decentralised action in some areas using its own staff but at the level of community bodies such as CRPF, SMC and GP; this is contributing towards building a culture of independent action.
- d. Local hiring: the staff coming from the local areas will remain a part of the community even after the programme ceases to exist and that could also help.

However, none of these would help in absence of a concerted effort towards consolidating and institutionalising the changes, which is yet to happen. We focus on that in the following section on the way forward.

7.5. The Way Forward

The report discusses a few suggestions in relation to strategies at various places. Here, we reiterate the main suggestions as way forward for the programme to consider, especially in view of working towards deepening certain interventions, consolidation of the gains and sustainability of the changes. The suggestions are based on our assessment of the readiness for the introduction of these shifts. The rationale for these suggestions come from the analysis in the report, and are not being repeated here.

1. Deepening learning interventions: These have been successfully implemented and the report acknowledges amply that using evidence from diverse sources. However, the need for and potential exist for deepening these in several respects:
 - a. Sharing of and training on the framework and principles of the LEP activities with the LEP team of teachers, facilitators and trainers to equip them to act independently in the classes. This was perhaps not possible earlier when the teachers were new but now when a substantial percentage of the team has experience of several years, they are perhaps ready to take this responsibility. This will make the LEP classes more responsive to diverse needs of children, and also make it more sustainable in the long run.
 - b. Building in the goal of gender-attitudes within the LEP activities through both content and pedagogy. This can be done by carrying out a gender review of the content and pedagogy in operation and making shifts wherever there is potential.
 - c. Greater emphasis on comprehension and critical thinking. It is common for children to be able to read but not necessarily fully comprehend or be able to critically reflect on those. Children we interacted with, especially those with some LEP or RBC experience, perhaps fared better than what is usually seen across the rural areas in public schools. However, this also means there is a potential for integrating these into the approach by adding a few discursive individual or group activities.
2. Deepening the work with school-teachers and trainers on critical pedagogy: While the school-teachers have been supportive and received some orientation /training, for the sake of sustainability, the TSP would need to strengthen its interventions regarding teacher capacity building taking the government institutions such as BRC and DIETS on board. Most teachers think that syllabus-based teaching cannot be fully delivered through the activity-based experiences, and without addressing this issue, it would be not be possible to expect a deeper adoption of child-centered pedagogy in the regular classroom. The capacity building plan can cover all six blocks and be a combination of

training through hybrid modes and hand holding using their own experiences of LEP and LLP training.

3. Strategising for the institutionalization of certain key processes / mechanisms for attaining change: The TSP is at a stage where through a reflective and consultative process, it can formulate a strategy for institutionalisation of key processes and mechanisms, and then advocate for those with the state government. This plan can identify the non-negotiable elements required for sustaining the gains of the programme, and also for its replication elsewhere. For instance, mobilisation has been a key feature of the access and governance verticals of the TSP programme. The mobilisation depends on the presence of the mobiliser and the support that they receive from others in the team. This points towards the essential role of a mediator, i.e., mobiliser in this context, for realising the aspired role of SMC or GP or the community in absence of a fully literate, aware and empowered community. The institutionalisation-plan of the TSP can identify this as a non-negotiable element. This is just one example; the strategy can have several such elements back by the rationale and evidence for the same.
4. Knowledge building, dissemination and advocacy: Although ASPIRE/TSF has taken a few initiatives towards this direction, it would help to have a detailed strategy for documentation, knowledge building, dissemination and advocacy with diverse audience and aimed at institutionalisation of the gains. Diverse audience can play a role in opinion-building towards desired shifts in the public systems and service delivery.

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ANNEXURE I: TSP VER Verification Results

Table A. 1: Detail information Headcounts at Habitation level in VER (Odisha)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	9 (90)	9 (90)	9 (90)	9 (90)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)
Not available	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete information	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Total	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)

Table A. 2: Detail information Retention and transition of students to higher grades in VER (Odisha)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	6 (60)	7 (70)	9 (90)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)
Not available	4 (40)	3 (30)	1 (10)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete information	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Total	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)

Table A. 3: Detail information Enrolment status of child and the reason for school dropout and causes of migration of children to other areas in VER (Odisha)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	8 (80)	9 (90)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)
Not available	2 (20)	1 (10)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete information	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Total	10 (100.00)	10 (100.00)	10 (100.00)	10 (100.00)	10 (100.00)	10 (100.00)	10 (100.00)	10 (100.00)

Table A. 4: Detail information on PRI members in Register (Odisha)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	5 (50)	6 (60)	10 (100)	9 (90)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)
Not available	4 (40)	3 (30)	0 (0)	1 (10)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete information	1 (10)	1 (10)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Total	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)

Table A. 5: Detail information on SMC members in Register (Odisha)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	6 (60)	7 (70)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)
Not available	4 (40)	3 (30)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete information	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Total	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)

Table A. 6: Detail information on CRPF members in Register (Odisha)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	4 (40)	4 (40)	7 (70)	7 (70)	9 (90)	9 (90)	9 (90)	9 (90)
Not available	5 (50)	5 (50)	2 (20)	2 (20)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete information	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)
Total	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)

Table A. 7: Detail information on Anganwadi workers in Register (Odisha)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	6 (60)	7 (70)	8 (80)	8 (80)	8 (80)	8 (80)	8 (80)	8 (80)
Not available	3 (30)	2 (20)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)
Incomplete information	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)	1 (10)
Total	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)	10 (100)

ANNEXURE II: VER verification (Noamundi, Jharkhand)

Table A. 8: Detail information on children in VER (Noamundi)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)
Not available	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete information	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Total	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)

Table A. 9: Detail information Headcounts at Habitation level in VER (Noamundi)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)
Not available	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete information	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Total	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)

Table A. 10: Detail information Retention and transition of students to higher grades in VER (Noamundi)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)
Not available	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete information	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Total	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)

Table A. 11: Detail information Enrolment status of child and the reason for school dropout and causes of migration of children to other areas in VER (Noamundi)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)

Not available	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete information	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Total	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)

Table A. 12: Detail information Child wise plan (dropouts and never enrolled students) in VER (Noamundi)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)
Not available	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete information	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Total	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)

Table A. 13: Detail information on PRI members in Register (Noamundi)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	1 (50)	1 (50)	2 (100.00)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)
Not available	1 (50)	1 (50)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete information	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Total	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)

Table A. 14: Detail information on SMC members in Register (Noamundi)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	0 (0)	0 (0)	1 (50)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)
Not available	2 (100)	2 (100)	1 (50)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete information	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Total	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)

Table A. 15: Detail information on CRPF members in Register (Noamundi)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	0 (0)	0 (0)	1 (50)	1 (50)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)
Not available	2 (100)	2 (100)	1 (50)	1 (50)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete information	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Total	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)

Table A. 16: Detail information on Anganwadi workers in Register (Noamundi)

Information status	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Available	1 (50)	1 (50)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)
Not available	1 (50)	1 (50)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Incomplete information	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
Total	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)	2 (100)

Annexure III

Sample blocks and panchayats

Block	Panchayat
Koida	Malda
	Kashira
Joda	Birikalan
	Deojhar
Harichandanpur	Bareiguda
	Budhakhaman
Sukinda	Gobarghati
	Hatibari
Danagadi	Ollala
	Salijanga
Noamundi	Dudhbila
	Kotgarh

Annexure IV

Socio-economic characteristics of sample (Block wise)

1. Relative presence of social groups

Block	SC	ST	OBC	Refused to say	Total
Koira	5	35	10		50
Harichandanpur	0	41	9		50
Joda	3	37	10		50
Danagadi	45	3	1	1	50
Sukinda	15	18	17		50
Noamundi	5	30	15		50

2. Household status based on ration card

Block	APL	BPL	don't know	Total
Koira	1	45	4	50
Harichandanpur	2	46	2	50
Joda	2	48	0	50
Danagadi	7	43	0	50
Sukinda	5	44	1	50
Noamundi	5	45	0	50

3. Type of house

Block	Kutchha	Pucca	Semi-pucca	Total
Koira	39	5	6	50
Harichandanpur	38	4	8	50
Joda	27	15	8	50
Danagadi	32	13	5	50
Sukinda	14	18	18	50
Noamundi	44	1	5	50